

THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

A SPECIALLY COMMISSIONED REPORT

TRADE SECRETS OF USING E-LEARNING IN TRAINING

HOW BEST TO PLAN, DESIGN AND IMPLEMENT E-LEARNING TRAINING PROGRAMMES

Tony Bray

THOROGOOD

IFC



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

A SPECIALLY COMMISSIONED REPORT

TRADE SECRETS OF USING E-LEARNING IN TRAINING

HOW BEST TO PLAN, DESIGN AND IMPLEMENT E-LEARNING TRAINING PROGRAMMES

Tony Bray

THOROGOOD

Other Thorogood Professional Insights

Applying the Employment Act 2002 – Crucial Developments for Employers and Employees

Audrey Williams

A Practical Guide to Knowledge Management

Sue Brelade and Christopher Harman

HR Business Partners and HR Outsourcing

Ian Hunter and Jane Saunders

Dismissal and Grievance Procedures

Dennis Hunt

Flexible Working

Audrey Williams

Email – Legal Issues

Susan Singleton

Employee Sickness and Fitness for Work

Gillian Howard

Successfully Defending Employment Tribunal Cases

Dennis Hunt

Special discounts for bulk quantities of Thorogood books are available to corporations, institutions, associations and other organisations. For more information contact Thorogood by telephone on 020 7749 4748, by fax on 020 7729 6110, or email us: info@thorogood.ws

Published in 2005

Thorogood Publishing Ltd
10-12 Rivington Street
London EC2A 3DU.

t: 020 7749 4748
f: 020 7729 6110
e: info@thorogood.ws
w: www.thorogood.ws

© Tony Bray 2005

All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic, photocopying, recording or otherwise, without the prior permission of the publisher.

This Report is sold subject to the condition that it shall not, by way of trade or otherwise, be lent, re-sold, hired out or otherwise circulated without the publisher's prior consent in any form of binding or cover other than in which it is published and without a similar condition including this condition being imposed upon the subsequent purchaser.

No responsibility for loss occasioned to any person acting or refraining from action as a result of any material in this publication can be accepted by the author or publisher.

A CIP catalogue record for this Report is available from the British Library.

ISBN 1 85418 326 5

Printed in Great Britain by printflow.com

Contents

INTRODUCTION 1

Delivering Competitive Advantage 1
How Does it Work? 2
Where Are You? 2
How Can We Take Part? 3
A Practical Example 4

1 MANAGING AN E-LEARNING PROJECT 7

1. Define the Scope of the Training 8
2. Link Outcomes to Business Objectives 9
3. Carry Out Training Needs Analysis 9
4. Identify Key Players 10
   Who to Choose? 11
5. Allocate Topics to E-learning and the Trainer-led Course 13
6. Learning System Database 14
7. Establish Milestones and Budgets 15

2 ACCESSIBILITY 17

1. Why this is Important 18
2. Physical Accessibility 22
3. Dyslexia 23
4. Hearing Difficulties 23
5. Visual Impairment 23
6. Other Sources of Advice 24
7. Be Positive about Accessibility 26

3 THE SOFTWARE SUPPLIER 27

1. Select and Brief a Software Supplier....28
2. Establish the Project Team....29
3. Communicate Your Needs....30
4. Finalize the Storyboard Format....33

4 THE E-LEARNING SYSTEM 37

1. Strengths and Limitations of the Electronic Learning System....38
2. Agree the Screen Layout and Navigation Buttons....38
3. Explore Options for On-screen Tasks, Questions and Activities....40
4. Finalize How Learners will Access the E-learning System....41
5. Discuss How the System will Track Individual's Progress....41
6. Decide What Information to Collect about Learning System Usage....42
7. Sell E-learning into the Business....43

5 E-LEARNING COURSE CONTENT 47

1. Define Learning Objectives....48
2. Design the Overall Course Content....48
3. Identify Company Materials or Procedures Which Must be Used for Consistency....49
4. Harmonize the Content with Other Company Materials, Procedures or Products....51
5. Research Sources for Course Content....51
6. Clarify Expectations about Sourcing Materials....52

6 DELEGATE WORKBOOKS 53

1. Consider the Need for a Delegate Workbook 54
2. Discuss the Scope and Coverage of the Workbook....55
3. Consistency with the On-screen Image 57
4. Clarify the Format and Style of the Workbook 58
5. How Will Learners Access the Workbook? 61

7 DELEGATE ASSESSMENT 63

1. When to Use Quizzes....64
2. Are there 'Right' Answers? 65
3. Detailed Design 67
4. Who Will See the Results? 72

8 DESIGN THE COURSE 75

1. Confirm the Overall Course Structure 76
2. Build Each Screen Using Text and Images 79
3. Maximize the Learner's Participation....83
4. Link to the Learner's Workbook 87

9 PROJECT REVIEW MEETINGS 89

1. When to Hold Project Review Meetings 90
2. Review the E-learning Course Content....91
3. Hand Over the Storyboards to the Software Designers 93
4. Pilot the E-learning Course 93
5. Review the Trainer-led Course Design....94
6. Pilot the Trainer-led Course....95
7. Review the Effectiveness of the Whole Program....96

10 BUILDING THE STORYBOARDS 99

1. Why have Storyboards? 100
2. How to Build the Storyboards....103
3. In Summary… 108

11 THE TRAINER-LED COURSE 109

1. Establish the Project Team....110
2. Some Challenges 110
3. Identify the Key Skills to be Practised 112
4. Agree the Duration of the Course 113
5. The Optimum Number of Delegates....113
6. Agree the Key Milestones in Terms of Dates and Deliverables....114
7. Finalize the Budget 114

12 LINKS TO THE E-LEARNING COURSE 115

1. Linking the Two Learning Experiences....116
2. Using a Refresher Quiz 116

13 DESIGN THE TRAINER-LED COURSE 121

1. Develop an Overall Template for the Day 122
2. Design Individual Sessions in Detail 123
3. Design the Delegate Workbook 125
4. Write a Trainer's Guide 125
5. Create Supporting Materials....127
6. Draft a Venue Specification 127

14 PILOT THE TRAINER-LED COURSE 129

1. Select and Train the Trainers 130
2. Select the Venue 132
3. Collect Nominations for the Pilot Course 132
4. Issue Course Joining Instructions 133
5. Deliver the Pilot Course 135
6. Review and Modify the Course Design 135

15 APPLYING THE LEARNING 137

1. Assess Learners' Improved Skills and Effectiveness 138
2. Offer Coaching to Reinforce Learning 139
3. Evaluate the Effectiveness of the Training Program 140
4. Enhance Course Content to Offer Improved Skills 141
5. Release and Publicize the Program 142
6. Delivering Competitive Advantage 142

APPENDICES 145

Resource 1: Project Specification 146
Resource 2: Course Overview 152
Resource 3: Sample Learner's Workbook to Accompany the On-line Managing Meetings Course 155
Resource 4: Sample Opening Quiz 168
Resource 5: Sample Closing Quiz 179
Resource 6: Course Flowchart 190
Resource 7: Sample Screens 191
Resource 8: Learning Options 206
Resource 9: Project Status Report 207
Resource 10: Sample Storyboards 209
Resource 11: Refresher Quiz 215
Resource 12: Sample Course Outline 222
Resource 13: Sample Trainer's Guide 226

Blank

Introduction

Do you want to plan, design or implement a training program involving electronic learning? If the answer is 'Yes' then read this report. It will save you time, effort, money… or all three!

Most companies recognize the need for their staff to be constantly increasing their skills to stay ahead in today's frantic marketplace. Customer expectations are steadily increasing, with the resulting pressure on training budgets to achieve 'more for less' – greater skill levels for less cost.

For years people have been experimenting with computers as a training tool. Earlier trials with computer-based training and interactive video discs showed the potential of the medium – but the technology wasn't sophisticated enough. That's now changed – modern computers and their associated networks, coupled with intranets and the internet, mean that e-learning can now take its place as a serious contender in the training armory.

Delivering Competitive Advantage

E-learning has many benefits which can directly improve the competitive advantage of your company:

- It allows staff to acquire new skills when they need them, instead of waiting for the next scheduled training course.
- People can break the learning into 'chunks' to fit in better with the demands and time-pressures of their own job.
- The time required to learn the underlying theory is reduced to a minimum, reflecting the reality that people learn at different speeds and may already have varying amounts of knowledge of the new topic.
- As a result, non-revenue earning time is reduced, compared with traditional training courses, when the pace of learning is determined by the slowest person.
- It enables the subsequent trainer-led course to focus on practising the skills, removing the need to explore underlying theories.

- Trainer-led courses are thus shorter, with a corresponding reduction in all the associated costs – trainers, facilities, overnight accommodation, etc.

So e-learning really does deliver 'more for less' – greater skill levels with reduced costs.

How Does it Work?

For people to learn effectively with e-learning they need to experience three stages of learning:

- Grasp the Theory. They undertake a self-study e-learning course, supported by other learning resources, for example, books or videos.
- Practise the Skills. Learners come together with colleagues to practise their skills in a short, intensive trainer-led course.
- Apply the learning. They apply all the learning to reach new levels of business performance, supported by on-line coaching.

This report will show you how you can design and manage each of these key stages.

What this report will not cover is the technical aspects of designing and implementing the software associated with the learning management system. These are continually changing and, in addition, different software houses will offer their own basket of features and benefits.

Where Are You?

By 'where are you?' we're not asking where you are physically but where you are in the overall process of designing or implementing e-learning:

- You might be working in a company which is considering e-learning as an option.
- You might be a conventional trainer who feels threatened or nervous about the proliferation of e-learning.
- You might work in one of the many software companies that designs and implements electronic learning management systems for clients.

- Or you might be a consultant – freelance or working for a consulting company who offer this service to clients.
- You may simply be someone who is just interested to learn what the fuss is all about when you hear people talking about 'e-learning'.

This report will help you, no matter where you work or what your interest is.

You may be interested to know that an important aspect of a good novel is that you quickly realize the 'point of view' that the book is written from, and this report is no exception. To make it easier for all of us this report will be written from the perspective of someone in a company which is considering e-learning as an option.

How Can We Take Part?

If you've read this far you're probably interested in using e-learning in your company and now wondering how you can get started. There are many companies who specialize in this type of work and who will design you an excellent e-learning product or system – but at a price.

Building on the 'more for less' concept it is possible to carry out much of the work internally, using the skills and knowledge of your in-house training teams to do most of the work. Not only do you keep the costs down but perhaps, more importantly, the resulting training has that all-important authentic 'flavor' of your own company and its values.

This is where this report comes in – it gives you a practical, step-by-step guide to designing your own e-learning products. Even if you decide to out-source some or all of the work to a specialist external provider this report can serve as a valuable 'check list' of what needs to happen to ensure that the resulting product really is what you want.

A Practical Example

A report like this could easily become too theoretical and hard for you to turn the ideas into reality. So to ensure this doesn't happen, we'll look at one specific course throughout so you can see how the concepts are applied to a real topic.

What topic to choose – there are so many. Well, we need to choose one that everyone can relate to. Everyone attends meetings so we decided a good topic would be improving meeting skills. That way you can easily follow the whole process and, at the end of it, you will have a fully documented set of materials you can use immediately in your own company. You may also learn something useful about managing meetings!

We have given a comprehensive account of the key steps involved from start to finish, and we recognize that you may not need to read all of them. The overview for each chapter should indicate which parts you can skip over, depending on your own knowledge or experience.

Six Top Tips

The author thought it would be helpful to seek the views of the experienced professionals whose job is to translate the course content into functional and exciting multi-media experiences. Emma Pincott, who worked with the author on several assignments, kindly gave the following Six Top Tips.

They are injected at the appropriate point throughout the text to act as timely reminders, and expanded where necessary.

TOP TIP 1

Make sure you get key stakeholders involved at the earliest opportunity.

TOP TIP 2

Leave the IT department out at your own peril! They are critical to the ongoing success of your project.

TOP TIP 3

Don't forget about accessibility, or you may get caught out by the Disability Discrimination Act (DDA).

TOP TIP 4

Be clear about your expectations from the software or development company – do you want to lead, or do you want to be led?

TOP TIP 5

Don't forget to pilot your content, ideally before it gets anywhere near a piece of software.

TOP TIP 6

Finally, how will you measure the project's success? Seems a simple enough question, but it's all too seldom not asked!

Emma is a founder member of *dreamm*, a consortium of multimedia professionals who cover every known technology related to e-learning, as well as the soft-side of development (e.g. project management, instructional design, etc). Their specialities are e-learning, rich media, bespoke solutions and database driven websites. You can find out more about *dreamm* at www.dreamm.co.uk

BLANK



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Chapter 1
Managing an E-learning Project

- 1. Define the Scope of the Training....8
- 2. Link Outcomes to Business Objectives 9
- 3. Carry Out Training Needs Analysis....9
- 4. Identify Key Players....10
- Who to Choose? 11
- 5. Allocate Topics to E-learning and the Trainer-led Course....13
- 6. Learning System Database....14
- 7. Establish Milestones and Budgets....15

Chapter 1
Managing an E-learning Project

1. Define the Scope of the Training

To retain competitive advantage you, like most other companies, will be on a continuous drive to deliver products or services which are quicker, cheaper, lighter, smaller, easier to use, offer more features, cost less to make, etc. To enable these changes to happen, your staff will also be under continuous pressure to change their working practices… and this means continuous personal development. None of this happens by accident.

Most sophisticated companies recognize the strategic advantage that having highly motivated and developed staff gives them. No wonder then that for many training is an important and continuous activity.

So the starting point on our journey is to look ahead and try to identify the specific changes you want to see in your people, and then to define those changes in terms of measurable competences.

It's important at this early stage to involve line managers in this process, and also some of the staff in the target audience. Check out your ideas against their practical experience. There are three main advantages to you as training designer:

- Are you being realistic in what you can achieve in a given time?
- They will have a valuable fund of case studies and real examples which you can use to bring the training 'alive'.
- A further advantage of involving them at this stage is that it starts to build their commitment to the final program – they will feel much more 'ownership' through having been involved.

2. Link Outcomes to Business Objectives

Developing e-learning training programs is initially more costly than simply asking a trainer to design and deliver a one-off course, so you will want to be selective about which courses to deliver using e-learning.

You can be more certain of the longer term cost-effectiveness of e-learning if the courses you identify for this approach:

- will clearly deliver benefits directly related to overall business objectives
- are topics for which there clearly will be an on-going demand, or lots of people are likely to access the training in a short period
- are topics which are likely to stay unchanged over a period of time.

Although it is possible to modify the content or learning process for an e-learning course there are obviously finite costs involved, and it's probably something you'll be reluctant to get involved in.

Let's assume that e-learning is part of your solution. An important part of the process is to define the outcomes in specific competences. What exactly should people be able to do differently at the end of the training?

The more specific the definitions…the more likely the training will deliver the required outcomes.

3. Carry Out Training Needs Analysis

Once you have identified a topic as suitable for e-learning an important step is to assess the current performance of the staff whose working practices or behaviors need to change. To ensure you collect valid information you might wish to:

- use assessment methods which are objective and focus on measurable attributes
- use systems which deliver consistent results irrespective of who is doing it
- sample people at all sites, on all shifts, working on all products or services
- use standard competences which are in everyday use within the company so that people understand what is being talked about.

The results will now enable you to assess the gaps in performance which must be bridged to ensure your staff are going to deliver the new required standards.

Of course the gaps are unlikely to be consistent across the company. In some places groups of staff may be more developed in some aspects because, perhaps, the services they offer are already class-leading. And then, within any group of people, individuals will have their own strengths and development needs.

Consolidating the data will enable patterns to emerge:

- There will probably be a core of new skills required by most people to enable the new levels of service to be implemented effectively.
- There may then be other groups who, because of their current jobs, may need development in specific areas.
- Finally there will be a mass of individual development needs, which reflect the varied backgrounds and experience of any group of staff.

4. Identify Key Players

TOP TIP 1

Make sure you get key stakeholders involved at the earliest opportunity.

Ensure you involve all the interested parties in the project process upfront to lessen the possibility of endless delays caused by the project being put on hold whilst a.n.other department gets involved after finding out about the project indirectly.

Your list of key people will include some or all of the following.

A Project 'Champion'

A champion needs to be someone well known in the company who is able to influence a wide range of key people, especially operational and financial 'movers and shakers'. They will promote your project and, if things get tough, argue why it should not be abandoned in favor of other projects.

Your champion will almost certainly have an operational interest in the successful outcome of the training initiative, probably contributing towards the success of corporate objectives which they are personally associated with.

Budget Holder

You will need to gain [and keep] the active support of the budget holder to ensure that progress is not held up by irritating budgetary approvals or delays.

Topic 'Owner'

Each topic in the training portfolio will have someone who is recognized as the 'owner' of that project and who will have the power to 'sign off' changes to the strategy or the content of any materials related to it.

Subject Matter Experts

For the training to be credible you need to enlist the support of acknowledged experts in the field to provide up to the minute advice or guidance on the way the topic is being implemented, or may change in the light of future technological developments or legislative changes.

Instructional Designer

For the on-line learning to work effectively you will need a good instructional designer, whose job is to turn the raw facts or content into interesting and stimulating courseware.

Who to Choose?

Ideally the best solution is to find a subject matter expert who is also a good instructional designer. But don't compromise if there's any doubt. Their involvement will add credibility to the whole process.

You also have another issue to consider – do you use internal or external people?

Internal people will have extensive knowledge of current initiatives, be soaked in the culture and need no introduction to current processes or procedures. They will be less expensive than external subject matter experts or designers, but may not have so much flexibility in terms of availability.

The main benefit of using **external people** is they bring a fresh approach and are able to share best practice from other companies, unencumbered by all the internal politics or 'baggage'.

The downsides are that they will need to spend time familiarizing themselves with your internal procedures or initiatives and, of course, they generally cost more than internal people.

So the choice may simply come down to costs or time, or just availability to enable a project to be completed in a given timescale.

Software Experts

The success of any e-learning program is geared to the flexibility and user-friendliness of the chosen learning management system so choose the best you can afford. Remember the old adage – quality lives on long after the price is forgotten.

The word will soon get around about which software companies offer the best solutions so make your business networking opportunities work for you.

Internal IT Department

TOP TIP 2

Leave the IT department out at your own peril! They are critical to the ongoing success of your project.

It's important to involve your own IT people right at the start of the project to ensure you have their full cooperation with the technical aspects of the training. They will need to develop a close working relationship with the learning software company to ensure complete compatibility between the different systems.

Line Managers and Staff

We've already mentioned the need to gain the commitment of the managers and staff who are likely to be affected by the training, and you need to keep them actively involved throughout the whole development lifecycle. Listen to what they say and build their ideas into the program as it develops.

5. Allocate Topics to E-learning and the Trainer-led Course

Now we come to the bit the experienced trainers will have been longing for! Designing the training program end-to-end. Start by selecting the models, concepts, skills, behaviors, tools and techniques required. Ensure every performance gap is targeted and the individual elements are specified and brought together so the whole program is a comprehensive and cohesive set of experiences.

This is best done in an extended brainstorming session – use Post-it Notes to free up minds and dispense with any potential barriers.

- Once you have selected all the elements arrange them into a logical sequence – again this is where the Post-it Notes really come into their own.
- At this stage allocate broad timings for each element but be prepared to change as you work through more detailed planning later.

Once you have the broad outline, involve senior managers and line managers from the target audience. Their input will be invaluable and, again, it keeps their 'buy in' to the eventual program.

Training designed this way needs to be more thorough than a conventional approach, because the whole content of what the learners are going to experience needs to be specified before the first person starts the course.

- With conventional training there is always the opportunity for the trainer to modify the course to meet the learners' needs as you go along.
- With a combined e-learning and trainer-led approach there is much less opportunity to add additional learning points.

At some stage you have to go through the whole sequence of training experiences you've identified and decide how that particular piece of learning is to be delivered.

The main decider will be:

- is it knowledge, in which case it should be part of the e-learning course
- is it a skill, in which case it should practised during the trainer-led course.

As you consider how each chunk of the course is to be delivered you may be surprised by the variety of other resources you already have, including:

- books and training packs
- published articles

- video tapes
- DVDs
- audio tapes
- interactive videos
- computer-based training
- existing course designs and materials
- one-to-one discussions
- visits.

Wherever possible try to identify more than one resource for each chunk of the course. For example, the variety of learning styles in your target audience means that a video which interests one group may be a real turn off for others.

6. Learning System Database

As you progress through the project you will quickly realize that a comprehensive data base is essential to manage the progress of learners through the program. You can use this database to:

- record learners' initial interest in a particular program
- enroll learners for Grasp the Theory [the e-learning course]
- monitor their progress through Grasp the Theory
- collect nominations for Practise the Skills [the trainer-led course]
- send out Course Joining Instructions
- record action points resulting from Practise the Skills
- manage relationships with suppliers – e.g. e-learning providers and course venues
- monitor learners' progress with action points
- monitor ultimate improvements in business performance
- evaluate the effectiveness of individual learning programs.

7. Establish Milestones and Budgets

The final part of this stage is to look ahead and set the key dates by which the various elements of the program need to be in place. Using one of the conventional project management software suites may help to keep everyone involved in the development of what will become a complex project.

Don't underestimate how long it will all take. A quick glance at the Project Specification document [Resource 1] will indicate the time scales you can typically expect.

Also be prepared for staged payments to the software company – they will almost certainly raise this at the initial meeting.

BLANK

Chapter 2
Accessibility

- 1. Why this is Important 18
- 2. Physical Accessibility 22
- 3. Dyslexia.....23
- 4. Hearing Difficulties.....23
- 5. Visual Impairment 23
- 6. Other Sources of Advice.....24
- 7. Be Positive about Accessibility.....26

Chapter 2
Accessibility

1. Why this is Important

You may be surprised to see a chapter on accessibility so early in the report but it's position says volumes about the importance of the subject to anyone producing web-based materials. The emphasis on providing wider accessibility for web-based materials has been mainly triggered by the Disability Discrimination Act which came into force in October 2004.

TOP TIP 3

Don't forget about accessibility, or you may get caught out by the Disability Discrimination Act (DDA).

If a company is providing an e-learning course as part of a public program (open to anyone) or to members of their organization who have accessibility issues (i.e. blind, dyslexic, motobility problems, etc) then they have to provide the content in a format that will be 'accessible' to all potential users.

This is an issue that affects everyone in a company from the board downwards and is particularly important for customer facing staff. Many companies may say that their 'customer service to disabled people is great' but they may not have measured this belief against anything specific.

Yet your company may actually be turning disabled customers off because it has not even identified who these customers are and their needs. A common example is the perception of a disabled person being someone in a wheelchair and ignores the remaining 10.3 million people within the group who are not wheelchair users. Many disabled people are not disabled in as obvious a way as a wheelchair user – but their needs also have to be fulfilled.

Apart from the moral case, there are nearly nine million disabled people in the UK with a combined spending power of £45 billion and, with the Disability

Discrimination Act legislation coming into force, there are many good reasons to make your website accessible.

This chapter appears early in the report because you need to discuss 'accessibility' at every stage of the process, starting with selecting your software supplier. It's something you can easily build in as you go along but would be expensive and time consuming to incorporate retrospectively.

Motive for Change

The motivation for change generally comes from one of two directions.

- We may see that something's a good idea and wish to do it because we believe it is right. For example, most people don't 'drink and drive' because they accept that drinking affects their driving ability, and they don't want to cause an accident.
- However, some people don't 'drink and drive' simply because they fear the legal consequences. For them the deterrents of fines and driving bans are what stops them 'drinking and driving'.

We're sure that any responsible organization involved in producing web-based services will wish to ensure that everyone who wishes to use their services will be able to do so, irrespective of their individual abilities.

Although the current legislation focuses on companies providing public web-based services we can't imagine any responsible employer not wanting to give identical consideration for their own staff.

Whichever source of motivation turns you on there's something here for everyone. However, before we explore the positive things we can do let's briefly look at the drivers for change.

What Does it Feel Like?

For anyone with a full range of movement and unimpaired physical ability it's difficult to imagine what barriers are presented in everyday life. We just take things for granted.

If you would like to experience what it feels like for someone who has difficulties to try to access a website which hasn't been designed with accessibility in mind why not try the demonstration from the Disability Rights Commission – you can find it at **www.drc-gb.org/newsroom/demo.asp**

The Disability Rights Commission has recently undertaken a survey of 1,000 websites to assess their accessibility rating and you can see their findings at: **www.drc-gb.org/publicationsandreports**

Stick or Carrot?

If the carrot doesn't entice you… how about the stick?

Let's share with you one legal case concerning web accessibility: *Maguire vs. Sydney Organizing Committee for the Olympic Games [SOCOG]*. A single individual was triumphant in pursuing a complaint of web inaccessibility. His adversary: nothing less than the Olympic movement itself.

This case demonstrates that the legal need for accessibility is so clear-cut, and the means of achieving basic accessibility so straightforward, that even an unspeakably wealthy and powerful international organization can lose in a judicial proceeding.

In Australia in June 1999, **Bruce Maguire** lodged a complaint with the *Human Rights & Equal Opportunity Commission* (HREOC) under a law called the *Disability Discrimination Act*. His complaint concerned the website of the Sydney Organizing Committee for the Olympic Games (SOCOG), which, Maguire alleged, was inaccessible to him as a blind person.

According to the complaint, Maguire, unlike most blind people online, does not use a *screen reader* to read aloud the elements of a web page. Instead, he uses a refreshable Braille display. But neither technology can understand and turn into voice an image that lacks a text equivalent. Nearly all web pages online have some kind of graphics, including high-profile sites like those associated with major sporting events. Maguire contended that significant parts of the SOCOG website, *Olympics.com*, were inaccessible to him.

On 24 August 2000, the HREOC released its decision and supported Maguire's complaint, ordering certain access provisions to be in place on the Olympics.com site by 15 September 2000. SOCOG ignored the ruling and was subsequently fined Australian $20,000.

International Accessibility Standards

The World Wide Web Consortium's (W3C) commitment to lead the web to its full potential includes promoting a high degree of accessibility for people with disabilities. The Web Accessibility Initiative (WAI), part of the W3C, in co-ordina-

tion with organizations around the world, is pursuing web accessibility through five primary areas of work:

- Technology
- Guidelines
- Tools
- Education and outreach
- Research and development

The current version of the WAI Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) can be found at **www.w3.org/TR/WAI-WEBCONTENT**.

Recent Legislation

In the UK, the Disability Discrimination Act came into force in October 2004 and will put pressure on many organizations for change. It's not our intention to reproduce here whole chunks of this 175 page document, but it's worth touching on the highlights.

Part III of the DDA refers to the provision of goods, facilities and services. The Code of Practice, which specifically mentions websites, can be downloaded in its entirety from the Disability Rights Commission website. The parts which may affect you are:

2.2: 'The Disability Discrimination Act makes it unlawful for a service provider to discriminate against a disabled person by refusing to provide any service which it provides to members of the public.'

4.7: 'From 1st October 1999 a service provider has to take reasonable steps to change a practice which makes it unreasonably difficult for disabled people to make use of its services.'

5.23: 'For people with visual impairments, the range of auxiliary aids or services which it might be reasonable to provide to ensure that services are accessible might include... accessible websites.'

5.26: 'For people with hearing disabilities, the range of auxiliary aids or services which it might be reasonable to provide to ensure that services are accessible might include... accessible websites.'

Interpreting the legal jargon reveals the following guidelines:

- All users should be able to operate the websites successfully.
- Content/controls should be understandable to as many users as possible.

- Websites should be developed using web technologies that maximize the use of current/future accessibility and assistive technologies.
- Changes to websites should be assessed in their own right and also for their impact on overall site accessibility before release.
- Usability should be considered along with accessibility but should not be compromised by accessibility features.
- The product development lifecycle of all sites should be customer centered, including accessibility testing with real users wherever possible.

The best thing to do is to look through all the relevant websites and decide what is appropriate for your own situation. Let's briefly explore some of the key issues for the different categories of users.

2. Physical Accessibility

Two of the obvious potential problem areas are access for wheelchair users, and people who find using a mouse difficult.

Wheelchair Access

A fundamental issue is ensuring easy access for wheelchairs users in all office buildings. In addition, it is now possible to provide purpose-built office desks which have a work surface which can be raised or lowered to provide easy wheelchair access. A control pad on the desk controls the movement.

Mouse

Many sites use access keys, which are essentially keyboard shortcuts on a website that give a keyboard or screen-reader user quick and easy access to all the main areas of the site. The keys operate functions, just like they did in the DOS days, long before Windows!

3. Dyslexia

The advice from the Dyslexia Association is straightforward, easy to implement and stresses the need for clear and uncluttered screen design. Follow these guidelines for success:

- Keep the use of text on any screen to a minimum.
- Short paragraphs, with clear headings.
- Choose font colors carefully.
- Use pale colored backgrounds.
- Sans serif font, 12 point.

In fact, all these guidelines follow the advice for good design of any visual aids. For further information please contact:

The British Dyslexia Association
98 London Road, Reading, RG1 5AU
Tel: 0118 966 2677
Fax: 0118 935 1927
Email: helpline@bdadyslexia.org.uk

4. Hearing Difficulties

At the design stage it's relatively easy to build in captions or sub-titles which someone who has hearing difficulties can easily access.

Essentially you use the same text as would be spoken for the voiceover but it would be displayed on request.

5. Visual Impairment

- Web designers can use a screen reader which converts the on-screen text to a voice-over to enable blind people to use web materials easily.
- You can also make your website talk by downloading the free text to speech software Browsealoud. Simply install it and then move your mouse over any text, link, picture or button and Browsealoud will speak it to you. You can download this from www.browsealoud.com.

- If you would like a demonstration of the type of facility it offers why not try the basic narrator facility you probably have on your own PC. To access it click: *Start– Accessories – Accessibility – Narrator* for a simple demonstration.

The RNIB offers a wide range of booklets and general advice, including their See It Right booklet. You can get any of these materials from their website, which is: **www.rnib.org.uk** and select the '*Good Design*' banner.

The RNIB website offers lots of practical advice in their Web Access Centre, which can be accessed at www.rnib.org.uk/webaccescentre. This is a resource where you can find information on design guidelines, tips and explanations as well as information on implementation and evaluation of accessible websites, case studies and further useful resources.

The RNIB reminds us that accessible web design is something that is constantly evolving and for this reason they do not offer a download manual. They are constantly updating the Design and Build section of the Web Access Centre with new techniques and would prefer that people go back to them for the most current information.

The RNIB has a comprehensive See it Right document which they use to audit websites against the guidelines, which are taken from the WAI (Website Accessibility Initiative) guidelines. The RNIB also publishes a newsletter that lets people know of major changes.

6. Other Sources of Advice

The Disability Rights Commission

The Disability Rights Commission acts as a good contact point for all issues relating to accessibility. You can contact the DRC Helpline by voice, text, fax, post or email. You can speak to an operator at any time between 08:00 and 20:00, Monday to Friday. Their contact details are:

- Telephone: 08457 622 633
- Textphone: 08457 622 644
- Fax: 08457 778 878
- Email: enquiry@drc-gb.org
- Website: www.drc-gb.org

DRC publications are available in a range of formats and the DRC website provides up-to-date information, advice and links to other organizations.

Ideas on Best Practice

If you like to see some example of what some sites are doing to improve accessibility visit the ability net site: **www.abilitynet.org.uk**

The site explores how everyone who uses computers can easily learn a few simple things to customize their computer set up.

- They explore how to overcome any problems caused by the display – from struggling to see the text to getting sore eyes through overuse.
- They also look at how you can make your keyboard and mouse suit you – reducing any discomfort and helping you to make fewer mistakes when typing.
- Finally they look at how you can use the things built into your computer to help you read when you find reading lots of text difficult.

To use this service visit the ability net site and click on each of the areas of need and work through some of the exercises to find a computer set up that suits you.

Bobby Approval

In Europe there are several initiatives you can call upon to help ensure that all your web materials conform to specified minimum standards. One of these free services, Bobby, will allow you to test web pages and help expose and repair barriers to accessibility and encourage compliance with existing accessibility guidelines, established by the World Wide Web Consortium [W3C].

To learn about products to test websites of all sizes for accessibility issues, please visit the **accessibility section on www.watchfire.com**.



Once your website reaches a Bobby Approved rating, you are entitled (though not required) to use the applicable Bobby Approved icon on your site. These icons identify your organization as one committed to inclusion.

7. Be Positive about Accessibility

The main point to emerge from this chapter is to be positive about accessibility as you progress through your e-learning project. It starts right at the beginning when it's much easier, and less expensive, to build these features in.

Put accessibility positively on the agenda for every step of the journey:

- Chapter 3 – as you're selecting your software supplier ask about their attitude towards, and experience with, accessibility.
- Chapter 4 – incorporate accessibility into your Project Specification.
- Chapter 5 – consider accessibility issues as you design the course overall.
- Chapter 6 – ensure the delegate workbook is clear and easy to use.
- Chapter 7 – design the quizzes to be easily accessible.
- Chapter 8 – consider accessibility at every stage of the design.
- Chapter 9 – ensure accessibility is on the agenda for every review meeting, and that things are being done.
- Chapter 10 – consider accessibility as you design the storyboards, including use of screen readers and sub-titles or captions.
- Chapters 11 to 13 – consider accessibility issues for the trainer-led course, especially the venue specification.
- Chapter 14 – any special accessibility advice for the trainers?
- Chapter 15 – any accessibility lessons to be learned for other applications?



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Chapter 3
The Software Supplier

- 1. Select and Brief a Software Supplier 28
- 2. Establish the Project Team.....29
- 3. Communicate Your Needs 30
- 4. Finalize the Storyboard Format.....33

Chapter 3
The Software Supplier

1. Select and Brief a Software Supplier

An early decision will be selecting the software company who will provide the electronic learning system for your course. No doubt you will have well established procurement procedures which will guide you through the process.

But of course you will need to shortlist the companies from the wide range of potential providers. Your own network of contacts will give you valuable personal recommendations which, coupled with extensive research, will give you a shortlist.

A few extra things to consider.

- Ensure you see an example of their learning system in operation on a typical course.
- Try it out yourself and see how 'user friendly' the whole package is.
- Is it easy to find your way around their package?
- Does the technology enhance learning or get in the way?
- Ideally try accessing their learning materials using your own network, not on a CD. That way you will sense how slow or frustrating the system may be for your own staff as they work through the modules.

TOP TIP 4

Be clear about your expectations from the software or development company – do you want to lead, or do you want to be led?

2. Establish the Project Team

Keep the project team small but ensure you have all the right people. This may sound obvious but you could easily find that you have a key person missing.

The author fell foul of this situation working with one client for whom he was acting as the instructional designer developing a performance management program. All the way through the design process he was working with one person who claimed to be responsible for all aspects of performance management.

Right at the last minute this person suddenly said "I suppose we ought to consult Ms X, who is responsible for the capability and disciplinary procedures." And, of course the moment Ms X saw the materials you can imagine what happened. We didn't quite have to start again but there was a huge amount of changes that had to be made to gain her commitment.

So do ensure that you have everyone who can 'sign off' the materials for the topic areas.

In addition, on the project team you will need:

- the person who has the financial authority for the project, or you will constantly be waiting for approval to go ahead
- the subject matter expert[s] who can immediately offer ideas or alternatives
- an instructional designer – who will design the actual training. This could be the same person as the subject matter expert
- the line manager for the training program
- a representative of the software company who knows the learning system thoroughly
- someone from your in-house IT department who can advise on the technical interface issues between the company's system and the electronic learning system
- an in-house trainer who can advise on training materials in current use, or changes that are soon to be implemented
- if appropriate, a line manager or possible end-user of the training.

Of course they don't need to attend every meeting – just those when they have a specific contribution to make.

Schedule the interim project review meetings well in advance, or you may find people are unable to attend a meeting scheduled at short notice. The dates should be negotiated as part of the contract so there are no surprises for anyone.

3. Communicate Your Needs

So you have everyone assembled for the initial meeting – where do you start?

To ensure you are all on the same track, and to minimize misunderstandings, the software supplier will probably suggest using a standard project specification document such as you can find at Resource 1.

Please take a few minutes to look through the general style and format. This document will act as the reference for all parties during the lifecycle of the project, especially during the periodic review meetings. Of course it can be modified but only with the full agreement of all parties.

Don't rush this first meeting – it's important to get the project specification right. You may need to schedule 3-4 hours to cover all the points in detail. Let's go through the sections briefly.

1. Introduction

This opening section briefly describes the project.

2. Format

Outline here the format to be used, ensuring you have compatibility with existing IT systems or other electronic learning systems.

3. Target Groups

A simple statement of who the training is primarily intended for, with perhaps secondary groups who may also benefit.

4. Target Countries

Which countries will the electronic learning system be used in? There are several considerations here:

- Technical compatibility of the learning systems.
- Language for both the on-screen text and the voice-overs.
- Are there cultural differences which make a message unacceptable or confusing in another country?
- Internal funding, if the costs are to be shared by several operating companies.

5. Learning Aims

This section gives a broad overview of what the training is designed to change.

6. Structure

This section sets out the broad chapters for the program.

7. Learning Outcomes

Section 7 details the broad changes in knowledge, skills or attitudes the learning needs to bring about. It does not attempt to define exactly how the results should be achieved. That's why you have an instructional designer.

This is when you explain the results of the training needs analysis. You will need to be very specific about the exact competencies that need to be explored and the learning outcomes the learners need to achieve once they have completed the training.

Good designers will not let you get away with woolly or unspecific requirements as they will know from bitter experience that if you are unhappy with the final outcome they will be funding any rewrites themselves.

The planning meetings can be quite challenging but they're important to ensure that everyone is in full agreement about what needs to be done, before any amount of work actually takes place.

If you are using external subject matter experts and/or instructional designers you will need to share with them sufficient of your internal procedures, processes or materials to enable them to do their job effectively.

It's particularly helpful if these materials can be made available electronically as it saves so much time when incorporating items into the e-learning course ware.

Don't expect to finalize this document at the first meeting. It may take several rounds of discussions before full agreement is reached on the contents. Don't rush at it – this is your contact so get it right!

8. Platform

This is when your own IT person and the representative from the software company will leave everyone feeling in the cold as they revel in the joys of technical specifications.

Don't try to get involved – after all, that's why you invited your own IT delegates along! Just ensure that what's being proposed is compatible and involves the minimum of additional IT budget.

9. Training Duration

This is designed to specify how long the training should last end to end, but don't spend too much time discussing it. It is for guidance only, as people will progress through the course at different rates.

You know from your own experience that five people reading exactly the same text will all take differing times. Some people skim whilst others read every part in great detail.

Add to that the design feature of e-learning that people can tailor the course to their own needs, and you can easily appreciate why it's difficult to give an exact time for the course.

But you need to be clear about whether it's a one hour course or a two hour course as it helps the instructional designer to assign priorities.

10. Notes

A section to record any notes for unusual aspects of the project.

11. Schedule

Use this section to agree the schedule for the whole project. Again this is important as it acts as the main driver for all the activities within the project.

You quickly become aware how long these projects take so schedule the review meetings in early. That way you can be sure that the key people will be able to attend. And if the meeting's not required … it frees up welcome space in peoples' diaries.

Allow sufficient time for internal 'sign off' of the materials as they are presented at different stages. You just need one or two key people to be away on holiday or away on a project, and suddenly the five day 'window' for client sign off stretches to two weeks or longer.

Then it's no good blaming your contractors when the project starts to seriously slip.

There may also be intermediate progress reviews of a more informal nature. For example, the author, when acting as instructional designer, likes to have the client 'sign off' the content and sequence of screen images before starting work on transferring them to storyboards.

That way both client and designer are happy with the content and flow before more detailed work commences.

At this stage in the meeting the software supplier will probably raise the issue of staged payments, and seek your agreement to specific arrangements.

4. Finalize the Storyboard Format

Another decision to get early on is the format to be used for the storyboards.

Let's explain the jargon. Once the course content is settled, the instructional designer will develop a series of screens which will present the detailed course content, item by item, to the learner. For our one-hour Meetings Skills courses there will probably be about 120 separate screens. We'll look at designing the storyboards in more detail in Chapter 10.

Once you have 'signed off' the content as meeting the learning needs, the instructional designer will assemble the series of images into a set of storyboards. These will give the software designers all the information they need to convert the course content into the screens seen by the learner through the magic of the learning system.

The format used for the storyboards needs to be simple, comprehensive and user friendly for both instructional and software designer.

We have suggested a format at Resource 10 which you can propose during this initial meeting. As you can see on the first page there are four main components:

1. Storyboard header, which tells the software designer:
   - this is screen number 0001, the first in the package
   - the chapter is 'Welcome'
   - the title of this screen is 'Welcome page'.
2. The screen image shows the designer:
   - what the learner should see on this screen
   - the images and text and the positional relationships.

   The designer interprets the screen within the technical limitations of the learning system.
3. The description, which tells the software designer:
   - what the learner should be able to do
   - how the learning system should react to the learner's inputs.
4. The voice-over tells the voice-over artist:
   - what to say
   - how the words should be coordinated with changes on the screen.

We suggest using PowerPoint or a similar format for the storyboards because it's easy to move text and images around freely.

Tips for success

1. Hold a pre-meeting with the internal team to agree a combined approach on all the key issues before you meet the software supplier. It will save a lot of time, cost [and credibility!]
2. Don't be intimidated by 'experts' and insist they use language everyone can relate to – Plain English. Winston Churchill once had a run-in with an American General about using complex language. He asked him: "Would people have understood me if I had said 'Hostilities will be actively engaged with our adversary around the whole coastal perimeter.'" The American looked puzzled. "No they wouldn't," Churchill continued, "So what I actually said was 'We will fight on the beaches!'".

3. Ensure you are working with the latest, agreed versions of internal policies and definitions. The author was developing a suite of performance management courses for one client when, two days before the trainer-led course was scheduled, their management board decided to continue using the existing competency framework and definitions.

The HR team had expected the board to approve a new set of definitions which had been used in both the e-learning course and the trainer-led course. Lots of last minute [and expensive] changes!

BLANK



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Chapter 4
The E-learning System

- 1. Strengths and Limitations of the Electronic Learning System 38
- 2. Agree the Screen Layout and Navigation Buttons 38
- 3. Explore Options for On-screen Tasks, Questions and Activities 40
- 4. Finalize How Learners will Access the E-learning System 41
- 5. Discuss How the System will Track Individual's Progress.....41
- 6. Decide What Information to Collect about Learning System Usage 42
- 7. Sell E-learning into the Business 43

Chapter 4
The E-learning System

1. Strengths and Limitations of the Electronic Learning System

One of the early discussions you need to have with the software designers is to understand the strengths and limitations of their learning system. This will be especially important to your instructional designer as they will need to know what they can, and cannot do, with the actual training materials.

We'll look at this aspect in Chapter 8 when we discuss designing the course in more detail, but for the moment you need to understand the range of flexibility the designer has when creating each screen.

- For example, if you ask the learner to rearrange a series of items on a particular screen, how easy will it be to display them on a later screen and perhaps add a commentary on the order the learner has selected?
- What limitations are there to asking a learner to carry out a task, then to have the results displayed on a later screen?

You may not know all the questions to ask right at the start because the instructional designer may not have a fully formed idea of how the course may develop. But as you start to develop the course materials the instructional designer may need to consult with the software designers to check out specific ideas before they are implemented, to avoid wasted effort.

2. Agree the Screen Layout and Navigation Buttons

An important issue to discuss is how the materials will be presented to the learner. What will the screen actually look like? Every software provider will have slightly different approaches to the screen appearance and you need to discuss and agree how they will use the available space.

No doubt your corporate relations people will be able to give you guidance about the way that the company logo needs to be displayed, as well as the colors for borders and fonts.

Imagine the learner looking at their computer screen. The usable screen area, the center part of the screen, will generally be sandwiched between an upper and lower border.

The upper border is often used to tell the learner exactly where they are at that moment. The components are typically:

- the company logo and name
- the course title
- the current chapter title
- the actual page or screen number.

If you recall the storyboard format we discussed in Chapter 2, these items are in the header at the top of the storyboard.

The lower border on the visible screen is often used for navigational icons, which enable the learner to move around the course:

- a right arrow – which takes you to the next page
- a left arrow – which takes you to the previous page
- a home sign – which takes you to the home page
- a '?' – which takes you to Help
- a printer icon – which enables you to print that page.

Of course there may be more, depending on your particular software provider and what you agree as part of the contract.

You quickly realize that the usable screen area starts to shrink quite dramatically and can often give the instructional designer quite a headache. But the golden rule is to never to have too much on one particular screen, so it seems to work quite well.

3. Explore Options for On-screen Tasks, Questions and Activities

One challenge facing the instructional designer is to keep the learner motivated and interested as they work through the course. No matter how exciting the screen image, or the impact of the material that's presented, the attention span of a typical adult learner is probably quite short.

So we have to keep them interested by changing the screen appearance and the types of tasks they are asked to complete. A course which simply presents screen after screen of text or pictures will quickly lose the learner's interest.

So the secret of success when designing e-learning is just the same as designing trainer-led courses – active and meaningful participation. And lots of it!

There are many different ways to achieve this, including:

- click and drag answers
- re-arrange items on the screen
- type in responses to questions
- quizzes
- responding to multi-choice questions
- use of short video clips
- case studies.

We'll look at the options in more detail in Chapter 8. At this stage you need to ask the software providers for their ideas on what they recommend works best with their learning system.

And the range is continually expanding as the software driving learning systems become ever more sophisticated. The instructional designer needs to build up a close working relationship with the software team so that they each understand the best way to keep the learner turning the page.

4. Finalize How Learners will Access the E-learning System

This is the first of a series of essentially internal discussions you need to have to ensure that everyone involved or affected by the electronic learning system is in agreement with what's planned. There may be many other issues you face, prompted by the nature of your own business or the way that your IT systems are structured.

This initial topic prompts you to consider how learners will access the e-learning system, and there are many sub-sets of this question to debate. Some of the options are:

- People are able to access the learning system direct by selecting the appropriate drive.
- Staff are only able to access the system after they have enrolled with the HR department – please see the next section.
- People access the e-learning system through another internal gateway. For example, the course may be part of another suite of materials such as a Line Manager Development System.

This apparently simple decision brings into play a series of discussions involving a variety of departments and budget holders, and needs to be sorted out internally before approaching the software supplier.

Depending on the speed of the network you may also wish to make the courseware available on CD-ROM so that people with slow links or limited computer access can still benefit from the course.

5. Discuss How the System will Track Individual's Progress

This relates back to of the issues raised just now – enrolment.

Will staff members be able to access the e-learning program materials only after they have 'enrolled' on the course with the HR department?

- If not, you could have unrestricted usage of the system and the HR team would be unaware of how many people had worked through the course and with what results.

- This could be a problem if you have an internal system for nominally charging departments for the training they have.
- It would also make it difficult to make links between usage of training on the one hand and training needs recorded in individual Personal Development Plans on the other.

The HR department will probably wish to know which staff members have started working on the course and which parts they have completed.

This will be important if staff, having completed the e-learning course, have the opportunity to experience a short, trainer-led course, as the HR department will need evidence that the individual has satisfactorily completed the e-learning.

6. Decide What Information to Collect about Learning System Usage

Stepping back from seeing how individuals are working through the system the company as a whole will wish to monitor the overall success of the learning system, and the contribution it's making to achieving corporate objectives.

There's a wide range of information you may wish to collect, and it will probably include the following:

- The number of staff who start the course, perhaps by department and grade/rank.
- The proportion of staff who do not complete the course, perhaps by department and grade/rank.
- The time taken by learners to work through individual chapters, which might indicate the degree of challenge each chapter presents.
- A breakdown showing the percentage of learners who fail to complete each chapter, which might indicate those which are most challenging or least interesting.
- The time taken to complete the whole course, or parts of the course, as an indicator of the cost-effectiveness of e-learning.
- The time delay from an individual learner starting the course to completing it, or abandoning it.
- Feedback from individual learners on which parts they found most interesting or useful, and those parts they found least helpful.

- The impact of the e-learning system on the company's IT system overall.
- The quality of service experienced by individual learners in different locations – does the internal network operate sufficiently fast over all sites?

You can quickly appreciate that there's lots of information you might need to collect and it may be difficult and/or costly to build it in retrospectively.

7. Sell E-learning into the Business

All this discussion about the way the e-learning course will be used and measuring the take up and success will no doubt prompt very valid considerations about how the new training will be publicized.

A lot of energy will have to be directed into raising awareness of people to the new system and overcoming the very natural reluctance many people will have. Although the 'go live' date may seem far away it will quickly race round.

Developing a strategy for 'selling' e-learning into the business will be easier if you've actively involved managers and users throughout the design process.

Blended learning, using a combination of e-learning with a shorter trainer-led course, is different from conventional training approaches and people may need some encouragement to embrace it willingly. You should also consider how to overcome resistance by learners.

The Benefits

The main benefits are:

Matching the training to the learner. Delegates take different time to learn the theory of any subject and some will need to spend more on some aspects than others. With blended training learners can adjust their pace to their own specific needs.

Moving at the speed of the slowest. Having everyone together in the training room to learn the theory means that at times the course will be slower than many would like.

Variety of learning resources. The learner can experience a rich mixture of learning sources, many of which are not expensive.

Matching learning style. The learner can experience a wider range of learning techniques which should enhance their learning process as they can match it to their own learning style.

Operational effectiveness. Working off-line to study the theory of a course means that the learner can fit in the study with their own work pressure.

Cost-effectiveness. The trainer and learners are in the training facilities for the minimum amount of time.

Minimum disruption. The organization suffers the least amount of disruption to their revenue-earning activities.

The Downsides

So there are many advantages to using blended training but, like everything in life, it's not all roses. There are certain potential disadvantages which you will need to be aware of, and prepare for.

Time pressure. The one-day trainer-led course, when delegates practise their skills, is by its nature intensive and so every minute is precious.

Varied amount of preparation. Sadly not every learner will approach the e-learning course with the same degree of motivation. Personal commitments, coupled with the pressure at work mean that your delegates will arrive with varying degrees of theoretical knowledge.

No time for 'hobby horses'. The time pressure means that the trainer has to be focused on practising the skills which follow from the theory which the learners have studied. There is simply not sufficient time to introduce new theoretical concepts.

Model the concepts. It is essential for the trainer to model the concepts covered in the e-learning part of the learning or delegates may be confused. This is sometimes difficult for trainers, as they may not always accept every element of the theory course.

On Balance…

Weighing the advantages and disadvantages most organizations will find the concept of blended training to be potentially useful. Once you've made the decision to go ahead with e-learning you need to market and implement it energetically using all possible media.

Consider internal magazines, newsletters, company intranet, and notice boards. Also be aware of when managers will be discussing annual appraisals so that e-learning becomes one of the possible development options.

BLANK



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Chapter 5
E-learning Course Content

- 1. Define Learning Objectives 48
- 2. Design the Overall Course Content 48
- 3. Identify Company Materials or Procedures Which Must be Used for Consistency.....49
- 4. Harmonize the Content with Other Company Materials, Procedures or Products 51
- 5. Research Sources for Course Content.....51
- 6. Clarify Expectations about Sourcing Materials 52

Chapter 5
E-learning Course Content

1. Define Learning Objectives

So you're now at the stage when you can start designing the overall structure of the e-learning course. The starting point is to clarify the learning outcomes – what specifically do you want learners to be able to do differently having completed the course?

You've already done most of the work – remember Section 7 of the Project Specification document which you can find at Resource 1. That sets out the main chunks the course should cover.

What's useful now is for the instructional designer and subject matter expert to talk the list through with the topic 'owner' to clarify any issues, and to see if any other thoughts have arisen since the list was first compiled.

This is a final opportunity to modify the list of learning outcomes before the concentrated course design work starts. After this point changes start to become more expensive, and time consuming, to incorporate.

2. Design the Overall Course Content

The overall flow for the course will have been defined in Section 6 of the Project Specification where the chapters are listed. The instructional designer now starts to 'flesh out' the list in Section 7 with specific tasks, exercises, text, case studies etc, to bring the topic alive and ensure the learner derives the required outcomes.

A recommended way to do this is to use Post-it Notes to develop the whole sequence of experiences the learner will work through.

- At this stage don't get too worried about the flow between items or even exactly what the learner will do.
- All you're trying to do now is to sort all the possible ideas into a logical sequence which will feel 'right' for the learner.

- Also, don't worry about the content of each piece, as long as you can anticipate it will deliver the required outcomes.

This process can take several hours and results in a rash of Post-it Notes which, however, contain the key elements you need for your course design.

Just to show you how the process develops, we've given you at Resource 2 the initial notes which resulted from the Post-it Note plan for the Meetings Skills course. Please take a few minutes to glance through the way it developed, and the extra ideas which were prompted. For example, references to items being included in the delegate workbook – more of that in the next chapter!

Can you start to see the transition from the list of general outcomes in Section 7 of the Project Specification to a structured flow which we can use to design the course?

The additional benefit of using Post-it Notes is that you can ask other people for their ideas and comments and, if you don't like what they say, you simply rearrange the Post-it Notes once they have left the room! But the chances are you will find their comments helpful and build them in.

3. Identify Company Materials or Procedures Which Must be Used for Consistency

Once you have the broad sequence and flow you can look at each chunk and consider the actual content to use.

And now we come to a very important issue. Depending on the topic there will be a varying amount of company-specific information, processes, standards or policies which must be included, and you need to find and use them. For example, if you're designing a course on selling your company's products:

- you must use exactly the same materials used elsewhere in the sales process
- contracts, specifications, conditions, prices, terminology, brand images etc will all be defined by the relevant marketing teams and you must use them all.

However, if you're designing a course on, for example, performance management the situation will be more fluid.

- There will be many standard procedures and policies which are implemented across the company which will have to be incorporated into the e-learning course. For example, the company discipline procedure.
- There will also be many other aspects of performance management which are more generic, for example, soft skills which can be imported as best practice from outside the company. Examples could be asking open questions and helping an individual to boost their self esteem.

If you're designing a presentation skills course then the situation is likely to be different again:

- Apart from some general advice about using standard PowerPoint templates there will probably be little mandatory material to be incorporated.

The instructional designer will need to have access to all these materials, ideally in electronic format, so they can be used in the e-learning course with the minimum amount of effort.

In many companies these materials exist in the company intranet so they are readily accessed electronically.

One further aspect whilst we're on this section is to clarify any content that must be included in your training package. Perhaps there has been a directive about some important issue, or there may have been some recent legislation which places onerous responsibilities on employers which has to be stressed to all employees.

- For example, one can't imagine a recruitment and selection course which doesn't include a section on equal opportunities.

4. Harmonize the Content with Other Company Materials, Procedures or Products

Another different, but linked issue, is the need to ensure that the materials you develop in the e-learning course are consistent with other company materials.

So, for example, if we were developing a recruitment and selection course for e-learning, we would need to ensure that all the terms and content related to 'job descriptions' or 'short-listing process' were consistent with the words and concepts used anywhere those concepts were discussed.

This may take some effort as you will need to contact a wide range of people in the company to see if anything they have, or are responsible for, may impinge, however slightly, on the topic you are developing. Again, it is time well spent – better to change something now than when many hours of development have been committed.

5. Research Sources for Course Content

Throughout these two last steps you will have been annotating the equivalent list we showed you in Resource 2 as you identify materials you must use, or other sources you can call upon.

By the nature of things you are likely to still have a range of topics for which you don't have an immediate source. So that's the next challenge – plug those resource gaps.

The most obvious person to call on is the subject matter expert. If you've chosen well he or she should have an up-to-date stock of resources or people to call on.

Another excellent source is the internet. Just type in your topic in Google and watch the pages fill up. The author was recently writing a training package and his partner suggested mentioning a story which recounted the way that a colony of monkeys developed new skills.

Having explained the outline of the story she casually said "Why not try the internet?" So he did. He typed in '100 monkeys' and was blessed with pages of stories, reference material, analysis and books. Very helpful it was too!

6. Clarify Expectations about Sourcing Materials

By now the equivalent list to Resource 2 should be looking fairly healthy, with few gaps, if any. A final step in the process is to clarify who is going to source specific materials, when they will do it and the format they intend to use.

The author remembers working with one client and sourcing materials was a continual problem area.

- People said they would supply items by certain times and didn't.
- Others did supply materials which later turned out to be earlier, and out-dated versions of key documents.
- Others supplied documents on time but in a format which the author couldn't unlock.
- It all wastes time and causes unnecessary frustration.

It also makes sense to have one central contact point in the software company who becomes the clearing house for information flows – both into and out from the client company.

You also need to discuss issues such as copyright if you're relying on external people to source documents or materials.



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Chapter 6
Delegate Workbooks

- 1. Consider the Need for a Delegate Workbook 54
- 2. Discuss the Scope and Coverage of the Workbook 55
- 3. Consistency with the On-screen Image 57
- 4. Clarify the Format and Style of the Workbook 58
- 5. How Will Learners Access the Workbook? 61

Chapter 6
Delegate Workbooks

1. Consider the Need for a Delegate Workbook

An early discussion will center on the need for a delegate workbook to accompany the e-learning course. Note the assumptive 'close' in this statement – there shouldn't really be any discussion about the need for a workbook – only what it contains and how it works alongside the e-learning materials.

Just in case you're not convinced let's ask the obvious question – why have a workbook? There are several reasons:

- Working through a lengthy e-learning course should be interesting and help the learner to acquire lots of knowledge and skills. But without a permanent reminder of the topics you've covered, the retention rate can easily fall dramatically once the screen is switched off.
- A good e-learning course will actively involve the learner throughout the whole course. The learner may be asked to complete tasks, or to sequence lists of options, or do other interactive activities. Of course you can write these on scraps of paper, but there is more value if these tasks are written in a workbook which acts as a focus.
- Another issue is continuity. It's very unlikely that the learner will work through the entire course in one session. It's more likely that the course will be done in chunks, with varying amounts of time between sessions. A workbook will remind the learner where they got to in the previous session and so kick the latest session off more productively.
- The workbook should also act as a focus for the action plan the learner should develop as he or she progresses through the course. A good e-learning course will generate lots of 'Ah Ha!' moments – those sudden realizations or moments of truth which lead towards changes in behavior or attitude. You need somewhere to write them down – or they quickly disappear.

Let's assume you've persuaded all the key people of the need for a delegate workbook to accompany the e-learning course – now we need to consider what it should contain.

2. Discuss the Scope and Coverage of the Workbook

A workbook could potentially become very large so it's essential early on to decide the scope and coverage. You will need to be quite ruthless as there will be many types of topic competing for inclusion in the workbook. These include:

- reinforcement of the key learning points included in the e-learning course
- spaces for the learner to record the results of tests, case studies or other activities posed during the e-learning materials
- spaces for the learner to record action points as the course unfolds
- the opportunity to reinforce key company messages or initiatives which relate to the e-learning topic.

Let's examine each one in turn.

Reinforcement of the Key Learning Points

This is a powerful way to drive home the key learning points of the course, and the challenge will be deciding what to include.

- If you include too many topics the workbook becomes bulky, and may lose some of its impact.
- If, driven by the need to keep size down, you exclude too many of the learning points people may find the workbook a bit 'lightweight' and not particularly helpful.

Spaces for the Learner to Record the Results of Tests or Other Activities

It is widely recognized that the value of a workbook, and therefore the e-learning course it's based on, is dramatically improved if the design actively encourages the learner to interact with the program and record their own thoughts, ideas or interpretation of the course materials.

So allow sufficient space for the learner to effectively create their own course materials, within the overall structure of the course. As with the previous section you need to strike a balance: too frequent recourse to this approach may cause irritation in the learner, whilst too infrequent recourse loses the value of the intervention.

Spaces for the Learner to Record Action Points

Learning or understanding is one thing – knowing how to use the newly acquired skills or knowledge is something totally different. So an important element of the workbook is to encourage the learner to write their action points as they emerge during the course with the hope that they might then do something tangible.

Otherwise the moment the e-learning program ends, it's quite possible that the other messages competing for the learner's attention may drown all the learning gained from the e-learning program.

The workbook should encourage the learner to periodically write specifically what they intend to do differently, and by when. That way you have a sporting chance they will actually apply the learning.

Reinforce Key Company Messages or Initiatives

A further category competing for inclusion may be key company messages related to the topic or related initiatives. For example, an e-learning course on performance management would present a superb opportunity to cascade the corporate messages on mission, vision, individual accountability etc.

As with the other elements you need to be mindful about how much of this type of information is included in both the e-learning course and the accompanying workbook:

- Too much, and it may turn learners off because of 'information overload'. They probably see the messages repeated in official documents, company newsletters etc, and so may welcome the e-learning as somewhere they can escape from these initiatives.
- This type of information also tends to have a relatively short 'shelf life' and needs to be updated quite frequently. Modifying the workbook will be tiresome, but modifying the e-learning course may become prohibitively expensive.

So the design team will need to take a broad overview about how large the workbook should be, and the relative amount of space allocated to the four topics outlined above.

3. Consistency with the On-screen Image

Before considering the style and format of the workbook, it's important to stress that the workbook should mirror exactly what the learner sees on the e-learning screen.

- The sequence and flow needs to be the same.
- If you use concepts or models they must be identical.
- If you use characters in case studies they must be the same names, sex, appearance etc.
- Use identical industries and settings.

This sounds so obvious but it can go wrong and a real example shows the potential pitfalls.

The author had worked with one company to design and deliver a series of one-day courses to accompany a suite of e-learning courses. Then the e-learning provider pulled out of the market, leaving the company to select another e-learning provider.

The author was asked to evaluate the suitability of a series of commercially available e-learning courses, together with the accompanying delegate workbooks. He duly started the process but was quickly confused. Apart from the title on the workbook the contents bore little relation to what was seen on the screen.

- The sequence of the learning points in the book was quite different from that presented on the screen, so the learner had to keep going forwards and then back again to try to follow the sequence. This was irritating to say the least.
- When case studies were used to demonstrate particular points there was little correlation between the on-screen material and the workbook. In one section, for example, the workbook referred to a regional trainer, Graham, and a branch officer, Jackie, who worked in insurance, but the e-learning course featured Michael and Irene, who worked for First bank. The photos showed totally different people.

- Once a page in the workbook had been matched to a concept on the screen, the actual contents were often totally different. Different diagrams were shown, lists were in different order, and there were even learning points which were not covered in the e-learning materials.
- The workbook bore little relation to on-screen tasks, so there was nowhere to record ideas and thoughts about specific pieces of work. Having to resort to scraps of paper caused further irritation.

The author reported this back to the e-learning supplier who then conducted an urgent internal review. It turned out that the e-learning course, together with the delegate workbook, had originally been designed for the US market. When the product was to be launched in the UK the e-learning course had been almost totally redesigned – but nobody thought to do the same for the delegate workbook!

And they had been selling this to UK clients for quite a few months.

So the learning point is to design the workbook and e-learning materials in parallel, and ensure that any changes or modifications to either are carried over into the complementary medium.

4. Clarify the Format and Style of the Workbook

When planning the workbook there are several design aspects to consider:

- The overall strategy.
- Non-negotiable items.
- Detailed design.

Let's examine each aspect in more detail.

The Overall Strategy

Before embarking on detailed design it's essential to settle the role the workbook plays in relation to achieving the overall goal of improving competitive advantage. You will need to involve all the key players in these discussions to ensure you have consensus before starting work. The questions to discuss will include:

- How does the workbook fit alongside the e-learning course?
- What balance of content do you want for the categories explored in section 2 above?

- How large should it be?
- How does *this* workbook relate to the workbook learners will get when they attend the trainer-led course?
- Non-negotiable Items

Once you have a clear idea of the role the workbook should play you need to clarify any non-negotiable items before you can start the detailed design. These 'givens' include:

Corporate Identity

- Your corporate affairs department will be able to give you detailed design specifications about the way that corporate logos, colors or fonts should be used to maintain a consistent image.
- This may cause a conflict if your usable screen area starts being 'eaten up' by the corporate design template.

The Learning Management System

You need to clarify with your software supplier exactly how much usable screen space you have for your course content. Ask them to bring along samples which clearly show how much flexibility you have.

- The usable screen area, where you can display your learning materials, will be the central part of the screen.
- The learning management system will probably use two bands of the screen, one across the top and the other across the bottom for chapter headings and navigation buttons.

Knowing the shape and relative dimensions of this usable area is vital before you can start any detailed design about how you want to present your content. For example, it determines if items are listed vertically or horizontally, which may have an impact on the way you have traditionally displayed a specific model or concept.

Brand Images

The final element of non-negotiable issues is the way that your brands or other trade-mark protected images are presented. It's worth involving the key people at an early stage, rather than incur time consuming and expensive redesign work later.

To ensure consistency, you might wish to extend this category to the wider range of internal corporate messages, which in effect have their own 'branding'. Gaining the approval of these departments is not just sound business practice but they may be able to alert you to forthcoming changes which are not widely known throughout the business.

Detailed Design

Once these wider issues are settled you can begin to discuss the more detailed aspects of designing the workbook. Of course, much will depend on the actual topic being presented, but there are still many common themes including:

- Front page – develop a consistent style across all the e-learning products.
- 'Welcome' page.
- Balance of text and graphics.
- How to refer to e-learning pages and other resources, e.g. company intranet.
- Consistency with existing hard copy documents.
- Style – for example using Plain English.
- Action planning page – consistent with existing style.

To give a flavor of what the workbook could look like we've given a sample workbook that could accompany the Managing Meetings course at Resource 3.

In overview, this particular learner's workbook comprises:

- Front cover.
- Page 1 – welcomes the learner to the course.
- Page 2 – reinforces the definition of a meeting.
- Page 3 – invites the learner to set SMART goals for an upcoming meeting.
- Page 4 – asks the learner to challenge the need for everyone to attend an upcoming meeting.
- Page 5 – asks the learner to practise using a Mind Map.
- Page 6 – refreshes the key steps in an effective meeting.
- Page 7 – reinforces the steps for using Cause and Effect Analysis.
- Pages 8 and 9 – details seven key facilitation skills.

- Page 10 – invites the learner to practise using Sunflower Analysis.
- Page 11 – asks the learner to plan the most effective form of documentation for a meeting.
- Page 12 – suggests an action planning template to use after a meeting.
- Page 13 – gives a personal action planning page for the learner to use after the course.

5. How Will Learners Access the Workbook?

A final aspect to consider is how learners will access the workbook and there are at least two possible approaches. You can either produce the workbooks in bulk and send one to learners as they commence the course, or allow learners to print their own workbook on demand locally.

Let's examine each approach in more detail as they each have advantages and disadvantages.

Central Stock

- ✓ More cost-effective printing.
- ✓ Easy to monitor demand for workbooks.
- ✓ Absolute control over the final appearance of the workbook and other materials.
- × Need somewhere to hold the stock of workbooks.
- × Need to have people and a system for sending workbooks to learners quickly.

On Demand Printing

- ✓ Easy to make amendments to reflect changes in the e-learning course.
- ✓ Learners can get their workbook exactly when they need it.
- ✓ No need for central stocks of workbooks.
- ✓ Easier to convert into other languages.
- × No easy way of monitoring demand.
- × Little control over the final appearance of the workbooks – dependent on the local printer.

There may be other factors to take into account which reflect your local situation. Whichever approach you adopt the resulting workbook should ensure your learners gain the greatest long-term value from the e-learning course.

You are now ready to start on the detailed design of the e-learning course materials.



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Chapter 7
Delegate Assessment

- 1. When to Use Quizzes 64
- 2. Are there 'Right' Answers? 65
- 3. Detailed Design 67
- 4. Who Will See the Results? 72

Chapter 7
Delegate Assessment

1. When to Use Quizzes

Why Use Quizzes?

One very useful feature of e-learning courses is the ability to assess the learner's progress by testing their knowledge or skills before they start the program, and then giving them a similar test at the end to see what they've learned. It can really prove how effective the e-learning course has been.

Quizzes, or self-assessment exercises, also facilitate one of the key benefits of e-learning which is the ability of the learner to control their own learning, by focusing on the sections they need to explore, and bypassing the material they are already familiar with.

Of course you don't necessarily need a quiz to do this – you could simply ask the learner to select the modules they think they need to experience. But asking them to do an initial quiz, and then using the results to select and deselect the appropriate modules, is likely to give a more objective result. Depending on the quiz of course.

If you're considering using quizzes you'll have to decide when to incorporate them:

- At the start of your e-learning course to assess the learner's knowledge.
- At the start to select the course modules they need to focus on.
- At the end of the course to evaluate how much they've learned.
- Or a combination.

You can also use quizzes at any stage during the course to draw attention to specific learning points, or to carry out interim self-assessments for the learner to see how much they've learned.

End-of-Course Assessment

If you're planning to use the 'before' and 'after' quiz as a means of evaluating the effectiveness of the course you will need to consider what questions to ask.

One approach is to repeat exactly the same quiz at the end as at the beginning. That way, it's argued, you can get a precise measurement about what has changed.

But using this approach gives lots of opportunities for the smart learner to 'cheat,' so you may find the results consistently better than the actual level of acquired learning.

Perhaps the best approach for the closing quiz is to have a mixture:

- Use some of the original questions, but perhaps rephrase or present them in a slightly different way so the learner doesn't just repeat the answers from the opening quiz.
- Balance the repeated questions with some new questions, so that the closing quiz looks and feels quite different.

How Many Questions?

How many questions should you ask in an opening or closing quiz? There's no absolute rule, only your instinctive feel for each situation.

- Less than five questions and the coverage of the overall topic will be small. As a result, you will collect a limited amount of data about the learner. It may also have limited value in signposting the learner to the most useful parts of the course.
- More than ten questions and the average learner may start to feel a little frustrated as they will want to get started on the course proper.

2. Are there 'Right' Answers?

If you decide to include quizzes or other forms of self-assessment in your program do be careful about the types of question you ask. This is an important issue to consider as you can easily demotivate learners by making them choose what you believe are 'correct' answers, when they may believe there are a variety of 'appropriate' answers.

'Right' Answers

Obviously there are many topics for which there are 'right' and 'wrong' answers. For example, if the e-learning course was on aviation meteorology, one question could be:

Buys Ballot's law states that, in the Northern Hemisphere, if you stand with your back to the wind, the area of lower pressure is:

- *A. on the right*
- *B. on the left*
- *C. ahead*

And there is only one correct answer and it's B. In the Northern Hemisphere, if you're flying towards an area of low pressure the aircraft will drift to the right, as the wind is coming from your left.

Recommended Answers

There are also many topics for which there may be 'recommended' answers.

For example, if the course was on Health and Safety you could ask the following question on RIDDOR, the legal framework for Reporting of Injuries, Diseases and Dangerous Occurrences Regulations, 1995.

How and when should incidents be notified under RIDDOR?

And the answer would be:

- This notification must be by the quickest practicable means and this is usually by telephone.
- The notification must be followed by a written report within ten days and this is usually done using Form F2508.

Note the word 'usually' in the answer, implying that this is what is expected, but is not mandatory. There may be situations when the 'usual' approach is not appropriate.

Best Practice

Finally, there are many topics for which there may be 'best practice,' but what you actually do depends so much on the situation. For example, if you were designing a quiz question on problem solving you could ask:

- What logical steps would you work through to ensure a problem is solved effectively?
- The recommended steps might be:
    1. define the problem
    2. collect relevant data
    3. identify the root cause[s] of the problem
    4. identify possible solutions
    5. choose the best solution[s]
    6. implement and review.

But there could be good reasons for inserting additional steps, or skipping steps, depending on the actual situation. Imposing one 'right' sequence on the learner might risk alienating them.

You need to very careful about which category you apply to the questions in your quiz because, for example, if you try to 'upgrade' what is a recommended approach and impose it as a 'right' answer, you risk alienating your learners right at the very beginning of the course. And, depending on their reaction, they may abandon the course right there!

3. Detailed Design

Once you have decided the overall plan for quizzes in the course you can then design each quiz or self-assessment task.

- Start by selecting the actual content to be used – choose topics which are relevant to the course material and which represent the main stream of the course.
- Once you have done that you then decide the way to present the questions, aiming for variety to keep the learner interested.
- For example, multi-choice questions or re-arranging a range of possible answers, can be interspersed with more conventional methods.

As you design the quiz or self-assessment tools bear in mind how you will score the learner's answers, and how the results will be displayed and referred to later in the course.

Designing an Opening Quiz

Let's return to the Managing Meetings course we're using to provide examples of what you can actually do. If you look at Resource 4 you will see an example of how the opening quiz could be created.

Let's go through the pages in more detail. Remember for each question the learner's responses will need to be stored and displayed later in the 'answers' section.

PAGE 1 – WELCOME TO THE QUIZ

- This tells the learner what's going to happen, and invites them to complete the quiz.
- Saying "Not all have the 'right' or 'wrong' answers…" sets the ground rules.
- "…and no one else will see your responses, so please answer honestly." This assures the learner that, in this case, no one else will see the results..

PAGE 2 – QUESTION 1

- This question asks the learner to tick either a Yes or No box in a list of questions.
- The word 'essential' should help the learner to be positive about selecting either Yes or No.
- However, you will need to agree with the software supplier how to react if the learner attempts to tick both boxes.

PAGE 3 – QUESTION 2

- This question asks the learner to click and drag the headings to the appropriate boxes.

PAGE 4 – QUESTION 3

- This question asks the learner to tick the appropriate boxes in a list of questions.
- The word 'expect' should help the learner to select the appropriate boxes.

PAGE 5 – QUESTION 4

- This question asks the learner to click one choice from four possible answers.
- On this occasion there is really only one 'right' answer in the options listed.

PAGE 6 – QUESTION 5

- This question asks the learner to list a maximum of nine items.
- It's not necessary for the learner to use all nine headings.
- On this occasion there are no 'right' answers – just a recommended list.

Having asked the questions you need to comment on how the learner has responded. So the learning system needs to be able to record the learner's responses and be able to display them at an appropriate moment.

Let's continue looking at this sample opening quiz to see how the material could unfold. As before the comments relate to the pages in Resource 4.

PAGE 7 – ANSWER TO QUESTION 1

- This page displays the learner's response to Question 1, alongside the 'recommended' answers.
- The phrasing, "If ours are different from yours remember… depending on the situation" suggests that there isn't an absolute answer.
- Refer the learner to the specific section in the course covering this aspect.

PAGE 8 – ANSWER TO QUESTION 2

- This page shows the learner's selection alongside the recommended choices.
- If the learner has chosen differently, refer them to the appropriate section of the course.

PAGE 9 – ANSWER TO QUESTION 3

- This page shows the learner's selection alongside the recommended choices.
- If the learner has chosen differently refer them to the appropriate section of the course.

PAGE 10 – ANSWER TO QUESTION 4

- This page shows the learner's selection, together with the recommended choice.
- If the learner has chosen differently refer them to the appropriate section of the course.

PAGE 11 – ANSWER TO QUESTION 5

- This page shows the recommended list of nine items.
- It might be very complicated to make a comparison between this list and how the learner has actually responded.

Designing a Closing Quiz

Having looked at the opening quiz in some detail, let's look at the type of closing quiz you could develop. This is best done once you have designed the rest of the course material, so it may be one of the last tasks you complete.

Again let's use the Managing Meetings course as an example. If you look at Resource 5 you will see an example of a closing quiz.

Let's go through the pages in more detail.

PAGE 1 – WELCOME TO THE QUIZ

- This tells the learner what's going to happen, and invites them to complete the quiz.
- There's no need to repeat the ground rules used for the earlier quiz, unless something has changed.

PAGE 2 – QUESTION 1

- This question asks the learner to list a maximum of seven items.
- On this occasion there are no 'right' answers – just a recommended list.

PAGE 3 – QUESTION 2

- This question tests recall on a specific discussion point.
- It asks the learner to enter a number in each of three % boxes.
- The three numbers must add up to 100 per cent.

PAGE 4 – QUESTION 3

- This question asks the learner to enter the names of the steps in the appropriate boxes.

PAGE 5 – QUESTION 4

- This question asks the learner to enter five facilitation techniques in the boxes.

PAGE 6 – QUESTION 5

- This question asks the learner to click and drag the 'format' boxes to the appropriate 'meeting' boxes.

Having asked the questions, you need to comment on how the learner has responded. So the learning system needs to be able to record the learner's responses and be able to display them at an appropriate moment.

Let's continue looking at this sample closing quiz to see how the story could unfold. As before, the comments relate to the pages in Resource 5.

If the results are below a certain, pre-determined level you may wish to direct the learner to go back into the course and repeat a particular section again.

PAGE 7 – ANSWER TO QUESTION 1

- This page shows the list of seven recommended items for an effective agenda and invites the learner to compare it with his/her response.
- Refer the learner to the specific section in the course covering this aspect.

PAGE 8 – ANSWER TO QUESTION 2

- This page shows the learner's response alongside the recommended percentages.
- If the learner has proposed different percentages, refer them to the appropriate section of the course.

PAGE 9 – ANSWER TO QUESTION 3

- This page shows the suggested headings underneath the recommended choices.
- If the learner has chosen differently, refer them to the appropriate section of the course.

PAGE 10 – ANSWER TO QUESTION 4

- This page shows the learner's response alongside the recommended answers.
- If the learner has chosen differently, refer them to the appropriate section of the course.

PAGE 11 – ANSWER TO QUESTION 5

- This page shows the recommended allocation of report formats to meeting types.
- If the learner has chosen differently, refer them to the appropriate section of the course.

4. Who Will See the Results?

Having designed the quizzes in detail you must now consider who will actually see the results and how they will be used. This topic can become quite a hot one, and you may quickly expose a wide range of views around the planning team.

No doubt there will also be lots of discussion about which 'results' are being considered. Are they solely the 'before' and 'after' quiz results, or any other measurable results generated during the e-learning course?

- Some will argue passionately that the results of the quizzes are there purely for the learner's benefit, to show them their level of knowledge before starting the course, and how effectively they're learning the new material.
- Others will argue that the results of the quizzes should be available to the professionals involved in designing and administering the e-learning courses, so that they can evaluate how effective the courses are, and which parts seem to be most challenging to learners, and so may need re-designing.
- This information also gives valuable data on the percentages of learners who abandon the course, the average time taken to complete the course, and a broader feel about the 'take up' of e-learning in different parts of the business.

Of course there are different cost implications for the two different approaches.

Learner's Use Only

If the quiz results are only to be made available to the learner, the learning management system will need to be able to store the results from each session and be able to display them again each time the learner logs-on to the system.

This will be especially important if the quiz results are to be used to help the learner select the most needed parts of the course.

Wider Publication

If the quiz results are to be given a wider publication, then there will be the need to transfer the data from the electronic learning system to the HR administration system. All this comes at a cost, not only for the software work, but also for people to be trained to administer the system and publish the results.

BLANK



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Chapter 8
Design the Course

- 1. Confirm the Overall Course Structure 76
- 2. Build Each Screen Using Text and Images 79
- 3. Maximize the Learner's Participation 83
- 4. Link to the Learner's Workbook 87

Chapter 8
Design the Course

1. Confirm the Overall Course Structure

Having settled the issues of the opening and closing quizzes, and any other form of delegate self-assessment, you are now ready to start designing the course itself.

When you discussed the Project Specification earlier in the program, the overall flow for the course will have been defined; Section 6 of the Project Specification lists the chapters [please refer to Resource 1 the sample Project Specification]. In addition, you may have used Section 7 to list the learning points, tasks, exercises, text, case studies etc, to bring the topic alive and ensure the learner achieves the required learning outcomes.

It's important to make time to review these initial plans before you start the detailed design work as ideas may have changed since they were first agreed. In these fast moving times companies undertake new initiatives or decide to conquer new markets, and your training materials will need to reflect these changed priorities.

Just as importantly, the course designer will need to make small changes to the content and flow of the course as each section is designed. The author of this report, for example, has made many small modifications to the overall flow as the manuscript has developed, recognizing the reality that new ideas come in once you start writing or designing anything.

It can be beneficial to develop a flow chart of the course as this helps:

- the course designer to explain to the client the route that learners will go through as they experience the course
- the course designer to stay on track as he or she gets involved in the detailed design
- the design team in the software house to understand how the various elements all relate together, and the links between individual storyboards.

The flow chart will start out quite simple, but may then become more complex as the course materials develop. Using our Managing Meetings course as an example we have shown, at Resource 6, a typical course flow chart. We haven't put all the detail on it otherwise it would become incredibly confusing, but let's walk through the main elements.

Welcome

- The learner enters the course at the Welcome page, then learns the Benefits of the course, before reaching the Course Overview.
- The Course Overview lists the chapters and enables the learner to discover more about each chapter.
- Having read the overview for each chapter, the learner can go directly to the chapter to start work, or return to the Course Overview.
- The final option from the Course Overview is to go to the Opening Quiz.

Opening Quiz

We have shown the results of the Opening Quiz being placed in a Store, so that the results can be:

- referred to during the relevant chapter. As you reach a learning point that was used during the Opening Quiz you can remind the learner of their answer and then build upon it, whether they chose the 'right' answer or not
- used to redirect a learner to a part of the course they seem to have struggled with
- accumulated towards an overall record of achievement which tracks and reports on individual learners, or simply collect statistics for overall course usage. You may wish to refer back to Chapter 6, Section 4.

Chapters

- Having been through the preliminaries the learner goes to the chosen Chapter and starts working through the learning material. We'll look at how this can be designed later in this chapter.
- At the end of each chapter there is normally a summary and an invitation to do some action planning whilst the topic is fresh in the mind.

- It's useful to have links to the learner's workbook throughout the chapters, to reinforce key messages, or to involve the learner in practical tasks which require them to record ideas or results.
- Finally, having completed the chapter the learner has three choices – to return to the Course Overview to select another chapter, complete the Closing Quiz, or exit the course.

Closing Quiz

We have shown the results of the Closing Quiz being placed in a Store, so that the results can be:

- used to redirect a learner to a part of the course they seem to have struggled with
- accumulated towards an overall record of achievement which tracks and reports on individual learners, or simply collect statistics for overall course usage.

Having completed the Closing Quiz the learner is invited to do some final action planning, before exiting the course.

Closing Action Plans

- Before finally exiting the course the learner is encouraged to review the learning points that they have amassed and ensure they are recorded in the workbook.
- Also the learner may learn more about what comes next, for example, if there's a trainer-led course they can attend to practise their skills.
- There may also be a reference to other sources, for example, books or video tapes/DVDs which can add to their fund of knowledge.

2. Build Each Screen Using Text and Images

You are now at the point when you can begin to design each individual screen which will comprise the actual course material. Within each chapter you will have agreed the specific learning points the learner needs to understand to ensure the overall learning objectives are met.

This is where we come to one of the major differences between e-learning and a trainer-led course.

- A trainer working with a group of delegates gets continuous feedback on how well they are grasping the ideas or concepts being presented. A good trainer will respond to this feedback by inserting additional ideas or models to help overcome any blocks or barriers they see.
- With e-learning this cannot easily be achieved without inserting regular tests or assessments – which can be tiresome for the learner. What you see is what you get.

This places a heavy burden on the course designer to ensure that the learning material is comprehensive and makes no assumptions about the learner's current level of knowledge or their mental capability. So each screen of information needs to lead naturally to the next, drawing the learner through a logical, developing story.

There are two distinct and interrelated design issues here and, for the sake of simplicity, we will look at them separately.

- The first issue is to decide *what* actual information, either in terms of text or graphics, you wish to present to your learner.
- The second, critical issue is to decide *how* the information is to be presented. If the presentation style lacks creativity or is too passive, the learner will quickly lose interest.

Deciding *What* Information to Include

To make it easier to follow the design process we have given some sample screens in Resource 7. These are purely for illustrative purposes to show what can be done – you will need to design your own within the design constraints you will be working with.

- Sample screen 1 displays the main benefits of completing the course which should motivate the learner to want to get started.

- Sample screen 2 shows the learner the total course and, by clicking on any line, they get a more detailed breakdown of that module. This screen can also show which modules they have completed.
- Sample screen 3 shows the learner what they can expect to learn in Chapter 1, and then gives them options.

Referring to the Managing Meetings course again, the outline contents for Chapter 1, which is all about planning and preparation, are:

- Do you need a meeting? The learner explores the options available.
- Setting SMART objectives. The learner knows how to apply SMART to the meeting's goals.
- Planning a meeting. The learner learns the value of planning.
- Challenging invitations. The learner knows how to ensure that only essential people attend the meeting.
- Mind Mapping. The learner explores the value of Mind Maps for planning and discussion.
- Effective agendas. The learner knows how to draft an effective agenda.
- Managing the venue. The learner knows how to manage the venue for best effect.

Looking through this list one can quickly see that some items are self explanatory, for example, understanding SMART, whilst others are pretty vague at the moment, such as 'The learner learns the value of planning.' So the first step in designing the course is to specify *exactly* what information to include on each screen for every chunk of the course design.

As usual there's a balance:

- Too much information …and the average learner may lose interest. Remember also that each chapter has a target time for completion.
- Too little information …and the learner may not have enough to understand the topic thoroughly.

Let's focus on one of the early topics – do you need a meeting? The course designers decided that a supplementary topic should also be addressed: when is it best to hold a meeting?

Having reviewed all the information which could be displayed, they decided to include the following options for each of these two questions.

Do you really need this meeting? The alternative approaches include:

- Appointing project team leaders with full authority to deliver a specific result, so minimizing the degree of consultation required.
- Delegating ownership of the problem or issue, so reducing the number of people who need to be involved in decision making.
- Video conferencing. This enables many people to contribute to a multi-site discussion with the minimum amount of travel and disruption to normal work.
- Sharing experiences, facts and results by conventional materials and high-tech solutions such as virtual teams, electronic mail, or voicebox systems.
- Asking people to complete questionnaires or other data-gathering instruments to minimize fact finding meetings.
- Using telephones, mobile phones, pagers and fax machines more adventurously.
- Having flexible seating arrangements so that people can sit in informal teams for the duration of a project or assignment.

And for the second question, when is it best to hold a meeting? They suggested:

- Solving complex problems or issues
- Sharing ideas or experience
- Developing teamwork
- Gaining people's commitment to a plan or course of action
- Assessing performance and discussing improvement
- Fact finding
- Reaching negotiated agreements
- Critical personal events, for example, discussing individual performance, awards, job selection and discipline.

You can quickly realize that what may appear in the Project Specification as a one-liner may eventually develop into a lot of material which all has to be planned, designed and reviewed. At this stage in the design process you need to go through the Project Specification, line by line, deciding exactly what information to share with the learner.

Deciding *How* to Present it

Once you have confirmed the content you must then decide how to present your information, and there are some Golden Rules to follow. If you think of the guidelines you would follow for designing visual aids to accompany a presentation, you won't go far wrong.

Using Text

- Don't have too much text on any screen or it looks very 'busy' and may turn the learner off.
- Use large sized fonts so the course doesn't become an eyesight test.
- Limit the number of different fonts and ideally use one. Is there a corporate standard?
- Use the stronger font colors, and again you may have to adhere to corporate standards.
- Be careful with contrasting colors, especially red and green, as color blind people will find them difficult to read.

Using Images

- A picture tells a thousand words so they say, but ensure it's the right picture!
- Ensure every image has a positive learning point – avoid using images just because they are funky or striking.
- Ensure images can't inadvertently offend people – what may be fun to you may cause embarrassment or offence in others.
- Don't have too many visual gimmicks – they quickly tire and start to distract the learner's attention away from the learning points.

Blend of Text and Images

- Some form of blend of text with images is probably going to give the best learning transfer.
- Look for variety in the way you present your text and images to keep the learner interested and alert.

Graphs and Charts

Follow all the usual rules about presenting information about figures and growth rates, for example:

- For most people a pie-chart or a bar-chart will have more impact than a table of figures – especially when coupled with appropriate use of color.

3. Maximize the Learner's Participation

An important aspect of designing e-learning that we've stressed all the way through is to keep each and every learner interested. Although you may find your own topic interesting you can't assume that everyone who starts the course will share your enthusiasm.

So how can we do it? Let's look at a real example and see how the designers for Managing Meetings dealt with it. It's not our intention to go through the design of this particular course, screen by screen, but just select examples of different approaches you might wish to consider using.

We looked at one of the opening sections in Chapter 1, which was: Do you need a meeting? It would have been easy to just list the recommended options but the designers decided instead to involve the learner more actively.

The designers actually used three screens to cover this particular topic and, if you look at Resource 7, you can see how this topic was explored.

The learner starts this section by seeing Screen 4 – do we really need this meeting?

This screen involves the learner right at the start by asking them to consider two important questions and input some ideas onto the screen using their keyboard.

Having clicked to continue, the learner then sees Screen 5 – do we really need this meeting? This screen follows-up by offering a number of alternatives to holding a meeting, then asks the learner to compare this list with theirs.

Once they click to continue, the learner sees Screen 6 which offers some ideas about when it's best to hold a meeting. It offers eight ideas, then asks the learner to compare this list with theirs.

By the time the learner has covered these three screens they should have confirmed the value of their own original ideas, and added one or two new options they may not have previously considered.

Practical Tips

Earlier we discussed some of the methods you can use to keep the learner interested, and now we'll share some more with you. These are intended purely to give an idea of what you can do. The main limitations are:

- your own creativity
- the budget – some great ideas will suck up large amounts of money, but will add little value to the learning power of the course
- technology – improvements in learning management systems are constantly widening the horizons [but at a price!]
- time – always keep an eye on how long the modules will take to work through.

These methodologies are all listed for easy reference in Resource 8, Learning Options.

Enter Answers to Specific Questions

- You pose a specific question and ask the learner to enter their responses on the screen.
- The next screen will show the 'right' answer, and ask the learner to reflect on any differences between the responses.
- Please look at Resource 7, sample screens 7 and 8 for an example.

Simple Display of Text and Images

- For many screens you can simply show the key text, together with any appropriate images.
- This will convey the learning points in a clear way.
- Try to avoid too many 'runs' of this type of display or the learner may lose interest.

Audio Demonstration

- You use an audio demonstration and ask the learner to choose between several options.
- For example, sample screen 9 asks the learner to decide which of the three phrases was spoken assertively, which was aggressive and which was passive.
- The learner clicks and drags the box to the number.
- Sample screen 10 shows the 'right' answer.

Another excellent use for this technique is to show how fast to speak when you're giving a presentation. The voiceover repeats the same paragraph at different speeds, and the learner chooses which is the most appropriate.

Rearrange a List of Options

- You present the learner with a list of options or actions and invite them to decide which order they would choose.
- For example, sample screen 11 asks the learner to decide how they would deal with a disruptive person at a meeting, by rearranging the options into their preferred sequence.
- The next screen, sample screen 12, shows the recommended order compared with the learner's choice.

Case Studies

- You introduce a person or team who are faced with a task and give sufficient background information to enable the learner to make informed judgements.
- Then you introduce a number of alternative approaches and ask the learner to decide which is most appropriate.
- It can be particularly helpful if you use one or a series of case studies which continue throughout the course which you can refer to periodically to illustrate specific learning points.
- This approach is particularly useful if you are designing an in-house program, as you can select case studies which are industry-specific.

Simulated Conversations

- The learner overhears several versions of a conversation and has to decide which is the most appropriate for the given situation.
- The subsequent screen would reveal the recommended way and discuss its merits.
- For example, you may wish to show the various ways the Chairperson of a meeting could deal with a sensitive issue. The learner would hear a voiceover demonstrating several ways of dealing with the topic and would rank the options.
- If the learner picks the less effective options they can be directed to a short audio clip which demonstrates why that approach is less effective.

Video Clips

- The underlying approach is similar to simulated conversation but, in addition to the voiceover, the learner also watches a short video clip which demonstrates the variety of approaches.
- The subsequent screen would reveal the recommended way, and discuss its merits.
- If the learner picks the less effective options they can be directed to a short video clip which demonstrates why that approach is less effective.
- This approach is very flexible and realistic but also costs significantly more to develop.

Animations

- Creative use of diagrams or cartoons to bring otherwise dull or complex issues to life.
- Can be useful, for example, to build-up a complex diagram of a piece of equipment or plant, from initial outline to the full picture.
- The learner can see how the component parts of a complex machine move together to operate effectively.
- Another way is to develop a 'route map' showing how the learner can progress through a variety of steps to reach an end goal. For example, showing how a project team works through key steps to manage a complex project.

4. Link to the Learner's Workbook

A further way you can keep the learner actively involved is to ask them to undertake tasks in the workbook which accompanies the e-learning course. You will recall that we discussed the merits of having a learner's workbook in Chapter 6, and you can find an example of the workbook that could accompany the Managing Meetings course in Resource 3.

To illustrate how this works, we've shown how the designers incorporated this type of activity to SMART goals or objectives. Working through Chapter 1, the learner is introduced to the concept of SMART goals or objectives – please look at sample Screen 13 in Resource 7.

The learner then works through a series of screens which explore the SMART concept in more detail until they arrive at the summary screen, see sample screen 14. But, in addition to summarizing the SMART concept, this screen also invites the learner to undertake the following task:

- Having now looked at SMART objectives I would like you to consider a meeting you are planning and write down your SMART objectives. Please copy the results into your workbook.

You can see at sample page 15 in Resource 7 the equivalent page of the learner's workbook, which mirrors sample screen 14.

The Managing Meetings Workbook

It's worth taking a few minutes to look at the workbook which could accompany the Managing Meetings course and see that in this example:

- seven pages *Reinforce* ideas from the e-learning course.
- six pages *Involve* the learner in active participation.

This particular example of a learner's workbook comprises:

- Front cover.
- Page 1 – *Reinforce*. Welcomes the learner to the course.
- Page 2 – *Reinforce* the definition of a meeting.
- Page 3 – *Involve*. Invites the learner to set SMART goals for an upcoming meeting.
- Page 4 – *Involve*. Asks the learner to challenge the need for everyone to attend an upcoming meeting.
- Page 5 – *Involve*. Asks the learner to practise using a Mind Map.

- Page 6 – *Reinforce*. The key steps in an effective meeting.
- Page 7 – *Reinforce*. The steps for using Cause and Effect Analysis.
- Pages 8 and 9 – *Reinforce*. Details seven key facilitation skills.
- Page 10 – *Involve*. Invites the learner to practise using Sunflower Analysis.
- Page 11 – *Involve*. Asks the learner to plan the most effective form of documentation for a meeting.
- Page 12 – *Reinforce*. Suggests an action planning template to use after a meeting.
- Page 13 – *Involve*. Gives a personal action planning page for the learner to use after the course.

This represents a reasonable balance between the needs of *Reinforcing* ideas from the e-learning course, and actively *Involving* the learner in meaningful tasks.

Now you have finished much of the hard work of designing the e-learning course, it's time to show your results to the project team and ask for their approval to go ahead with the more detailed design.



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Chapter 9
Project Review Meetings

- 1. When to Hold Project Review Meetings 90
- 2. Review the E-learning Course Content 91
- 3. Hand Over the Storyboards to the Software Designers 93
- 4. Pilot the E-learning Course 93
- 5. Review the Trainer-led Course Design 94
- 6. Pilot the Trainer-led Course 95
- 7. Review the Effectiveness of the Whole Program 96

Chapter 9
Project Review Meetings

1. When to Hold Project Review Meetings

During the design process there will be lots of informal progress review meetings to iron out immediate issues and concerns, but there will also be several occasions throughout the project lifecycle when more formal review meetings are essential.

The meetings should bring together all the key project stakeholders and give them the opportunity to comment on progress to date before any further work starts. This can avoid time-consuming and expensive redesign work later in the project.

There are at least six critical moments when you might consider holding a formal review meeting:

1. Once the content of the e-learning course has been designed, but before work starts on the storyboards.
2. On completion of designing the storyboards – this meeting can be used to formally hand the storyboards over to the software designers.
3. After piloting the actual e-learning courseware, but before the course is offered on 'general release' to the target audience.
4. On completion of designing the trainer-led course, and prior to the pilot event.
5. After piloting the trainer-led course, but before the course is offered on 'general release' to the target audience.
6. Some months after general release of both the e-learning and trainer-led course to assess the overall effectiveness of the whole initiative.

It can be helpful to record the main action points which are discussed during the review meetings in a Project Status Report, such as you can find at Resource 9. Documenting these discussions and agreements reduces the opportunity for 'misunderstandings' about exactly what was agreed, and who undertook to take action on specific points.

2. Review the E-learning Course Content

A review meeting at this early stage gives the stakeholders the opportunity to evaluate:

- the course flow chart, which sets out the route that learners will follow
- the detailed learning points, and the way they are portrayed screen by screen
- the learner's workbook, so they can see the relationship with the on-line materials
- the way the learning management system will store, process and report on progress learners are making with the course.

The best way to do this is to demonstrate the screens on a computer so that people can get a feel for what the information will look like and, as best you can, to simulate any animations or interactive parts. It's also helpful to give everyone a hard copy of the screen images on which they can make their own notes.

This meeting is also a valuable opportunity to check out with the project champion, and other key stakeholders, if there have been, or are likely to be, any changes in strategic direction which may affect the course content or where it sits in the portfolio of learning resources.

The project champion should be aware of impending changes or new initiatives which could have a major impact on the project. You need to know about these changes before any of the expensive work starts.

TOP TIP 5

Don't forget to pilot your content, ideally before it gets anywhere near a piece of software.

A valuable activity for this stage in the process is to try out the course materials on some typical delegates who form the target audience for the course. Obviously the course materials are not in their final format, but you will receive some very helpful feedback.

Here's how to simulate the 'real thing' as best you can at this stage of development.

- Do it in a one-to-one session, so have a typical learner working through the materials with the course designer.

- Starting with the course workbook allow the learner to familiarize themselves with its contents.
- Then ask them to start working through the planned on-line materials, going through each screen in turn.
- As you're testing the suitability of the on-screen material to be self explanatory, the course designer should only comment if the learner is obviously unable to grasp the learning points. This can be very difficult as the natural tendency is to comment or expand on the course materials.
- The most you can do is simulate the intended voice over for each screen.
- The course designer will also need to act the part of the learning management system, telling them what will happen at different stages of the course. For example, you might say to them: "If you click Continue at this point you will jump to page XX, so let's go there and see what happens then."
- As they work through the course you should note any areas which seem to be confusing or where the flow could be improved, and seek the learner's comments on what they think should be different.
- Keep an eye on timings – it will give you an idea of how long the course will take to complete.
- At the end of each session summaries your notes and ask the learner for any additional comments or suggestions.

Once the materials have been tried on a selected group of delegates you can then take stock of all their comments and decide how the course materials need to be improved. Their comments will typically:

- Show where the flow needs to be changed. Simply rearranging the order of some screens may make the materials easier to understand, or for a topic to 'come alive' more
- Tell you where you need to insert additional screens because, perhaps, the concepts are not sufficiently well explained. You may have made assumptions about people's knowledge or understanding
- Show you which screens are redundant and can be removed.
- Give you some idea about how interesting they found the materials, and which parts need to be injected with additional interest or participation
- Indicate how successful the overall course is in equipping them with additional skills or confidence.

3. Hand Over the Storyboards to the Software Designers

The next critical point when a formal review meeting is essential is when you are ready to hand over the storyboards to the software designers for them to start converting your ideas into software in the chosen electronic learning management system.

The storyboards, and the associated documentation such as the course flow chart, constitute your contract with the software house and so it has to be right. Remember that changes after this stage tend to become more expensive.

This meeting could well be lengthy as you may need to discuss some or all of the following topics.

- Start with the 'big picture' – discuss any changes to strategic direction which may have an impact on your project.
- Go through the storyboards item by item, explaining how you want each screen to appear and function.
- Discuss the learner's workbook – how can you ensure the style and images are consistent with the e-learning course materials?
- Discuss how learners will access the e-learning, and the interface with existing internal IT systems if appropriate.
- Look at the way the learning management system will store, process and report on the progress learners are making with the course.
- Discuss timescales for completing the design work and the planned 'go live' date.
- Address any changes to the budget.

4. Pilot the E-learning Course

On or before the due date the software designers will present you with the complete e-learning course. It's a good idea to pilot this before making it available to the wider target audience.

- This will give you valuable feedback on how people reacted to the course materials in their final form.
- It will also tell you how 'user friendly' the target audience found the electronic learning management system.

- You will also learn how fast or slow your existing IT network is, and the amount of frustration learners sometime suffer if the network is slow.
- This may highlight the need to upgrade the IT services to certain sites or locations if e-learning is to become popular and widely accepted.
- Depending on how much you incorporate the course into your existing IT system you may also collect valuable feedback on how effective the learning management system is in tracking individual learners, as well as collecting overall statistics.

After trying out the courseware on a selected group of learners at a representative number of sites, you should hold the next project review meeting when all of these topics can be discussed. If you've done the earlier reviews thoroughly then the number of changes resulting from these pilot events should be small and therefore not too costly.

In addition to the results of the pilots, you will need to review the other topics listed in Section 8.3 above.

5. Review the Trainer-led Course Design

For many topics an e-learning course is a superb way of enabling learners to acquire knowledge or understanding about the subject – but don't lose sight of the fact that they only have the theory. If they need to acquire practical skills, learners will need to practise them.

So for many topics you may decide to schedule a short, trainer-led course after people have finished their e-learning. In most cases a well-designed, one-day course will give a small number of delegates sufficient practise to consolidate their e-learning.

If this is the case, then the next review meeting should be scheduled to approve the design of the trainer-led course, together with all the supporting materials and documentation, prior to the pilot event being held.

The extra items for the agenda of this review meeting include:

- Look at the links to the e-learning course.
- Is the balance of time on the various elements appropriate?
- Are the content and images consistent with the e-learning course?

- What additional visual aids may be required?
- How effectively does the course workbook tie into the e-learning course?
- Review the planned schedule for the course.
- Who will deliver the course and what training will they require?
- How will you identify delegates to attend?

6. Pilot the Trainer-led Course

Another key stage for a formal progress review meeting is when you've held the pilot trainer-led course. The topics for discussion could include:

- delegates' comments and feedback
- trainer's comments and suggestions for improvement
- the pace, timings, contents and flow
- was there too much/too little in the day?
- did the course reinforce the e-learning sufficiently?

Now that the two key components, the e-learning and the trainer-led course, have been piloted and finalized, you can also use this meeting to consider the wider launch of the whole training program. No doubt you will have already discussed how the courses will be offered to the target population and how nominations will be accepted, processed and recorded.

This will also trigger further discussions on the logistics once the program builds a reputation and people start to enlist for the e-learning course and, subsequently, the trainer-led course.

7. Review the Effectiveness of the Whole Program

When we started out on this journey we proposed that the whole e-learning experience should be seen as a three-part process:

1. **Grasp the Theory**. Learners undertake a self-study e-learning course, supported by other learning resources, for example, books or videos.
2. **Practise the Skills**. Learners come together with colleagues to practise their skills in a short, intensive trainer-led course.
3. **Apply the learning**. Learners apply their new knowledge and skills to reach new levels of business performance, supported by on-line coaching.

Coming out of the last review meeting outlined in paragraph 6 above, the program can swing into full production, with learners completing both the e-learning and trainer-led courses. After a few months it will be essential to review how much has actually changed in terms of business performance, once they have time to use their new skills in real situations.

This is where we can reinforce the final Top Tip as presented in the Introduction:

TOP TIP 6

Finally, how will you measure the project's success? Seems a simple enough question, but it's all too seldom not asked!

Although this is the moment to explore how successful the whole program has been, a well organized project team will have decided the success criteria many months earlier, so that relevant data can be collected from the very start of the initiative.

Many years ago, when the author first became involved in Quality Management Systems, he was amazed by the huge manuals that always seem to be created. Overcome by the sheer volume of material he was expected to become familiar with he asked one of the experts what the underlying principles were.

The expert said that any good Quality Management System would help you to do three main things:

1. **Say what you do.** Develop a clear, written statement of exactly what you intend to do.

2. **Do what you say.** Put in place the people, equipment, materials, tools, training and other resources to enable you to do what you said you would do.
3. **Prove it.** Take consistent and reliable measures which prove that you do what you said you would do – first time, every time.

So once people have completed both parts of the formal training and have applied their skills and perhaps received some coaching, you can look back and confirm what's actually changed.

This will be helpful for this program as you can change or tweak parts to make it even more effective. But it will also help you for the future as you start to develop other e-learning programs.

BLANK



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Chapter 10
Building the Storyboards

- 1. Why have Storyboards? 100
- 2. How to Build the Storyboards 103
- 3. In Summary… 108

Chapter 10
Building the Storyboards

1. Why have Storyboards?

The project is about to reach a critical stage – when it is handed over to the software design team to transform your creative ideas into stimulating, enjoyable and productive electronic learning, using the magic of an electronic learning system.

To enable all the detail of the learning points, together with the 'flavor' of the course to be accurately translated, the software designers will require a detailed briefing on each and every screen that needs to be created.

This is done by designing a suite of storyboards, much like a film company use to explain the development of the plot in a movie. So the final stage in development is to convert all the individual screens into their equivalent storyboards. For our one-hour Meetings Skills courses there will probably be about 120 separate screens.

In addition to the storyboards, the software designers will also need the course flow chart to enable them to confirm the route the learner needs to take through the material.

Much earlier in the design process you will have agreed the format to be used for the Storyboards – we discussed this earlier in Chapter 3, Section 4. The first page of Resource 10 shows the outline format for the proposed storyboard which needs to be simple, comprehensive and user friendly for the software designer.

Make no mistake the storyboard is, in effect, the contract you have with the software designer – the quality of the final course will be a reflection of the quality of the storyboards.

Let's go through each element in more detail.

Storyboard Header

This is at the top of the page and tells the software designer some key information about this particular screen.

Screen Number

- The screen number 0001 shows this is the first in the package. The numbers will initially run sequentially to the end of the course, although you can add or delete screens later if you wish.
- If you're adding a screen after '1021' simply make it '1021a' – if you're deleting a screen, simply drop the number.
- Each storyboard will have its own unique number which enables the designer to locate every screen in the course.

Chapter Title

- The chapter titles help identify where you are in the course.
- It will normally appear in the border along the top of the screen.
- The first screen in the example is in the 'Welcome chapter'.

Screen Title

- The title of this particular screen is the 'Welcome page' and again this would normally appear in the top border of the learner's screen.

The Screen Image

The next box down in the storyboard shows the designer the required screen image – let's look at this in more detail.

- The main requirement is to clearly illustrate what the learner should see on this screen. This is much easier with a picture instead of trying to describe what you want.
- You should show images and any text, together with the relative positions you would like to achieve.
- If you use PowerPoint you can show a certain amount of animation, or how the images should develop.

Having defined what the learner should see, and the broad parameters you want to apply, you must now leave the software designer to interpret the screen within the technical limitations of the learning system.

This is why it's so important to have a good working relationship between the course designers and the software designers.

The Description

The next box down is the description which tells the software designer some other important information.

- What should happen with the text and images and with timings and sequences.
- What the learner should be able to do whilst at that screen.
- And what they should not be able to do.
- How the learning system should react to the learner's inputs.
- Where they go next when they leave this screen.
- If any information needs to be stored, when it will be required again and in what format.

We explored in detail the variety of available options in Chapter 7, Sections 2, 3 and 4 so this is where you get to exercise your creative flair!

The Voice-over

The final box on the storyboard gives details of any voice-over that's required. It's not mandatory to have a voice-over but it certainly helps the learner to stay interested in what's happening. It adds a further dimension to the learning experience.

Remember though that the voice-over shouldn't contain any information not on the screen as it's quite possible that many learners will switch the voice-over 'off'. They may be in a noisy environment, or a quiet one where the distraction of the voice-over would be quite unwelcome.

What's the ideal speed for the voice-over speech? About 140 to 150 words per minute.

The voice-over box tells the voice-over artist[s]:

- what to say
- how the words should be coordinated with changes on the screen
- specific instructions about tone of voice, pace, emphasis, pauses etc
- the author has usually added some extra advice to the voice-over artist along the lines of:

  Please feel free to make small changes to the language or words to make the voice-over more natural, without changing the meaning or substance of the course.

2. How to Build the Storyboards

Let's walk through a few screens of the Managing Meetings course – you can find these at the first few pages of Resource 10.

Screen 0001

STORYBOARD HEADER

- Number 0001.
- Welcome chapter.
- Welcome screen.

THE SCREEN IMAGE

- This shows the opening course title and a simple graphic.

DESCRIPTION

- Learner clicks the 'next' button to enter the course – go to 0002
- Images – people holding a meeting

VOICE-OVER

"Welcome to this module on managing meetings. To enable you to get the best from the course you should have a copy of the course workbook handy. This provides a reminder of the main learning points, and somewhere to write your responses to some of the tasks. It also gives you somewhere to build up your action plan as you go through the course."

Screen 0002

Having done the first screen you can now turn to the next one and repeat the process. Please see Resource 10 (0002. Welcome. Benefits).

STORYBOARD HEADER

- Number 0002.
- Welcome chapter.
- Benefits screen.

THE SCREEN IMAGE

This shows the benefits of completing the course and hopefully at least one, and possible several, will appeal to the learner.

DESCRIPTION

- Learner clicks 'yes' button to continue – go to 0003.

VOICE-OVER

"You may feel pretty confident about the way you manage meetings, but just read this page – it won't take more than a few minutes. If just one of the ideas could benefit you, then it will be worth the hour or so it will take you to work through the course."

Pause for five seconds.

"Click 'Continue' and we'll start the journey."

CONTINUE THROUGH THE COURSE

You get the idea. There are no short cuts – it's a screen by screen job, requiring intense concentration to detail that requires constantly checking where the learner needs to go to next and signposting it clearly for the software designer.

Other Examples

To make this chapter more varied let's look at some examples from courses on other topics.

Screen 0023

This storyboard is from a course on stress and shows how the format can be used to create a different effect.

STORYBOARD HEADER

- Number 0023.
- Chapter 1.
- Pressure and stress.

THE SCREEN IMAGE

- This shows the words 'Pressure' and 'Stress' with some linking text.

DESCRIPTION

- Start with 'We often hear…'
- Text animation – dissolve in the word 'pressure'

- Add 'and'
- Then stretch outwards the word 'stress' [like an elastic band stretching]
- Add 'as though they…'
- Learner clicks 'next' – go to 0024

VOICE-OVER

"We often hear people talk about pressure and stress as though they're the same. But are they?"

Screen 0033

Let's look at another example – you can find in Resource 10 (0033. Chapter 3. How stressed are you?). This screen links back to a question in the opening quiz for this particular course.

STORYBOARD HEADER

- Number 0033
- Chapter 3.
- How stressed are you?

THE SCREEN IMAGE

- Linking text with a formula: Event + Response = Outcome.

DESCRIPTION

Build the text in four steps:

1. Start with heading and opening paragraph.
2. Then bring in 'Do you recall…?'
3. Then show the formula.
4. Finally show 'Please click on…'
    - Learner clicks: Event – go to 0034
    - Learner clicks: Response – go to 0035
    - Learner clicks: Outcome – go to 0036

VOICE-OVER

"Do you remember this formula from the opening quiz"

[Pause]

"It reminds us that, whilst we may have limited control over what happens to us, we should be able to control the way we respond to those events.

And it's our response which determines the outcomes we get. Two people can experience exactly the same event but get totally different outcomes because they handle the situation differently.

This course will help you to adopt more appropriate responses to stressful events."

Screen 0065

Let's look at another example – you can find this in Resource 10 (0065. Chapter 4. Breathing properly 3).

This demonstration shows the learner what relaxed breathing really feels like. You can see how the various parts of the storyboard enable the software designer and the voiceover artist to coordinate their efforts to produce a slick performance.

STORYBOARD HEADER

- Number 0065
- Chapter 4.
- Breathing properly 3 [this is the third screen on this topic].

THE SCREEN IMAGE

Mixture of text and images as shown.

DESCRIPTION

- Open with the heading.
- Pause one second – reveal text 'Ready? First of all…. …press the button.'
- Learner clicks 'Go'.
- Reveal text 'Now breathe in deeply…' then these items separated by one second pauses – 'one', 'two', 'three', 'four', 'five', text 'Pause. Now breathe out…', 'one', 'two', 'three', 'four' and 'five'.

- Pause three seconds then reveal text 'Now you know the …'
- Learner clicks: Next – go to 0066

VOICE-OVER

"Not sure what six breaths per minute is like? Then try this exercise."

Pause: *"Ready? First of all breathe out. Now press the 'Go' button and breathe in deeply for a count of five. Watch the screen to get the timing."*

Pause: *"Now breathe out to a count of five – again watch the screen to see the timing."*

Pause: *"All done? Now you know what six breaths per minute feels like. So repeat it for ten minutes."*

Pause: *"Do that regularly and you will feel more relaxed."*

Screen 0103

Let's now look at an example of another demonstration – you can find this in Resource 10 (0103. Chapter 4. Visualization 4).

STORYBOARD HEADER

- Number 0103.
- Chapter 4.
- Visualization 4 [this is the fourth screen on this topic].

THE SCREEN IMAGE

Steps explaining how to do the visualization.

DESCRIPTION

Learner clicks next – go to 0104

VOICE-OVER

[Instruction for the voice-over artist. Slow your voice and keep it at a soft, low pitch. Pause for at least five seconds between lines to allow them sufficient time to visualize something, and then time to experience it.]

"Walk down the path until you see a hedge with a gate in it.

Open the gate and walk through.

Take your shoes off.

Walk through the soft green grass of a meadow.

See the waving red poppies blowing in the breeze.

Smell the fresh air.

Feel a soft warm breeze on your body.

There is a bright blue sky above.

Feel the warmth of the sun, relaxing your muscles.

Walk towards a shallow bubbling stream."

3. In Summary…

These examples have hopefully shown you the general approach to take when designing the storyboards. When you're working with your own materials you will quickly get a feel for what works and develop your own style and approach.

It's essential to develop a good working relationship with the software designers so that they feel comfortable about ringing you to confirm: "On page 1147 you say you want us to do… Do you really mean that?"

Designing the storyboards is intense, tiring work and you will make mistakes in logic or detail however hard you try not to. So allow plenty of time for proof reading and, ideally, ask someone who has not had any contact with the project to read it for you. They will see errors and omissions much better than you ever will!



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Chapter 11
The Trainer-led Course

- 1. Establish the Project Team....110
- 2. Some Challenges....110
- 3. Identify the Key Skills to be Practised....112
- 4. Agree the Duration of the Course....113
- 5. The Optimum Number of Delegates....113
- 6. Agree the Key Milestones in Terms of Dates and Deliverables....114
- 7. Finalize the Budget....114

Chapter 11
The Trainer-led Course

1. Establish the Project Team

You have now reached another key stage in the project when you start designing the trainer-led course to accompany the e-learning course. The starting point is to set up the project team to plan and manage this phase of the project, and it could mainly be the team you established for the e-learning, with some additions and deletions. You may wish to refer back to the project team we outlined in Chapter 1, Section 4.

You might wish to add:

- someone experienced in designing trainer-led courses
- ideally the trainer who will deliver the pilot course[s]
- someone from the team who will administer the trainer-led courses.

You may not need:

- the software experts
- any internal IT representation.

2. Some Challenges

As we've discovered, there are many advantages to using blended training but, like everything in life, it's not all roses. There are certain potential challenges which you will need to be aware of, and prepare for.

Varied amount of preparation

Sadly not every learner will approach the Grasp the Theory phase [working through the e-learning course] with the same degree of motivation. Personal commitments, coupled with pressure at work or frustrations with the performance of the IT network, mean that your delegates will arrive with varying degrees of theoretical knowledge.

As delegates arrive for the course the trainer should reasonably expect that they have all completed the on-line course recently, and that their theoretical knowledge of the topic is fine. But no matter how many 'health warnings' appear in the Course Joining Instructions, typically the trainer can expect to find that in a group of eight delegates:

- only three or four people will have completed the on-line course fully
- perhaps three or four people will have completed most of the course, but with some gaps
- at least one person will have either attempted no more than 50 per cent of the course material, or studied the course so long ago that their recall of the content is poor.

Time Pressure

Any one-day Practise the Skills course is, by its nature, intensive and so every minute is precious.

Focus on the Essentials

The time pressure means that you only have time to focus on practising the skills which the learners have studied in Grasp the Theory. There is simply not sufficient time to introduce new theoretical concepts.

Model the Concepts

It is essential for the course trainer to model the concepts covered in the theoretical part of the learning or the delegates may be confused. This sounds obvious but it is not always easy, as trainers develop their own preferred styles and may not fully accept every element of the theory course.

Need to Talk

Working at a computer screen is a solo activity and the learner is deprived of the discussion and 'bouncing ideas' which they experience on a conventional course. So most delegates will arrive for the trainer-led course with some expectation that they will have time, however limited, for this.

3. Identify the Key Skills to be Practised

You started out in Chapter 1 taking an overview of the whole course and deciding which elements should be delivered in the e-learning course, and which topics should be part of the trainer-led course.

- Acquiring knowledge should be part of the e-learning course.
- Practising skills should be included in the trainer-led course.

It's always worth reviewing your initial ideas as things may have changed since you started the journey. For example, a topic which seemed ideal for the e-learning component may, based on peoples' feedback, appear to be something that would also benefit from some further work during the trainer-led course.

We also reminded you that, as you consider how each chunk of the course is to be delivered, you may be surprised by the variety of other resources you already have, including:

- books and training packs
- published articles
- video tapes
- DVDs
- audio tapes
- interactive videos
- computer-based training
- existing course designs and materials
- one-to-one discussions
- visits.

You won't necessarily use these resources during the trainer-led course, but you can recommend them to learners as additional sources of learning. The variety of learning styles in your target audience means, for example, that a video which interests one group may be a real turn off for others.

It's useful at this stage to decide which models, techniques or skills are critical for success and should therefore be reinforced in the *Practise the Skills* course. At this stage keep your mind open and just identify possible sessions for the course, recognizing that some of them may be dropped once you start to look at the time available.

4. Agree the Duration of the Course

In most cases, a one-day course should give sufficient time for delegates to practise their new skills and receive some meaningful feedback on their performance. This issue needs to be decided in relation to the number of delegates attending the course.

Let's look at a practical example. Most people will have attended a Presentation Skills course at some stage in their career, and the course was probably of two days duration with a maximum of eight delegates on the course.

- This format gives the equivalent of one-day spent exploring the theory, allowing each delegate to deliver three presentations during the rest of the course.
- By using e-learning to explore the theory you can reduce the trainer-led component to one-day and still allow time for meaningful skill enhancement.

In most cases one-day should be sufficient for what was previously a two-day course, otherwise there is no convincing reason for the expense of creating the e-learning component.

5. The Optimum Number of Delegates

To enable the duration to be limited to one-day you will need to keep the number of delegates down. As the numbers increase, the amount of individual attention each delegate receives obviously falls, so limiting the overall value of the experience.

- For this reason most courses will work best with a maximum of eight delegates.
- And what is your minimum number? It depends on the course content, but in most cases it might be four.

6. Agree the Key Milestones in Terms of Dates and Deliverables

At this early stage you will also need to look at some practical issues to ensure you have a successful event. One of the big advantages of e-learning is that learners can do it when they want, where they want, and spend as much time as they need. For the trainer-led course they must all be together, for the agreed duration, in one place.

So you will need to:

- book an appropriately sized and equipped venue
- ensure a suitably trained trainer is also available
- design the workbooks and trainer presentations
- confirm all your learners are also available.

Sounds easy – and it is, provided you do it early enough! Which is why you need the course administrator in the project team.

Remember also that this is the pilot course and you may need to make some changes, however small, before the course can be put on general release. This may be particularly important if you have a requirement to harmonize the course with some planned strategic initiative so, the sooner these dates are booked, the better.

If possible schedule a review meeting for the morning immediately after the pilot course. That way you get everyone together whilst the course is fresh in everyone's mind, and you don't lose any time preparing for the next course. It keeps the momentum going.

7. Finalize the Budget

Final item for the agenda – agree the budgets for the courses and the development work. Looking through the paragraphs above will trigger thoughts about the various provisions you need to make.

That's it. You should now be able to move into the next stage which is to design the trainer-led course.



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Chapter 12
Links to the E-learning Course

- 1. Linking the Two Learning Experiences.....116
- 2. Using a Refresher Quiz 116

Chapter 12
Links to the E-learning Course

1. Linking the Two Learning Experiences

It's vitally important to ensure that both components of the learning experience, the e-learning and the trainer-led course, are not only consistent but clearly linked so that they appear to be part of a continuous learning path. We've stressed all the way through the need to ensure that you use the same language, models, fonts, images, etc as these all reinforce a consistent approach.

Inevitably there will be a time delay between any particular person finishing the e-learning course and attending the trainer-led course, and that this elapsed time will vary from person to person. There are two easy ways you can link the two learning experiences together:

- use a Refresher Quiz during the course
- develop a delegate workbook for people to use during the course.

We'll explore delegate workbooks in more detail in Chapter 13.

2. Using a Refresher Quiz

Why use a Refresher Quiz?

In the last chapter we commented on some of the challenges faced as you design and then deliver a one-day trainer-led course following the on-line course. There are five key challenges.

1. **Varied amount of preparation**. Typically the trainer can expect to find that in a group of eight delegates, only three or four people will have completed the course fully whilst the rest will have varying amounts of knowledge.
2. **Time pressure**. The course is, by its nature, intensive and so every minute is precious.

3. **Focus on the essentials**. You only have time to focus on practising the skills which the learners have already studied.
4. **Model the concepts**. The course trainer must model the concepts covered in the theoretical part of the learning.
5. **Need to talk**. Delegates will arrive expecting that they will have time, however limited, to chat with others about the e-learning.

The one-day, trainer-led course timetable will be very busy so we strongly recommend using a Refresher Quiz early in the course as a mechanism for:

- overcoming these barriers
- refreshing the theoretical concepts presented in the on-line part of the program
- breaking the ice – encouraging strangers to talk to each other
- discussing any outstanding issues or concerns delegates may have
- helping the trainer to discover any potential barriers or individual learning needs before the day starts.

Designing a Refresher Quiz

Once you have accepted the concept of using a Refresher Quiz designing it is quite straightforward – if you follow these steps.

TIME

Start by deciding how much time you can allow for the session based around the quiz. We would recommend in total 45 minutes: 15 minutes for delegates to work through the questions with a partner, followed by 30 minutes discussion in the group facilitated by the trainer.

If you use more time than this you will start to seriously eat into the time available for practising the skills.

TOPICS

Then review the e-learning course and decide which are the main topics you need to refresh before you start the practice sessions.

A useful way to do this is using Post-it Notes as they give you flexibility and don't inhibit the flow of creative juices. Look through the e-learning course and jot on a Post-it Note every time you find a potentially useful question.

SELECT THE QUESTIONS

Select and discount possible questions from a list until you have the number you require. We recommend a maximum of ten questions for the available time, and accept that not everyone will answer all the questions. They are there mainly to prompt discussion.

WRITE THE ANSWERS

The final step is to write an answer sheet for the trainer to distribute following the group discussion.

PILOT THE REFRESHER QUIZ

Follow the good practice you established earlier and try the Refresher Quiz out on a typical group of people who have completed the e-learning course. Their feedback will be most helpful.

You can find an example of a Refresher Quiz, based on the Managing Meetings course, at Resource 11.

Using a Refresher Quiz

How should you use the Refresher Quiz during the course? We offer the following guidelines.

INTRODUCE THE QUIZ

- Stress that time is short and that you will not be able to discuss in detail the concepts presented in the on-line course.
- However, say it is useful to spend the first part of the day refreshing some of the underlying concepts.
- Ask delegates to select a partner, preferably someone they've not met previously.
- Once they have sat together give everyone their copy of the quiz and ask them to work through all the questions together.

DISCUSSION TIME

- As each partnership finishes the quiz give them copies of the suggested answers, and ask them to compare them with their responses.
- Once everyone has finished open a general discussion on the quiz.

- Stress that the 'suggested answers' are for guidance, and that the intended audiences for their presentation are the final jury on their effectiveness.
- Be prepared to discuss any topics which seem to spark discussion, **but keep an eye on the clock!**
- If someone has a specific topic they obviously wish to discuss in detail you may wish to say that you'll chat with them during the break.

BLANK



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Chapter 13
Design the Trainer-led Course

- 1. Develop an Overall Template for the Day 122
- 2. Design Individual Sessions in Detail 123
- 3. Design the Delegate Workbook 125
- 4. Write a Trainer's Guide 125
- 5. Create Supporting Materials 127
- 6. Draft a Venue Specification 127

Chapter 13
Design the Trainer-led Course

1. Develop an Overall Template for the Day

In Chapter 11 we looked at the main issues you need to consider before you are ready to design the one-day trainer-led course, and in Chapter 12 we looked at establishing links between the e-learning course and the trainer-led course.

In this chapter we'll look at all the issues involved in designing the trainer-led course – first we'll look at general principles, then see how they apply to our Managing Meetings course.

Template for the Day

Start by looking at the day overall and divide it into three main chunks:

1. **The start**. When you welcome people to the course, discuss objectives, and introduce the Refresher Quiz.
2. **The middle**. When delegates practise their skills.
3. **The end**. Time for action planning and close the course.

You could end up with a template something like this:

- Session 1 – Welcome. 9.00-9.45am.
- Session 2 – Refresher Quiz. 9.45-10.30am.
- Morning break. 10.30-10.45am.
- Session 3 – Skill practice 1. 10.45-12.00 noon.
- Session 4 – Skill practice 2. 12.00-1.00pm.
- Lunch. 1.00-1.45pm.
- Session 5 – Skill practice 3. 1.45-3.00pm.
- Afternoon break. 3.00-3.15pm.
- Session 6 – Skill practice 3.15-4.30pm.
- Session 7 – Action planning and close. 4.30-5.00pm.

Using this overall approach:

- will give you four skill practice sessions of about one hour each
- you can work at any time with two teams of four, with eight delegates on the course
- means that each delegate can act as Chairperson for a session during the day, and receive individual feedback on their performance.

Remember this is only a suggestion – you will need to adapt the general principles to your own situation.

2. Design Individual Sessions in Detail

Now you can design the detailed sessions to reinforce the learning points covered in the e-learning course, but remember:

- you don't need time to introduce the theory – that's already been done in *Grasp the Theory*
- don't introduce any new concepts or models – you haven't time and it will confuse people
- the precious time available should be devoted to practising the skills as realistically as possible, and to giving time for feedback from other delegates
- the overall objective is for delegates to leave the day feeling confident to use their new skills immediately.

Brainstorm the Possibilities

Why not use the Post-it Notes again to brainstorm what tasks or activities you might use for the skill practise sessions? Incidentally, it's best to refer to these sessions as 'skill practises' rather than 'role plays' as many people have a hang up about the latter!

Having brainstormed a list of possible sessions the author came up with the following six activities which could be used in the skill practice sessions.

- SMART Koosh throwing competition.
- Business improvement opportunity.
- Fun team problem solving task.

- Management planning meeting.
- Charity donation.
- Work-related problem solving session.

Select the Most Appropriate

These activities all provide an opportunity for the person leading the team to display their chairing skills, plus a mixture of facilitating, problem solving and other meetings skills covered in the e-learning course.

However, two of the activities, the business improvement opportunity and the work-related problem solving session, probably only work effectively if you're running an event in-house. The other four activities can work well even with a group of complete strangers so, for the purposes of this study, we'll use them.

Plan the Sessions

The next step is to plan your chosen sessions so they can be inserted into the outline template for the day. If you open Resource 12 you can see how the final document could look.

This document can now be used as the basis for two additional documents:

1. **Agenda for the day**. Strip out the detail, keeping just the main timings, and this can be given to your delegates as the outline agenda for the day's course.
2. **Trainer's Guide**. Expand each session with sufficient detail to enable the trainer to deliver the day.

Ask for Feedback

Before finalizing the design, invite comments or suggestions from trainers who might run the courses. The format of this type of training is very different from conventional courses and places extra demands on trainers. So get their input – it will be very helpful.

3. Design the Delegate Workbook

You will recall in Chapter 6 that we discussed at length the value in having a delegate workbook to accompany the e-learning course. There's no need to go over the material again for the same arguments apply just as much for this part of the program.

Delegates attending the trainer-led course will need something in which to write responses to tasks, together with their action plan, as well as having a reminder of the key learning points from the day.

Now you have finalized the day's program this is the time to design the delegate workbook. All the same design criteria apply as did for the workbook to accompany the e-learning course, so use the same style, fonts, images etc to give a message of consistency, and to link the two learning experiences together.

4. Write a Trainer's Guide

An important element of any training program is to ensure consistency and, for the trainer-led course, this is best achieved by writing a comprehensive Trainer's Guide, and then delivering some specific Train-the-Trainer courses.

We'll start in this section by looking at what's involved in writing the Trainer's Guide, leaving the Train-the-Trainer courses for Chapter 14.

Brainstorm the Content

As before, we recommend using Post-it Notes to brainstorm the content of the Trainer's Guide as there could be many different topics to include. Our suggestions would include some or all of the following topics.

SECTION 1 – WELCOME TO THE COURSE

- *Welcome* – set out the purpose of the Trainer's Guide and outline the contents.
- *Course delegates* – discuss maximum and minimum numbers.
- *Venue* – minimum requirements.
- *Course materials and equipment* – what you need to run the course.
- *Consistency* – stress need for trainer to follow the program and model the techniques.

SECTION 2 – COURSE TIMETABLE

- *The course outline* – overall structure of the day.

SECTION 3 – DETAILED TUTOR GUIDE

- *Detailed session notes* – advice on how to deliver each session.

SECTION 4 – COPIES OF THE COURSE DOCUMENTS

These will include:

- venue specification
- course joining instructions
- refresher quiz
- briefing notes for specific sessions
- end-of-course questionnaire.

Write the First Draft

Once you have the ideas you can quickly assemble them into a logical order, then write the draft Trainer's Guide, giving examples wherever possible.

If you look at Resource 13 we have shown an example of what the Trainer's Guide for the Managing Meetings course could look like. Each section could include the following information for the particular session:

SESSION TITLE

- Purpose
- Time
- Materials and resources
- Preparation
- How do I do it?

ASK FOR FEEDBACK

Before finalizing the Trainer's Guide invite comments or suggestions from trainers who might run the courses. The format of this type of training is very different from conventional courses and places extra demands on trainers. So get their input – it will be very helpful.

5. Create Supporting Materials

Design any extra materials you may need to use during the practical sessions, and the guideline here is to keep them to the barest minimum. You may be asking yourself what sort of materials you might need, and they could include:

- sheets for giving focused feedback
- briefing sheets for the skill practice sessions
- case study scenarios for exercises
- action planning sheets
- end-of-course questionnaire.

A word about computer graphics. Most people these days use PowerPoint graphics to illustrate their presentations or courses, and you may wish to invest the time to transfer some of the background materials for each course onto this medium. Remember to include the hardware and software requirements in your course specification.

6. Draft a Venue Specification

Much of the success of a course relies on the venue – if the setting is wrong, or perhaps the room is cramped, then it will be an additional barrier for the trainer to overcome. An easy way to minimize the risk of this happening is to define the 'ideal' venue and use this specification when searching for the course venue.

Make sure someone visits the venue, preferably the trainer delivering the course. To give an example of how badly this can go wrong the author arrived at a hotel which had been booked for a two-day, participative senior management workshop.

The main room booked was the Board Room which, although looking very elegant, barely had enough room for people to squeeze behind the chairs once people were seated.

By good fortune they had also booked two team rooms which, although only marginally larger, we were able to strip out the furniture, leaving only the chairs around the edges of the room. No room for screens for PowerPoint – we could just squeeze in two flip chart stands.

The moral of the story – visit it yourself and imagine being in the room for a full day.

Each course will be different in terms of the venue, the following general principles apply, however.

Room Size

Insist on a generously sized room as most hotels or conference centers will offer you a room which is far too small. This may be OK if you are sitting around a table holding a short meeting, but not for a participative, day-long training course.

Environment

Ideally your room should have natural daylight and air conditioning.

Room Layout

Every trainer has their own particular preferred approach but we would recommend:

- up to six delegates – sit around one table, set out board room style
- seven to eight delegates – use two tables, with three or four delegates per table, café style.

Tutor's Needs

The tutor will require a chair at the front of the room, and a side table for course materials and equipment.

Training Equipment

- At least two free-standing flipchart stands with a good supply of flipchart paper and pens – more may be required for specific courses.
- An OHP projector, with a pack of blank OHP acetates and a good supply of OHP pens, together with an OHP screen.
- If you're using PowerPoint you'll need a screen and projector – who will bring the laptop?
- Check the availability of sockets and extension cables.

Refreshments

- Ask the venue to supply water/orange juice etc, as well as tea and coffee at the formal breaks.



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Chapter 14
Pilot the Trainer-led course

- 1. Select and Train the Trainers 130
- 2. Select the Venue 132
- 3. Collect Nominations for the Pilot Course 132
- 4. Issue Course Joining Instructions 133
- 5. Deliver the Pilot Course 135
- 6. Review and Modify the Course Design 135

Chapter 14
Pilot the Trainer-led course

1. Select and Train the Trainers

Well before you can deliver a pilot course you will need to select, and then train, the trainers who will run the one-day courses to support the e-learning components. Ideally one or more of them will have been involved in designing at least the trainer-led course and, possibly, even the e-learning course materials.

Train-the-Trainer Event

In addition to the usual preparatory work prior to running any new course there are several important issues to get over to the future trainers, especially if they have limited experience of delivering the 'blended learning' type of course.

The best way of doing this is to hold some form of Train-the-Trainer event, ideally bringing together all of the people who might at some stage deliver the courses. Their experience will determine how much time they need.

- Everyone will need to work through the complete e-learning course before attending the Train the Trainer session.
- Trainers who are familiar with working with e-learning and/or the topic may need half a day to walk through the Trainer's Guide with you, exploring how they will deliver each session.
- Trainers who are not familiar with either working with e-learning and/or the topic may need a full day to walk through the Trainer's Guide with you before delivering a few sessions so that you can be confident about their style and approach.

Points to Stress

During the Train-the-Trainer session you will need to cover the following key points:

KEEP TO THE SCRIPT

When presenting the course it is essential that they do not deviate in any way from the concepts and ideas presented in the program, even if they don't agree with all of them.

NO NEW MATERIALS OR MODELS

The one-day timetable is already very 'tight' and there simply is no time to introduce any new materials or concepts.

PUT ASIDE THEIR OWN PREFERRED WAYS OF WORKING

Recognize that they, as experienced trainers, have their own approach to the topic and it is quite possible that certain skills or behaviors may be presented differently from how they would do it themselves. However, to avoid confusing the delegates and to ensure the course is delivered consistently you should ask them to:

- put aside their own personal preferences or styles and deliver the course as designed
- respond to any questions in a way that is consistent with the materials in *Grasp the Theory*
- project themselves as a role model for all the course concepts, demonstrating them consistently throughout the day.

By the end of the Train-the-Trainer event you should have a list of people who you are confident will deliver the courses consistently and energetically. If possible 'pencil in' dates for courses before they leave.

2. Select the Venue

Using the criteria in the draft venue specification in Resource 13, Section 4 select a suitable venue and confirm the date.

Don't skimp on the venue – it's a key ingredient for success. There's nothing more demotivating than being cooped up all day with a group of people in a claustrophobically small room. It can undermine everything that's gone before.

- It sounds obvious, but whenever possible, visit the venue in advance to ensure it really does meet your needs.
- At the very least ask the venue to send you a detailed room plan showing measurements, the locations of windows, doors and power sockets.
- Look for any built-in [and unmovable] training aids, e.g. screens for projectors and wall-mounted flipchart stands.
- Check out the size and location of any syndicate rooms you want.

Lead times on venues can be quite long and coming to an understanding relationship with nearby conference and training venues can relieve lots of pressure. The ideal would be to have dates 'penciled in' leaving you free to cancel if the numbers of delegates is insufficient to run the courses as scheduled.

3. Collect Nominations for the Pilot Course

By this stage quite a few people may have started the e-learning course and hopefully a growing number will have successfully completed it. Review the wait-list for the course and schedule an event once minimum numbers have been reached. This sounds easier than it often is in reality!

- You reach the minimum number count and seek a venue.
- They give you a date which you test out with your delegates – and find that not all can attend that day.
- You ask when they could attend, so you check out that date with the venue.
- Only they are fully booked that day!

And so it goes on! But eventually you will find a date when your delegates can attend, the venue has a suitable room… and the trainer is available!

Obviously a key element in managing this whole process is having a database which allows you to easily monitor who's taking part in the program, what stage they've reached, and what's happening next.

4. Issue Course Joining Instructions

The course joining instructions may be your first formal contact with your delegates so they need to be:

- **timely:** far enough in advance to give reasonable warning, but not so far that people lose them
- **complete:** make sure you include all the information people need
- **accurate:** it's easy to get addresses or telephone numbers confused
- **inviting:** make them look exciting and stimulate interest.

You probably have your own format – however, you may wish to look at the sample we've given in Section 4 of the Trainer's Guide, which you can find in Resource 12 Section 4. Ask delegates to confirm attendance and monitor the take-up to ensure the minimum numbers are met.

Let's briefly go through the main elements.

Welcome

- Welcomes the delegate to the course.
- Outlines what needs to be done prior to attending the course.
- Stresses that attending is conditional upon completing the full e-learning component.

Benefits of the Course

- Tells the delegates how they can expect to benefit by attending.

About the Course

- Because the day is busy it stresses the need to arrive on time and give full commitment.
- Asks for mobile phones to be switched off for the whole day.
- Gives outline timings.

The Venue

- Gives full details of the venue.
- Provides contact person's details at the venue.
- Directions on how to travel to the venue.
- Parking, security, refreshments, lunch etc.

Pre-course Work

- Detail any pre-course work.

Course Tutor

- Say when the tutor will be available at the venue.
- State that they welcome any questions delegates may have.

Dress Code

- State the dress code for the course, normally smart casual.

Can't Attend?

- Stress the need to give maximum notice if they can't attend so the place can be offered to another delegate.

Any Queries?

- Offer a contact if the delegate has any queries.

Sign off

- Sign off in a friendly way –'We look forward to meeting you on the day.'
- Ensure it is with a name that people can read.

5. Deliver the Pilot Course

Just before the scheduled date send course materials and equipment to the venue, clearly labeled for the trainer, with the name of the training room and date. The times the author has spent frantic minutes on the morning of the course searching hotels for a box of materials!

Finalize the administrative details with the venue managers. Confirm the number of delegates and trainers, timings and any special dietary requirements.

Finally confirm the date and venue with the trainer[s], together with travel directions and the name of the training room.

On the Day…

Sometimes it's tempting to have a mixture of delegates on the pilot, intermingling 'ordinary' delegates with people from the HR or training department. Quite naturally, the 'experts' want to come along to see how the pilot works and they want to be able to give their feedback during the review meeting.

However, try to keep the proportion of 'experts' low as the presence of these knowledgeable people disrupts the flow of the day. This can easily lead to the pilot course being quite different from what it would have been if the delegates were 'ordinary' operational people.

Also, because their focus is on the course itself rather than just practising the skills, they can also divert the discussions towards how the course needs to be improved, instead of how individual delegates need to change their skills or behaviors.

6. Review and Modify the Course Design

Get Feedback

At the end of the course it's essential to ask individual delegates to complete an end-of-course questionnaire as you normally would. Lots of people often scoff at these forms but, if you make it clear that you do take them seriously, people will often give you constructive, and sometimes painful, feedback.

The author can look back on many years of training experience and recognize that many of the good ideas that have been developed have arisen from delegate feedback.

At the end of the pilot course it's also valuable to ask the delegates to give some group feedback, and you can do this very easily.

- Head up two flipcharts like this: one headed 'This went well' and the other 'This could be better'.
- Split the delegates into two groups, one standing at each flipchart.
- Now ask them to list on the flipchart anything they want to relating to their heading.
- After five minutes or so, ask them to change flipcharts and add any extra ideas to the other one.
- Finally, ask everyone to gather round the 'This went well' flipchart and invite the 'author' of each comment to briefly say why it's important to them.
- Change flipcharts and all stand round the 'This could be better' list and again ask the 'author' of each comment to briefly say why it's important to them.

This process will give you lots of good ideas about what needs to be changed to make the pilot really effective, as well as stroking your self esteem!

The Next Day

If at all possible schedule a review meeting for early on the day immediately after the pilot course, so all the key people can review what happened whilst it's fresh in everyone's mind. You can then decide what changes need to be made and get going on the modifications.

You may also wish to look back at Chapter 9, Section 6 which covered this review meeting in a little more detail.

All done!

So that's the pilot trainer-led course all done and dusted!



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Chapter 15
Applying the Learning

- 1. Assess Learners' Improved Skills and Effectiveness.....138
- 2. Offer Coaching to Reinforce Learning.....139
- 3. Evaluate the Effectiveness of the Training Program 140
- 4. Enhance Course Content to Offer Improved Skills 141
- 5. Release and Publicize the Program 142
- 6. Delivering Competitive Advantage 142

Chapter 15
Applying the Learning

1. Assess Learners' Improved Skills and Effectiveness

We started this journey by looking at the three phases people work through to improve their skills or confidence. For this report we've been considering the application for a program which starts with e-learning, but in fact these stages apply for all learning experiences.

- **Grasp the Theory**. Learners undertake a self-study e-learning course, supported by other learning resources, for example, books or videos.
- **Practise the Skills**. Learners come together with colleagues to practise their skills in a short, intensive trainer-led course.
- **Apply the learning**. Learners apply all the learning to reach new levels of business performance, supported by coaching.

Delegates will return to their workplace after attending the trainer-led course and begin to implement their action plans. This is a potential danger period as they may get swamped by 'business as usual' when they return to their desks, and it's quite possible that all their good intentions from the course get lost!

In an ideal world, each delegate will have discussed the outcome from the course with their line-manager who will, of course, show an interest in their action plans. It's vital that the action points learners develop as they both *Grasp the Theory* and *Practise the Skills* are SMART in every way:

- **Specific** – they identify specific tasks or activities to focus on.
- **Measurable** – if they can't measure it they won't know how well they're currently doing and, worse still, they won't know when they've met the new standard.
- **Achievable** – a balance is required here. A too-easy goal is no motivation, whilst one that's unattainable is an immediate turn off.

- **Relevant** – both the learner and line-manager must see the objective as relevant to the job in hand.
- **Timed** – give it a date and time – and you have something real to achieve.

It will be important to develop some meaningful measurements to really determine the true improvement in individual skills or behaviors, especially if you want to compare changes across different parts of the business, or at different sites.

2. Offer Coaching to Reinforce Learning

The line manager needs to discreetly monitor the learner's progress against the action plans written at the end of the *Practise the Skills* course. Depending on their response they might need coaching, which can be given in at least two ways:

- The traditional method, when the line manager sits with the learner and gives one-to-one coaching on specific skills or behaviors.
- On-line coaching, when the trainer who delivered the trainer-led course offers remote coaching via the internet or the company intranet.

Whichever approach is adopted you must ensure delegates get every bit of help and encouragement to implement their action plans. One additional advantage of the second approach is that the central HR department has a continuing relationship with people who have passed through the e-learning system, so enabling them to monitor its ongoing effectiveness more realistically.

On-line Coaching

If on-line coaching is an option, it needs to mentioned at each stage of the process to reinforce its value to learners, and to ensure a reasonable take-up of the service. On-line coaching is quite different from the normal form of coaching and, in order for it to be successful, some additional elements need to be taken into account:

- Ideally the on-line coach needs to have been involved in the trainer-led course so they have seen the individual 'in action'.
- The on-line coach needs to have a copy of the action plan completed at the end of the trainer-led course, and be brought up to date with progress by the learner.

- It will be important to specify the maximum amount of on-line coaching the individual will receive, perhaps eight hours.
- It's useful to give a commitment about response time, for example, *To contact your personal coach, send an e-mail with your particular question to* ***coach@XXX.com****. We will normally respond within one working day although we endeavor to reply within a few hours.*

It's also worth considering establishing a form of automated follow-up whereby the learner receives a series of reminder messages at specified periods after attending the trainer-led course. The various forms the messages could take include:

- Top tips
- Frequently Asked Questions
- Action Plan Reminders

3. Evaluate the Effectiveness of the Training Program

At this point we return to the last of the Top Tips we shared with you earlier.

TOP TIP 6

Finally, how will you measure the project's success? Seems a simple enough question, but it's all too seldom not asked!

Report to Management

Full circle! The whole program started with an awareness of the need for change to maintain or improve the company's competitive advantage. So now it's time to report back to higher management on what's been achieved. You may wish to:

- report the evidence of improved performance, preferably with 'third party' comments
- demonstrate the effectiveness of the training program. How many people started and completed the course? How long did it take them?

- say how effective has it been in terms of measurable changes in skill or behavior
- show the measurable differences using a cost-benefit analysis
- comment on reasons for any significant differences between departments or sites
- offer any other wider applications that have been suggested
- mention other companies in the group, or the industry who might benefit from it
- offer other potential e-learning opportunities
- Focus on continuous improvement? What's next?

4. Enhance Course Content to Offer Improved Skills

It's not only the course delegates who can *Apply the Learning* – the course designers get their share too! You need to feedback comments you've received from delegates to the designers of the *Grasp the Theory* course. They will be able to make changes or modifications to the materials to make the program easier to use.

Feedback Comments to E-learning Suppliers

This is a good moment to give feedback to your suppliers to see how the software aspects of the e-learning components might be modified to make them easier to use or generally more effective.

5. Release and Publicize the Program

You are now ready to release the whole training program to your target market. Just a few practical issues to deal with:

- Finalize and publish materials.
- Purchase any new resources.
- Install new software if required.
- Buy and install any equipment that may be required.

Select and Train Staff

An important element in making this a success is the staff who will be managing the learning resources on a day-to-day basis.

- If you already have a learning centre then it's possible that you might be able to include the extra duties in their role, at least at the start.
- Otherwise you will need to identify staff to manage the new learning programs and give them suitable training.

Their cooperation and motivation will be crucial towards the success of the blended training process as they will be interacting with delegates day-by-day. On-line coaches also need training and time to do the job.

6. Delivering Competitive Advantage

We started out asking you if you wanted to plan, design or implement a training program involving electronic learning? If the answer was 'Yes' then we suggested you read this report. We promised it would save you time, effort, money…or all three!

Improving competitive advantage

We then outlined the many benefits of e-learning which we believe can directly improve the competitive advantage of your company:

- It allows staff to acquire new skills when they need them, instead of waiting for the next scheduled training course.
- People can break the learning into 'chunks' to fit in better with the demands and time-pressures of their own job.

- The time required to learn the underlying theory is reduced to a minimum, reflecting the reality that people learn at different speeds, and may already have varying amounts of knowledge of the new topic.
- As a result, non-revenue earning time is reduced, compared with traditional training courses, when the pace of learning is determined by the slowest person.
- It enables the subsequent trainer-led course to focus on practising the skills, removing the need to explore underlying theories.
- Trainer-led courses are thus shorter, with a corresponding reduction in all the associated costs – trainers, facilities, overnight accommodation, etc.

Having worked through the process you are now in a position to plan and implement an entirely new way of delivering improved skills and behaviors to your company or organization.

It's now up to you, and the people you work with, to prove that e-learning really does deliver 'more for less' – greater skill levels with reduced costs.

As you work through the process step by step you will do doubt encounter problems we haven't foreseen, and you will come up with novel solutions to tricky problems. Please let us know about them so we can incorporate this valuable feedback into future editions.

Best wishes for the journey ahead – Tony Bray.

BLANK



THOROGOOD
PROFESSIONAL
INSIGHTS

Appendices

- Resource 1: Project Specification 146
- Resource 2: Course Overview 152
- Resource 3: Sample Learner's Workbook to Accompany the On-line Managing Meetings Course 155
- Resource 4: Sample Opening Quiz 168
- Resource 5: Sample Closing Quiz 179
- Resource 6: Course Flowchart 190
- Resource 7: Sample Screens 191
- Resource 8: Learning Options 206
- Resource 9: Project Status Report 207
- Resource 10: Sample Storyboards 209
- Resource 11: Refresher Quiz 215
- Resource 12: Sample Course Outline 222
- Resource 13: Sample Trainer's Guide 226

Appendices
Resource 1: Project Specification

[Client Name]	
Outline for Project:	**[Managing meetings]**
Version:	1.1
Date:	1/01/200X
Author:	A N Other

Acceptance	Accepted by
Remarks	See changes

1. Introduction

This course is for all employees who regularly attend and, more specifically, chair meetings.

Recent audits of meetings have shown that the average duration of meetings has increased by 25 per cent without a corresponding increase in effectiveness.

More detailed attitude surveys have revealed that most people who attend meetings are critical of the skills displayed by the chair, especially in managing time and facilitating discussions on sensitive or contentious issues.

This document outlines the learning aims and contents of this web-based training, which we will refer to as 'Managing Meetings'.

2. Format

The disc will be developed according to the rules and standards of [Client Name] Global Training. The course must be designed so that it can be run 'online'. It may, however, also be issued on CD-ROM to users without online access.

3. Target Groups

TARGET GROUP

The **primary** target group of this program is all management grades and team leaders who chair meetings.

The secondary target group is staff who regularly attend more than four meetings each week.

KNOWLEDGE BASE

The users will have different levels of technical and/or professional experience, as they will be drawn from the full spectrum of the company's staff, both based in central office and the operational plants.

4. Target Countries

This web-based training will be applicable to managers and team leaders in the UK.

5. Learning Aims

The overall aim of this web-based training project is:

- To improve the effectiveness of meetings company-wide by enhancing the chairing skills of managers and team leaders.

The key objectives are:

- To improve the time management skills of all staff chairing meetings.
- To encourage wider debate on sensitive or contentious issues by improving the facilitation skills of the chairperson.
- To encourage staff who attend meetings to accept a greater responsibility for the success of the meeting.

6. Structure

The programme will divided into these chapters:

Chapter	Title
1	Introduction
2	Overview
3	Planning the meeting
4	Personal skills audit
5	Leading the meetings
6	Facilitation toolkit
7	Action planning and review

7. Learning Outcomes

The outcomes for chapters are:

No.	Chapter	Topic	Learning Target	Time
1.0	**Introduction**	Introduction		
1.1		Overview of course	The learner knows the aims and contents of the course	1.0
				1.0
2.0	**Overview**	Introduction		
2.1		Definition of a meeting	Learner refreshes what constitutes a meeting	1.0
2.2		Managing meetings	The learner refreshes the Plan-Do-Act cycle	1.0
2.3		Opening quiz	The learner tests their opening knowledge	5.0
				7.0
3.0	**Planning the Meeting**	Introduction		
3.1		Do you need a meeting?	The learner explores the options available	2.0
3.2		Setting SMART objectives	The learner knows how to apply SMART to the meeting's goals	4.0
3.3		Planning a meeting	The learner learns the value of planning	1.0
3.4		Challenging invitations	The learner knows how to ensure that only essential people attend the meeting	2.0
3.5		Mind Mapping	The learner explores the value of Mind Maps for planning and discussion	1.0
3.6		Effective agendas	The learner knows how draft an effective agenda	2.0
3.7		Managing the venue	The learner knows how to manage the venue for best effect	2.0
				14.0
4.0	**Personal Skills Audit**	Introduction		
4.1		Creating the right impression	The learner learns the value of a positive first impression	1.0
4.2		Body language signals	The learner learns about Words, Music and Dance	2.0
4.3		Talking clearly	The learners realise the importance of clear speech	3.0
4.4		Listening	The learner discovers how to become a better listener	2.0
4.5		Asking effective questions	The learner refreshes the key skills in asking open and closed questions	2.0
				10.0

No.	Chapter	Topic	Learning Target	Time
5.0	**Leading the Meeting**	Introduction		0.0
5.1		Role of the Chairperson	The learner explores the role of the Chair	2.0
5.2		Five key steps	The learner learns the five steps for an effective meeting	4.0
				6.0
6.0	**Facilitation Toolkit**	Introduction		0.0
6.1		Creating a common vision	The learner knows about tools to create a common view	2.0
6.2		Cause and Effect Analysis	The learner knows how to use C&E to search for underlying causes	1.0
6.3		Ask the Five Whys	The learner discovers asking Five Whys to drill down	1.0
6.4		Process mapping	The learner knows how to use Process Mapping to gain agreement to processes	2.0
6.5		Facilitation tips	The learner gains seven key facilitation tips	2.0
6.6		Sunflower analysis	The learner sees how Sunflower Analysis helps identify key players	2.0
				10.0
70	**Action Planning and Review**	Introduction		0.0
7.1		How to close the meeting	The learner learns the key steps in closing a meeting	1.0
7.2		What needs to happen next?	The learner discovers what needs to happen after the meeting	1.0
7.3		Action points	The learner finds out about documenting action points	1.0
7.4		Reporting the meeting	The learner is introduced to different formats for meeting reports	2.0
7.5		What else?	The learner discovers what else may be required	1.0
7.6		Personal action planning	The learner reviews the course and drafts personal action points	20
7.7	**Closing Quiz**			4.0
				60.0

8. Platform [minimum spec.]

Multimedia Computer: Pentium II, 300 MHz, 64 MBRAM 64kbps internet/intranet connection.

9. Training Duration

The training duration for the web-based training is planned to be one hour.

10. Notes

11. Schedule [Preliminary]:

200X

Date	Description	Notes
January 14	Kick off meeting [Client premises]	All participants
January 30	Distribute 'outline' document	[Instructional designers name]
February/March	Prepare 'basic design' document	[Instructional designers name] [research meeting with XXXX]
March 26th	Review 'basic design' document [client premises]	All participants
April 9	Distribute final version of 'basic design' document	
April/May	Prepare first 50 per cent of storyboard	[Instructional designers name]
June 3	Review first 50 per cent of storyboard [client premises]	All participants
June/July	Prepare 100 per cent of storyboard	[Instructional designers name]
August 1	Review first 100% of storyboard [client premises]	All participants
August 30	Distribute final storyboard	[Instructional designers name]

Resource 2: Course Overview

Here are the results of the initial Post-it Note planning session for the Managing Meetings course. Remember at this stage it's just rough notes – intended to prompt thoughts about the way the course could develop.

Managing Meetings – Contents

Introduction

- Benefits of this programme
- Module overview
- Definition of a meeting (insert definition of meeting into workbook?)

Chapter 1 – Designing the Meeting

- Do we need the meeting?
- Look at options i.e. video conferencing, telephone call, e-mail etc.
- Write SMART objectives
- Next screen – think of a meeting you are going to organise and think of SMART objectives (workbook – write SMART objectives?)
- Do Mind Map of what needs to be done to design the meeting. (do Mind Map in workbook?)
- Preparing an agenda
- Challenging invitations (workbook page?)
- Who needs to be there – and for how long?
- Managing the venue
- Match your needs with availability

Personal Skills Audit

- Personal skills audit questionnaire
- How do I create the correct impression? Words, music and dance
- Be a better listener
- Seek to understand before you make yourself understood

Lead the Meeting

- Agree the agenda, the roles and time – including how long for each item and finishing time – keep to it!
- What about rotating the role of Chairperson at regular group meetings?
- Create the right atmosphere
- Start in a positive way
- Explore issues
- Encourage full participation
- Discover the full extent of the issue
- Reach decisions
- Close in a positive way

Facilitation Toolkit

- Common vision
- Look for creative innovative ideas
- Decision making techniques
- Visual planning techniques – Mind Mapping, Post it Notes, Sunflower Analysis, Cause and Effect diagram (workbook?)
- Handling diverse views

Action Planning – Review

- Closing the meeting
- Summarise key agreements
- Who will do what and when?
- Use the company standard action planning page?

- Do we need to meet again?
- After the meeting draft a written summary
- Give thanks and credit where it is due
- Consider how you could do it better next time

Resource 3: Sample Learner's Workbook to Accompany the On-line Managing Meetings Course

1

Welcome to the on-line course

This workbook accompanies the on-line Managing Meetings course and is designed to help you get the best from your time investment.

The workbook helps in three specific ways:

1. It provides a reminder of the key learning points you encountered during the course.
2. It gives you somewhere to record your responses to some tasks you'll be asked to complete during the course.
3. It also gives you somewhere to record action points and reminders as you progress through the course.

Best of luck with the course. We welcome any feedback you may have to make it more productive, challenging or interesting.

Please remember there are several excellent sources of information on managing meetings already available in-house and you can find them at:

- XXXXXXXX
- YYYYYYYY

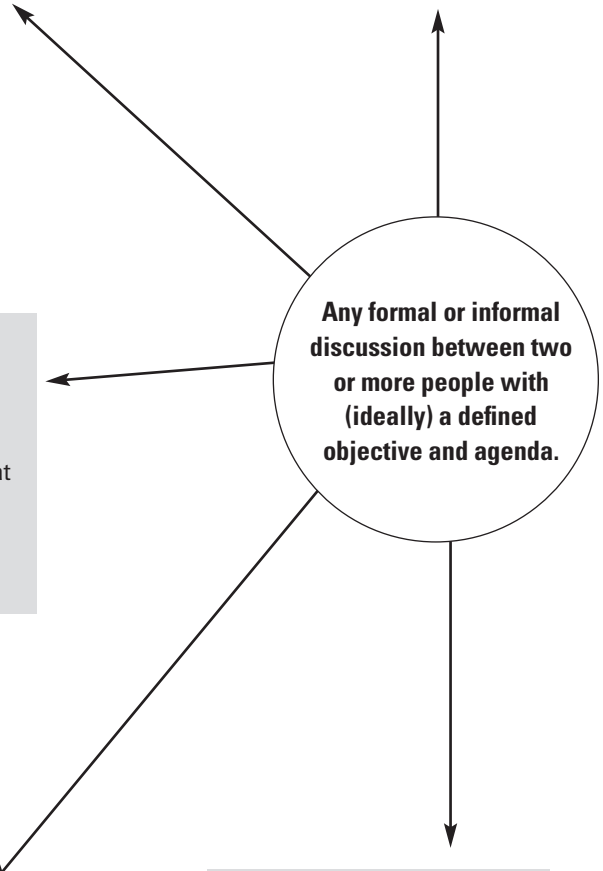
Contact name/phone/e-mail for HR department

2

Definition of a meeting

'Formal or informal' – the degree of formality can have a significant impact on the effectiveness of the meeting. People may feel inhibited and the time for discussion may be restricted in formal meetings. On the other hand informal meetings may require firmer control or greater self-discipline on the part of participants.

'discussion' – this implies that the process will be a two-way experience rather than one party simply talking at the other. This isn't always the case and one must question the effectiveness of a meeting which involves only one party listening.



'two or more people' – the number of people attending a meeting can also have a great impact on its effectiveness; personal experience tells us that around five to seven people is a comfortable number and, for most situations, probably ideal.

'defined objective' – start with the end in mind and have a clearly defined objective. Otherwise, if you aim at nothing you will hit it!

'defined... agenda' – it may sound formal but having a well structured and logical agenda will focus everyone's mind and deliver the required result in the given time.

3

Set SMART Objectives

Having now looked at SMART objectives I would like you to consider a meeting you are planning and write down your SMART objectives.

Specific

Measurable

Achievable

Realistic

Timed

4

Challenging Invitations

Who really needs to be there?

Look at a meeting you are planning. Go through the list of people invited to attend and assess:

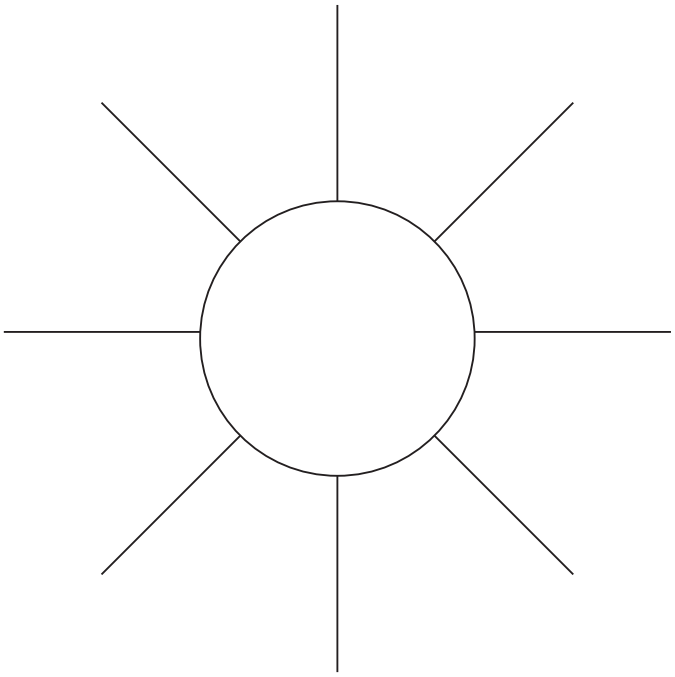
- Do they need to be there?
- Do they need to be there all the time?
- What other ways could they contribute?
- What other way could you inform them of the outcomes?

Having thought about these questions, what changes are you going to make to your invitation list?

5

Mind Map your meeting

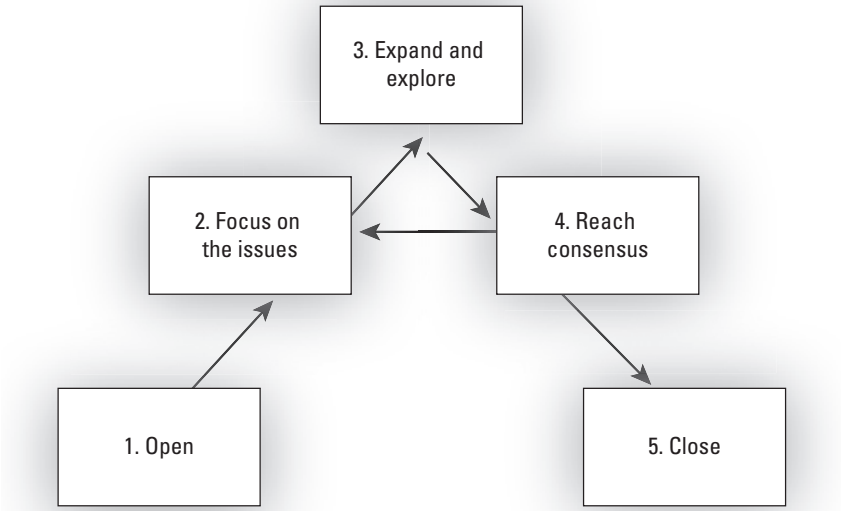
Design a Mind Map for a meeting you have to organise.



6

Running an effective meeting

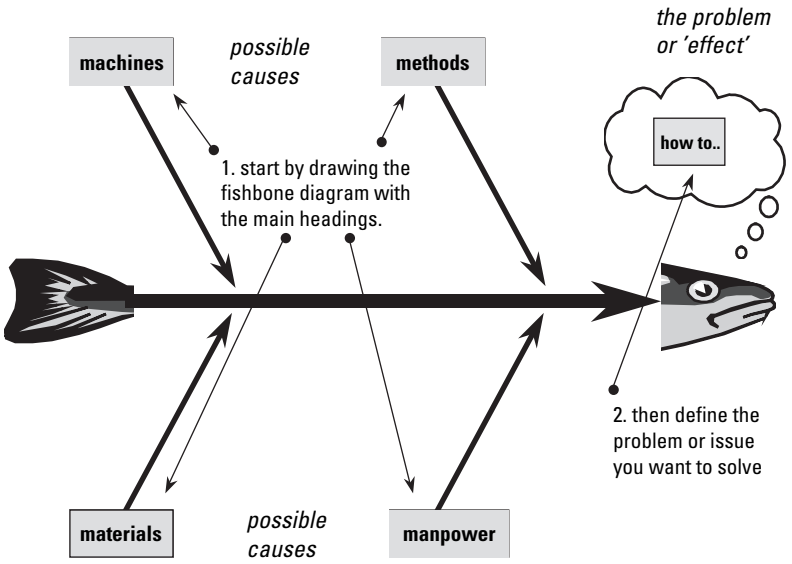
Below are my ideas. If your suggestions are significantly different please look at the following pages in the e-learning course – these suggestions may be helpful.



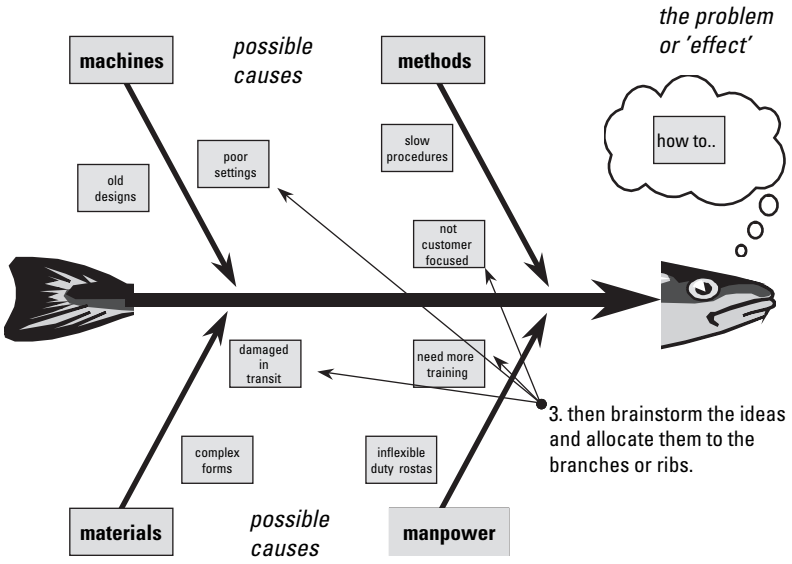
7

Fishing for ideas

Plan your fishbone diagram



Start the ideas coming



Facilitation tips

8

TECHNIQUE	USE THIS TO HELP YOU	WHAT TO SAY
Focus on agreement Find and highlight areas where group members agree.	• To regain momentum. • To energise a group. • To build a group's confidence.	"You're doing fine. Look at all the agreements you have already made!" "OK you agree on the main components – it's just the final section you have to work on some more!"
Build small agreements Break down major decisions into component parts.	• To achieve an experience of success and forward movement. • To reduce cognitive or emotional complexity.	"We don't seem to agree on the whole proposal. Lets see which parts we can agree on." "How about section A? Great! What else can we agree on!''
Spend a pound A method for assessing which alternatives the group is most interested in.	• To get a sense of priorities in the group.	"You all have an equal amount of money. Please distribute cash to the options which have the most value to you." "Then be ready to explain your rationale for your choices."
Pros and Cons	To highlight important features of each alternative.	"We have two basic alternatives. What are the pros of solution A? What are the minuses? How about solution B?"

Facilitation tips

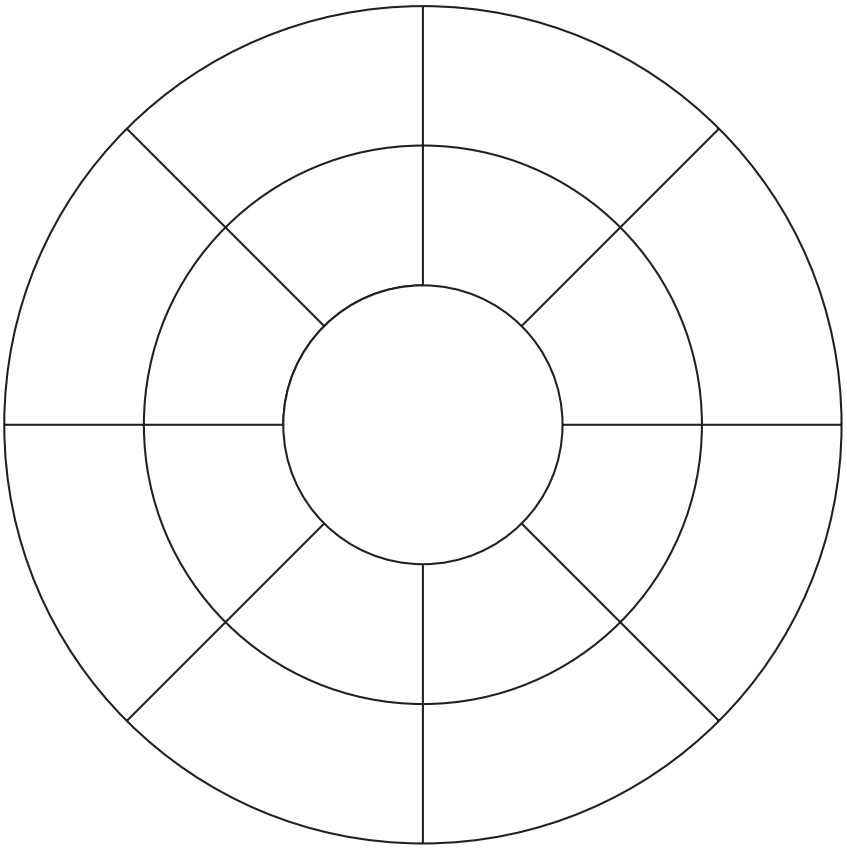
9

TECHNIQUE	USE THIS TO HELP YOU	WHAT TO SAY
What would it take? A question asked by facilitator to move a group towards final agreement.	To uncover the underlying needs of people who are not brought in to a generally accepted solution.	"It seems as though most people are in agreement and that Chris still needs something in order to buy in." "Chris – what would it take in order for you to agree to this solution?"
What have others done? Informal bench-marking by scanning group members' memories and experiences of how others have solved similar problems.	To identify other successes from you can draw ideas or inspiration.	"Does anyone know what other companies/ departments have done about this problem?" "What are some successful models or approaches?'"
Back off Deferring decision making for the moment and focusing the group's attention on confirming previous agreements.	• To help a group address its resistance to making a decision. • To identify and build agreements missing from an earlier problem solving phase.	"It looks like there are still some major points of disagreement. I think it would be a good idea not to force a decision at this point. Instead, let's go back and decide if our prior agreements still hold."

10

Sunflower analysis

You now know how it works – so try it out for yourself. Either take the big picture, or focus on one specific task or issue.



11

Your meeting

Think about the next meeting you are going to organise and decide what would be the best style of documentation.

Meeting:

Format:

Content:

Style:

12

Action planning template

Below is a suggested template for an action report.

Actions from ..... Meeting

Held on .....

Present

Apologies

Item	Action	Who	When

Next meeting .....

MEETING EVALUATION

Did well

Do better

13

Personal action plan

Name .....Date.....Division.....

Course .....Location.....

Objective 1	Action	By when
Desired outcomes	Actual outcomes	

Objective 2	Action	By when
Desired outcomes	Actual outcomes	

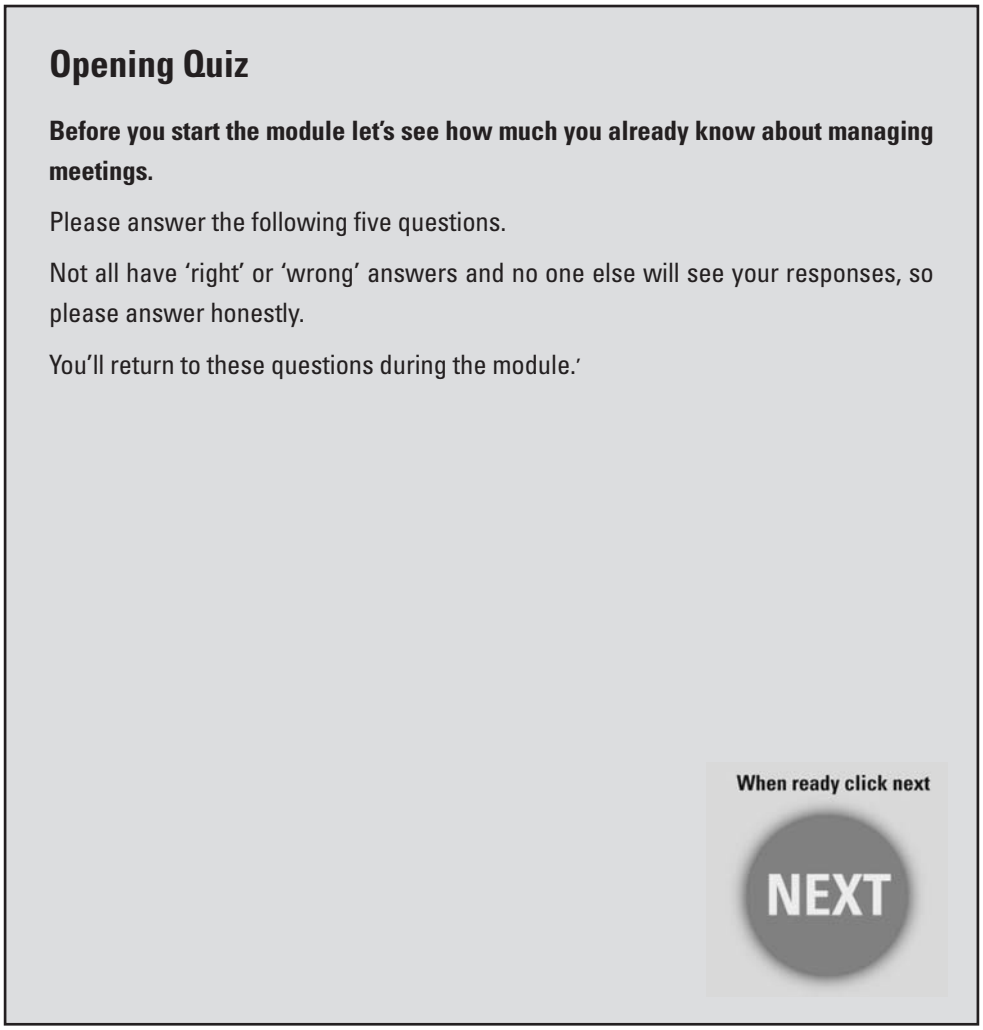
Objective 3	Action	By when
Desired outcomes	Actual outcomes	

Resource 4: Sample Opening Quiz

This tells the learner what's going to happen, and invites them to complete the quiz.

Saying "Not all have 'right' or 'wrong' answers..." sets the ground rules.

"...and no one else will see your responses, so please answer honestly." This assures the learner that, in this case, no one else will see the results.

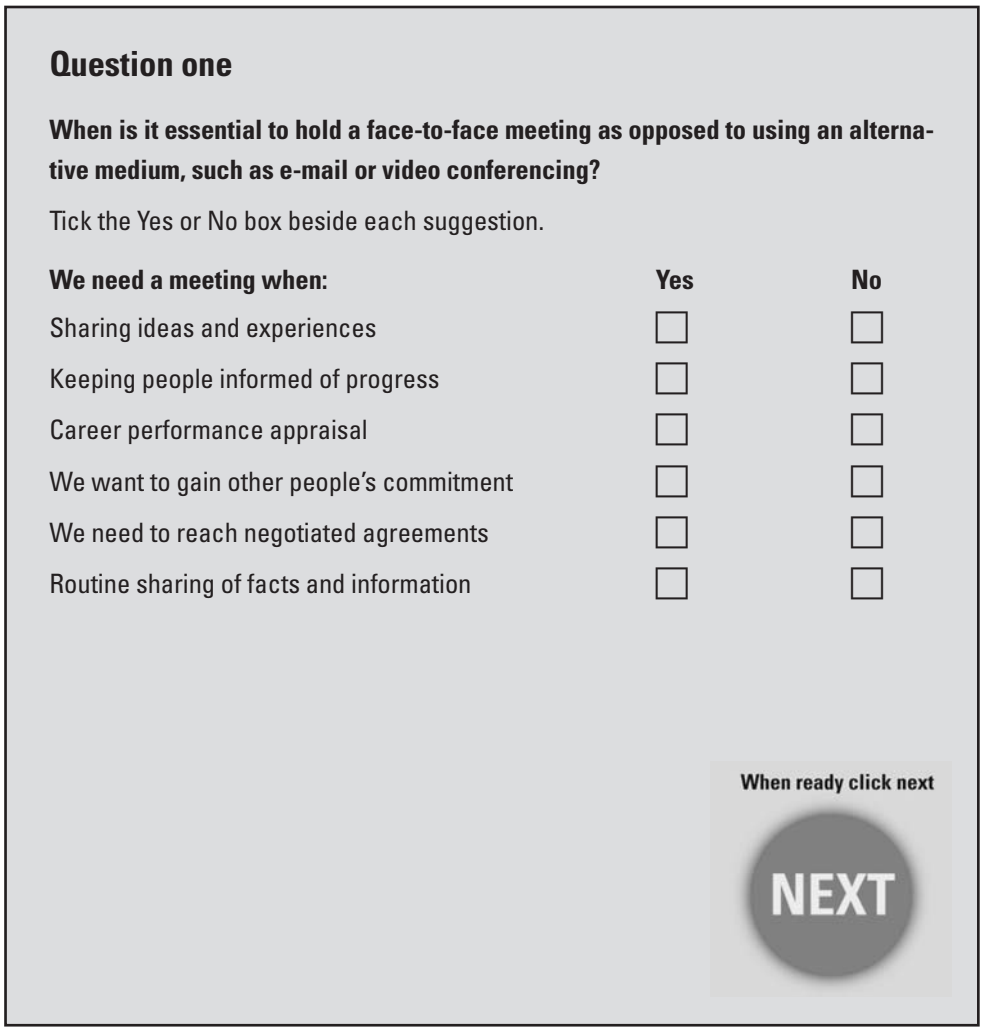


Sample Opening Quiz – Question 1

This Question asks the learner to tick either a Yes or No box in a list of questions.

The results will be stored and displayed later in the 'answers' section.

The word 'essential' should help the learner to be positive about selecting either Yes or No.



The learner ticks either the Yes or No box.

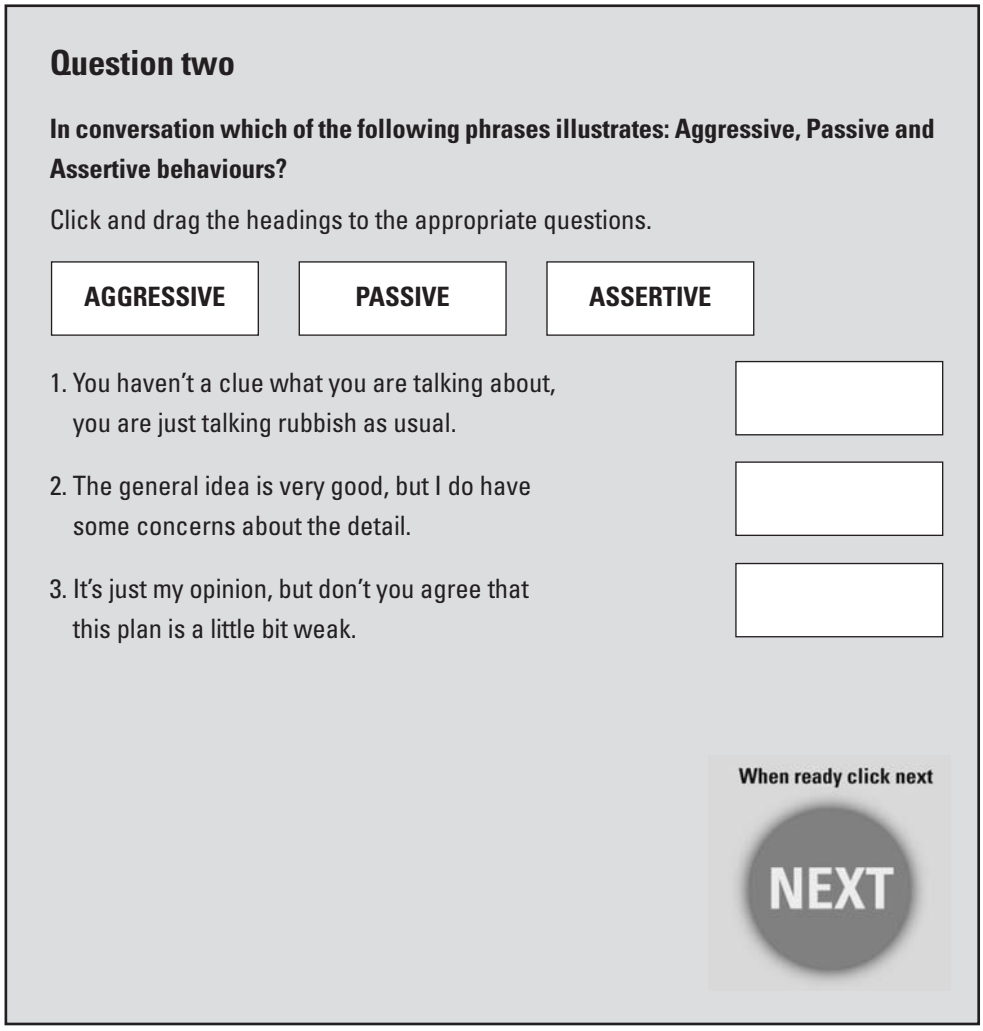
Store the results for later display in the 'answers' section.

Agree if the learning system will allow a learner to tick both Yes and No

Sample Opening Quiz – Question 2

This Question asks the learner to click and drag the headings to the appropriate boxes.

The results will be stored and displayed later in the 'answers' section.



The learner clicks and drags the answers alongside the right answer.

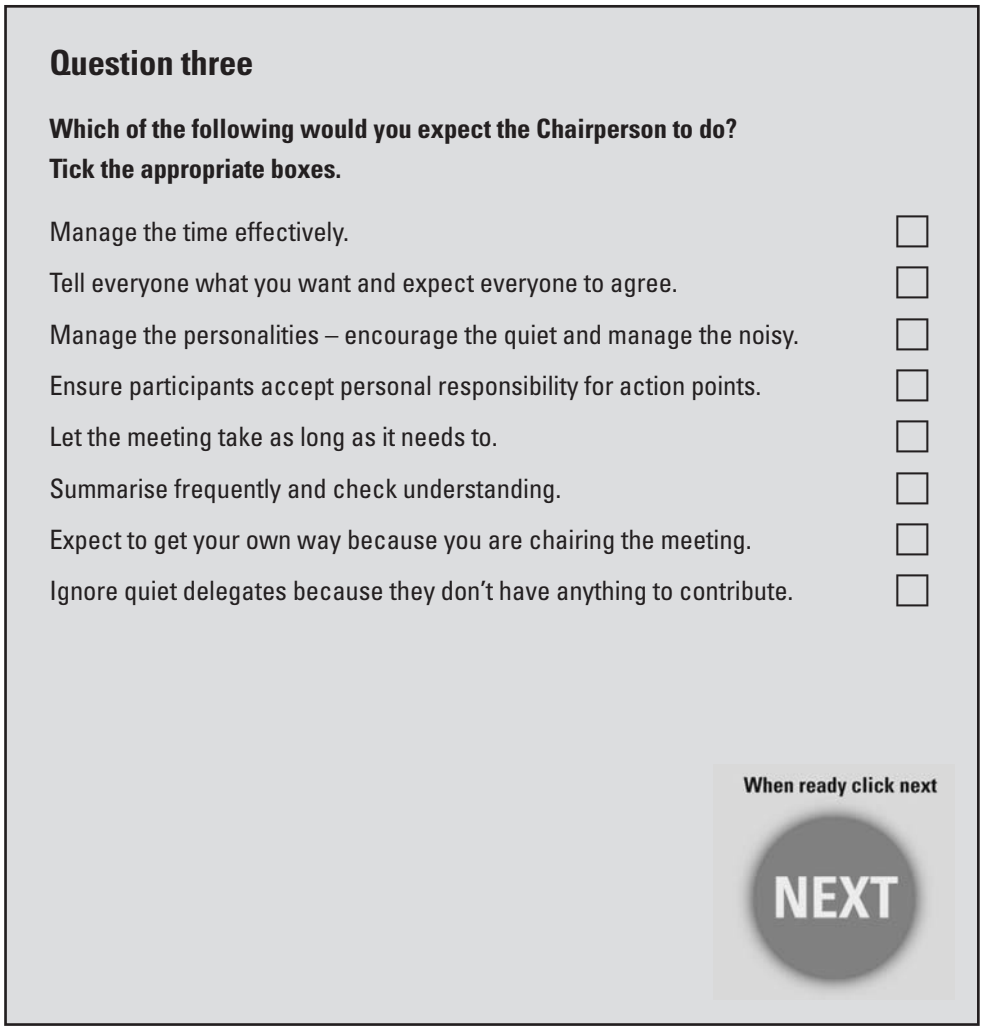
Store the results for later display in the 'answers' section.

Sample Opening Quiz – Question 3

This Question asks the learner to tick the appropriate boxes in a list of questions.

The results will be stored and displayed later in the 'answers' section.

The word 'expect' should help the learner to select the appropriate boxes.



The learner ticks the boxes they choose.

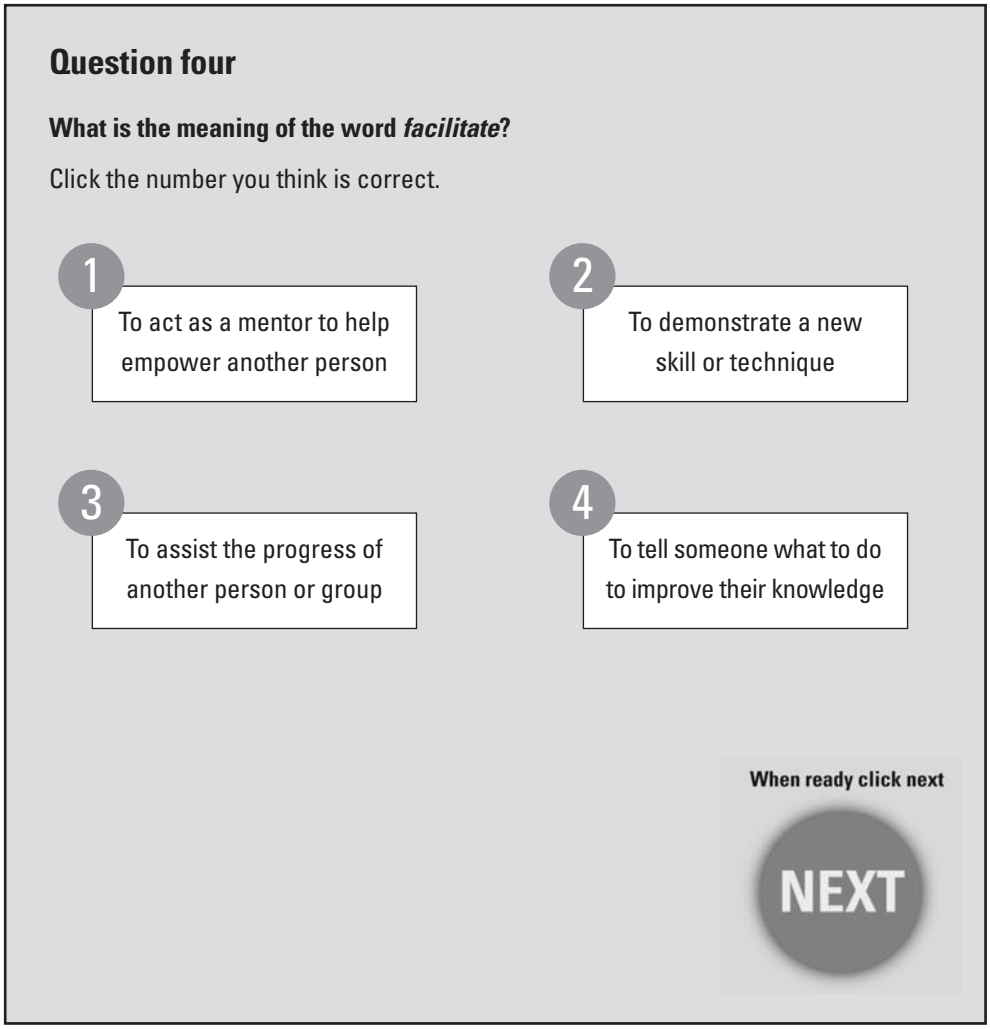
Store the results for later display in the 'answers' section.

Sample Opening Quiz – Question 4

This Question asks the learner to click one choice from four possible answers.

The result will be stored and displayed later in the 'answers' section.

On this occasion there is really only one 'right' answer in the options listed.



The learner clicks the box they choose.

Store the result for later display in the 'answers' section.

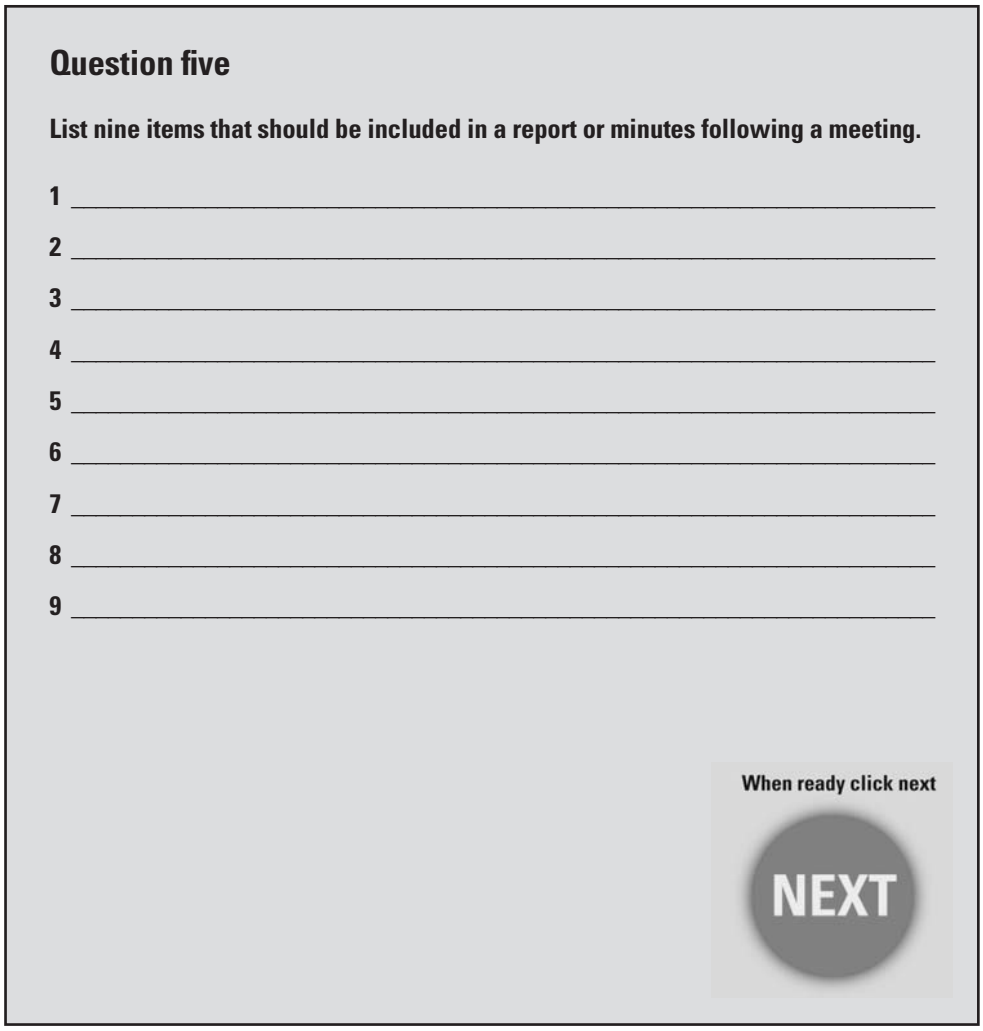
The system should not allow the learner to select more than one box

Sample Opening Quiz – Question 5

This Question asks the learner to list a maximum of nine items.

The results will be stored and displayed later in the 'answers' section.

On this occasion there are no 'right' answers – just a recommended list.



The learner types in their own ideas alongside the numbered sections.

The system should allow the learner to enter a specified amount of text alongside each heading.

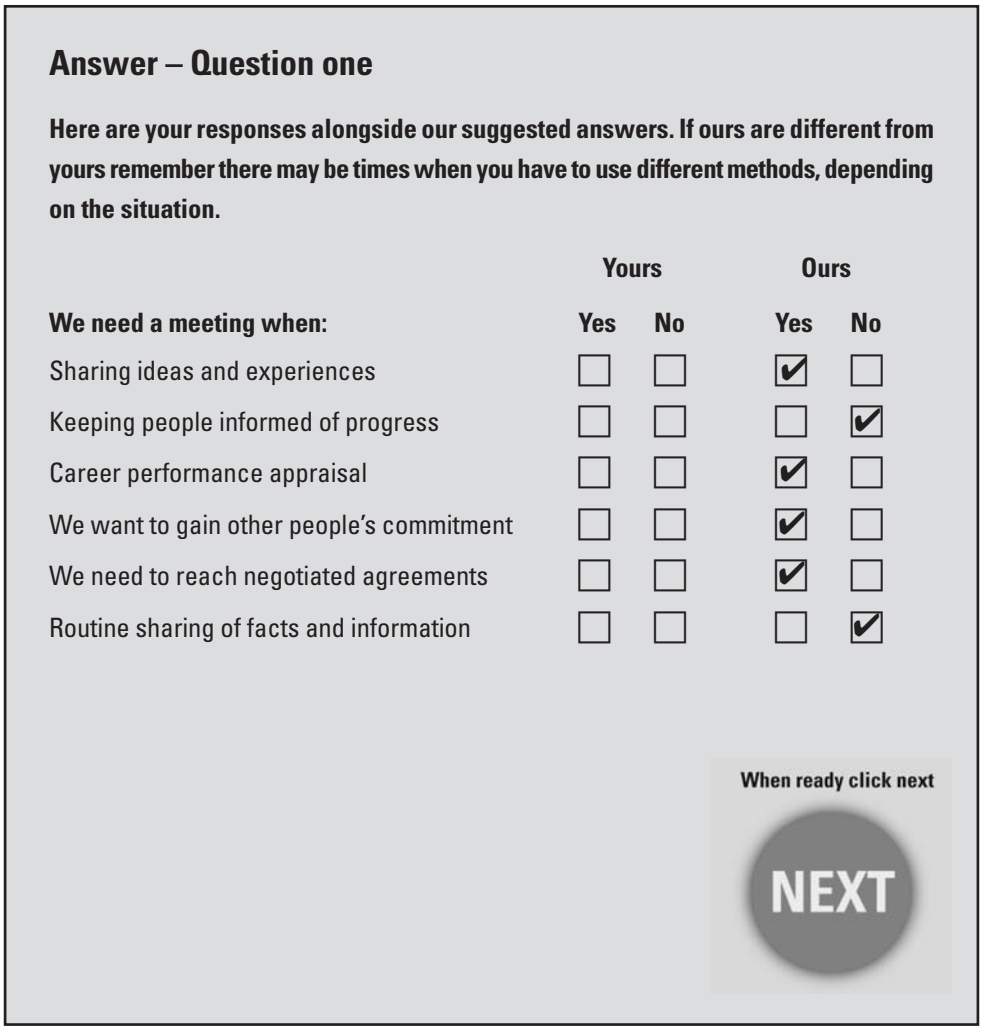
It's not necessary for the learner to use all nine headings.

Store the results for later display in the 'answers' section.

Sample Opening Quiz – Answer to Question 1

The following pages suggest ways of displaying the recommended answers, together with the learner's responses.

The phrasing 'If ours are different from yours remember… depending on the situation' suggests that there isn't an absolute answer.



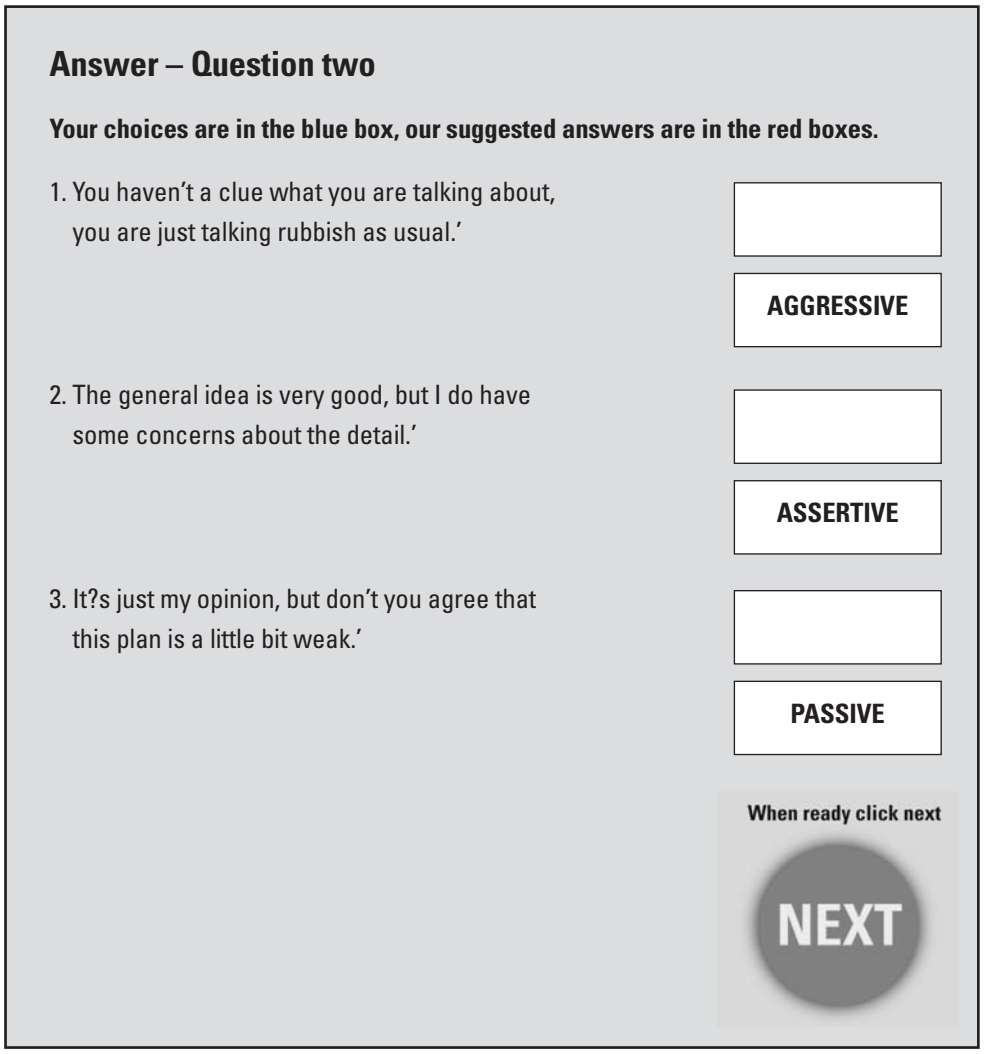
This page displays the learner's responses to question 1, alongside the 'recommended' answers.

Refer the learner to the specific section in the course covering this aspect.

Sample Opening Quiz – Answer to Question 2

This page shows the learner's selection alongside the recommended choices.

If the learner has chosen differently refer them to the appropriate section of the course.



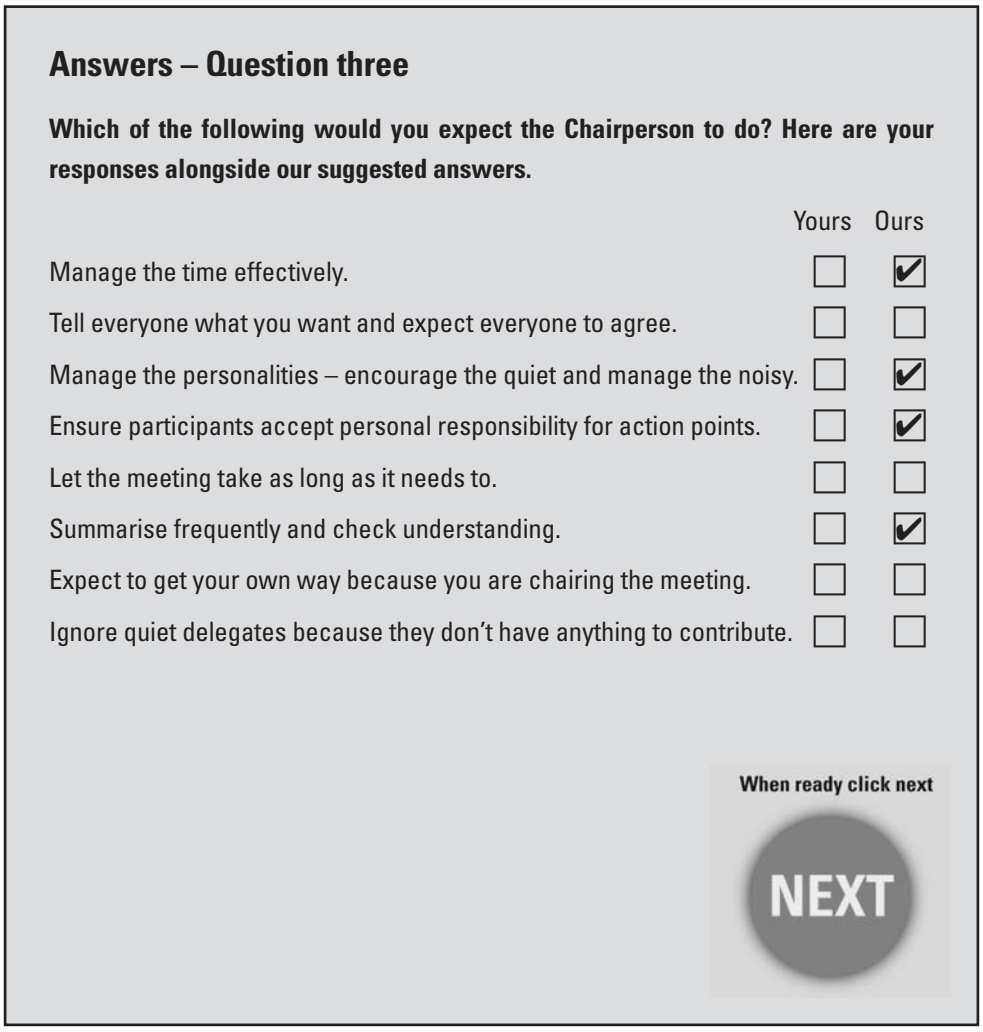
This page displays the learner's responses to question 2, alongside the 'recommended' answers.

Refer the learner to the specific section in the course covering this aspect.

Sample Opening Quiz – Answer to Question 3

This page shows the learner's selection alongside the recommended choices.

If the learner has chosen differently refer them to the appropriate section of the course.



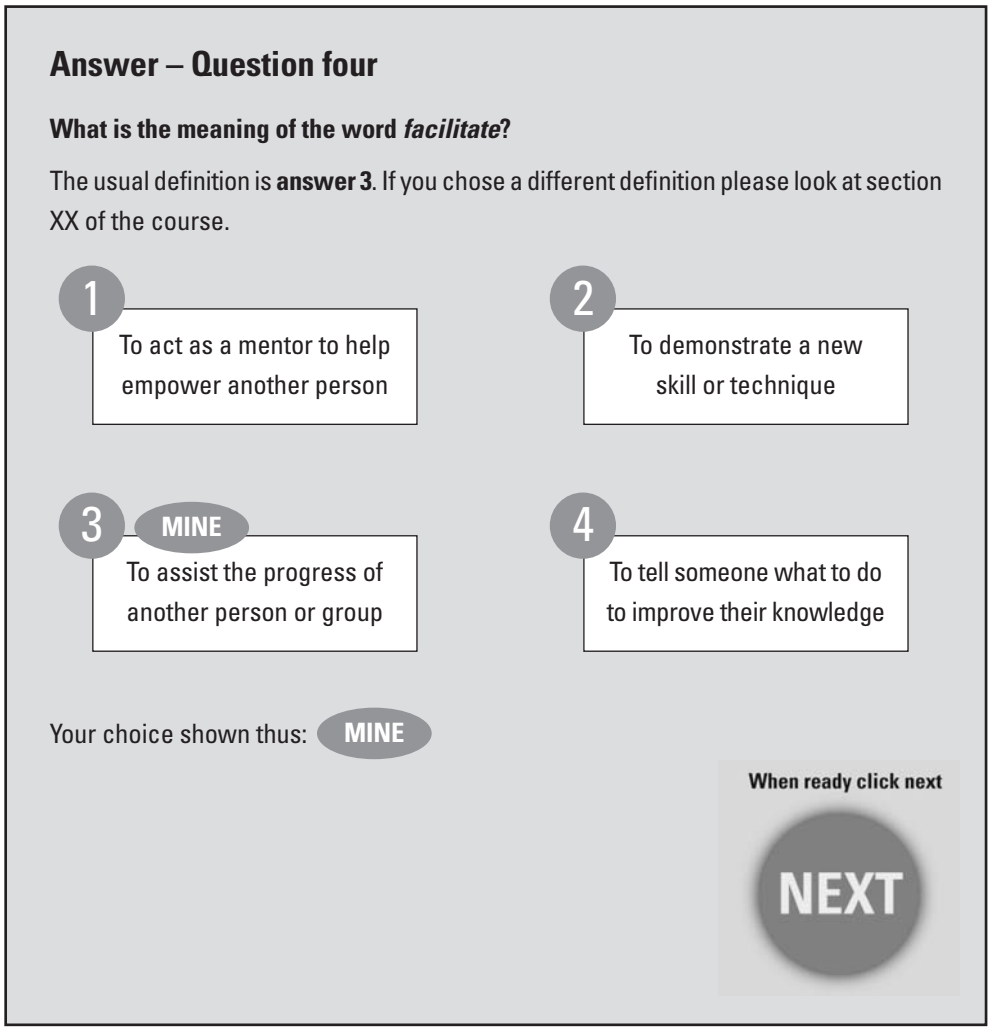
This page displays the learner's responses to question 3, alongside the 'recommended' answers.

Refer the learner to the specific section in the course covering this aspect.

Sample Opening Quiz – Answer to Question 4

This page shows the learner's selection together with the recommended choice.

If the learner has chosen differently refer them to the appropriate section of the course.



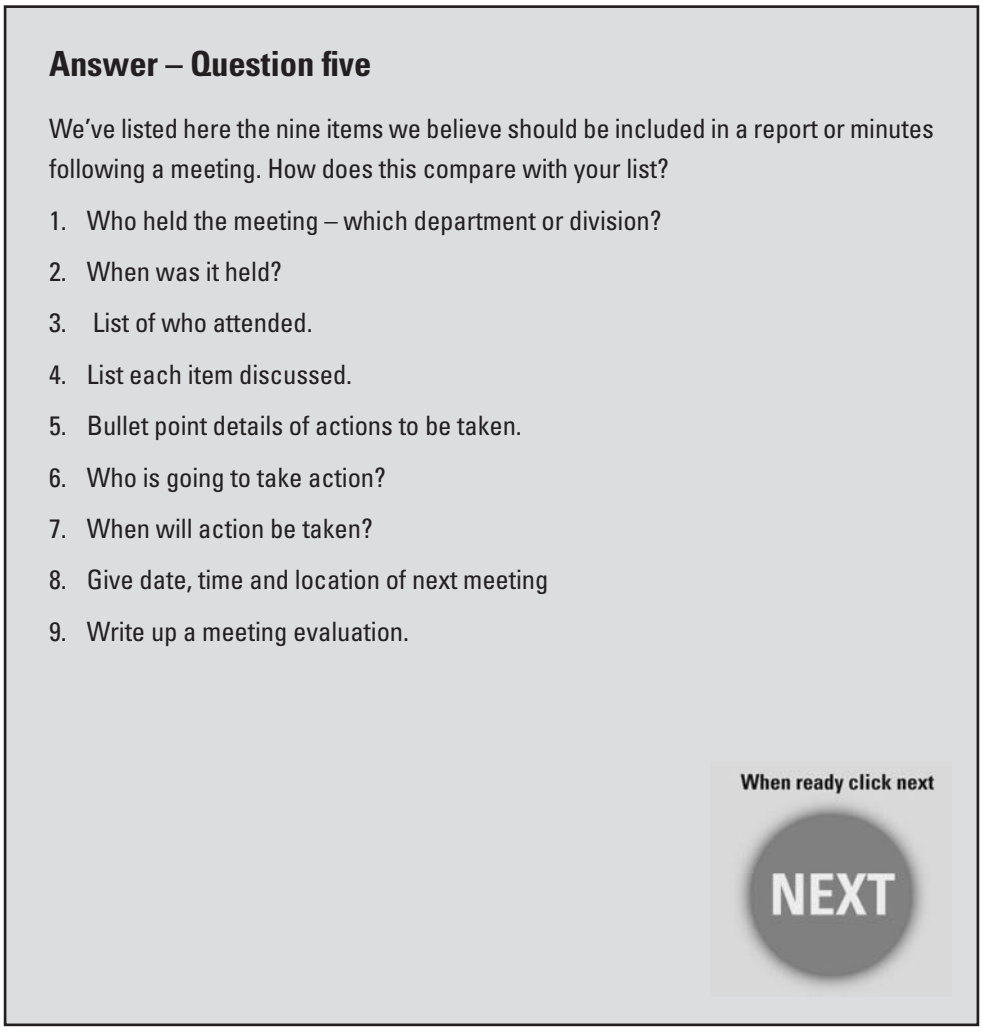
This page displays the learner's responses to question 4, alongside the 'recommended' answer.

Refer the learner to the specific section in the course covering this aspect.

Sample Opening Quiz – Answer to Question 5

This page shows the recommended list of nine items.

It might be very complicated to make a comparison between this list and how the learner has actually responded.

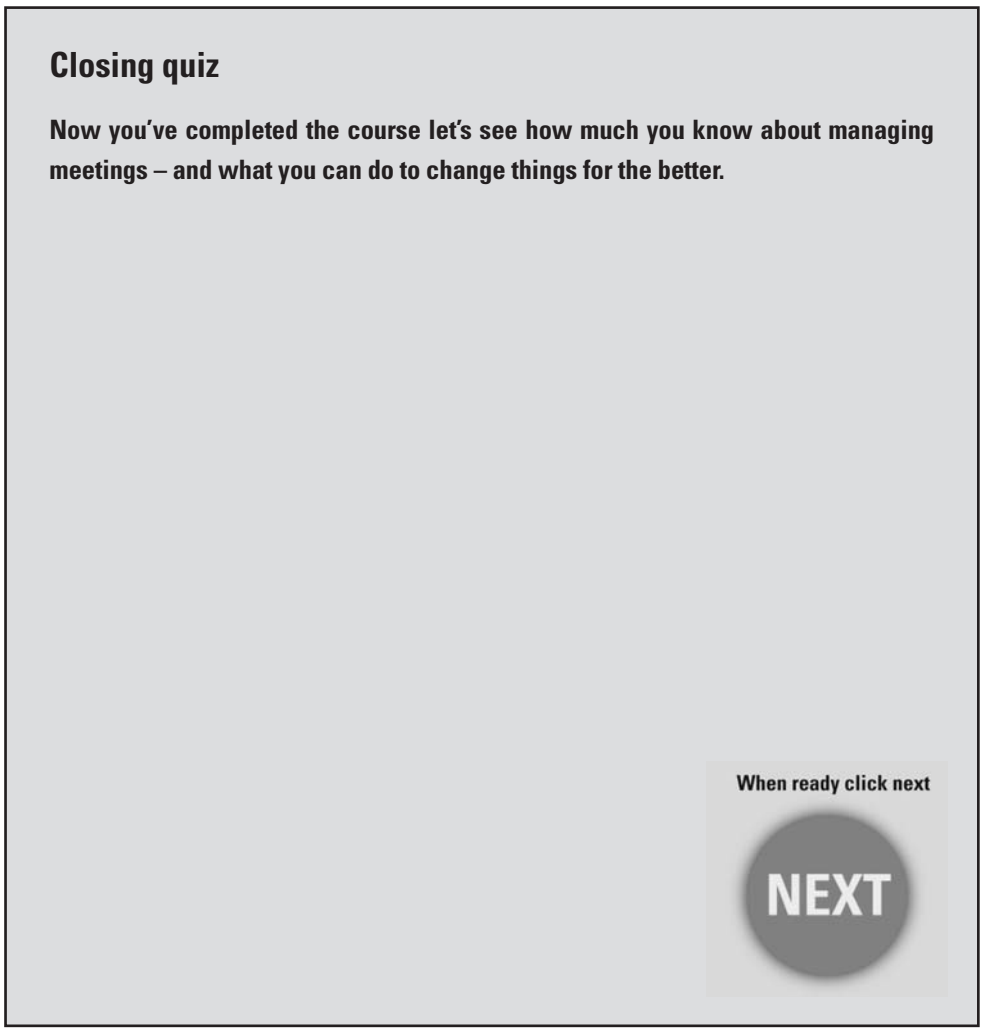


This page displays the learner's responses to question 5, alongside the 'recommended' answers.

Refer the learner to the specific section in the course covering this aspect.

Resource 5: Sample Closing Quiz

This tells the learner what's going to happen, and invites them to complete the quiz.



Sample Closing Quiz – Question 1

This Question asks the learner to list a maximum of seven items.

The results will be stored and displayed later in the 'answers' section.

On this occasion there are no 'right' answers – just a recommended list.



The learner types in their own ideas alongside the numbered sections.

The system should allow the learner to enter a specified amount of text alongside each heading.

It's not necessary for the learner to use all seven headings.

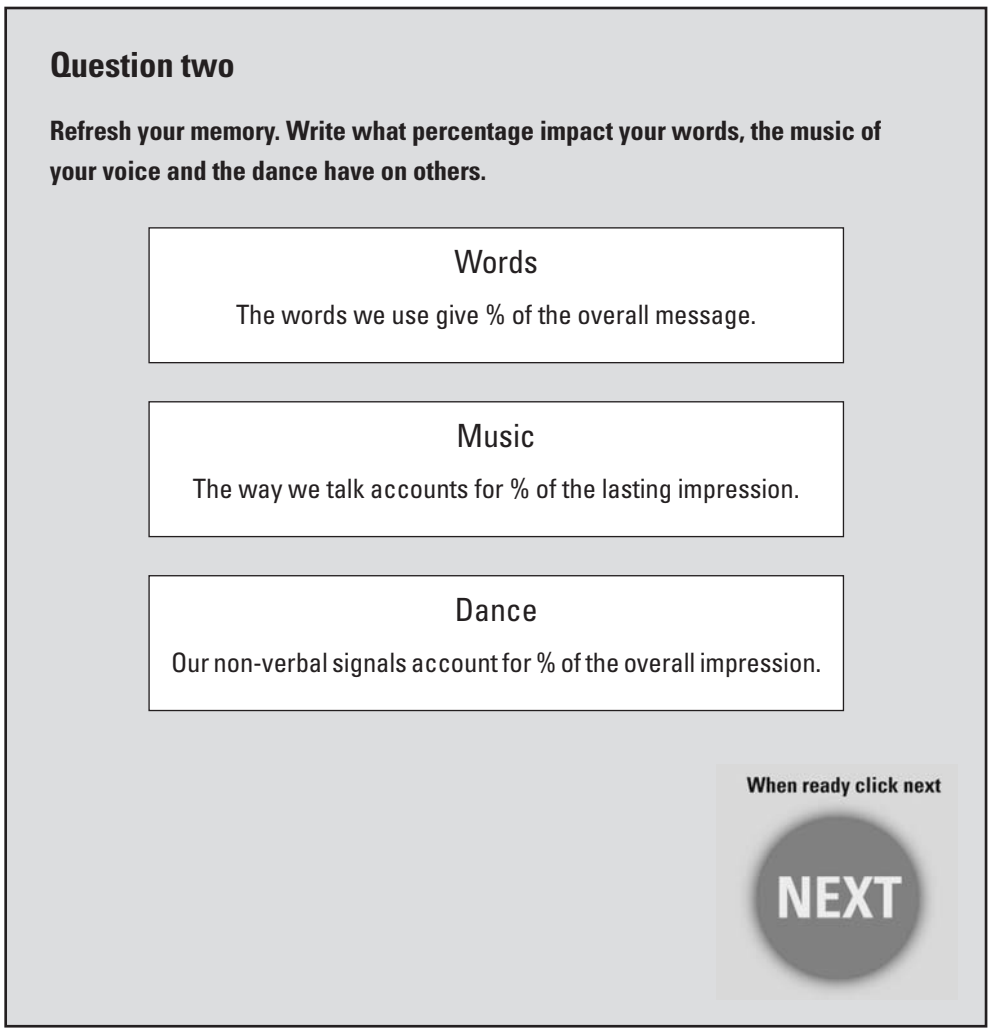
Store the results for later display in the 'answers' section.

Sample Closing Quiz – Question 2

This Question asks the learner to enter a number in each of three boxes.

The three numbers must add up to 100%.

The results will be stored and displayed later in the 'answers' section.



The learner enters one number in each of the three boxes.

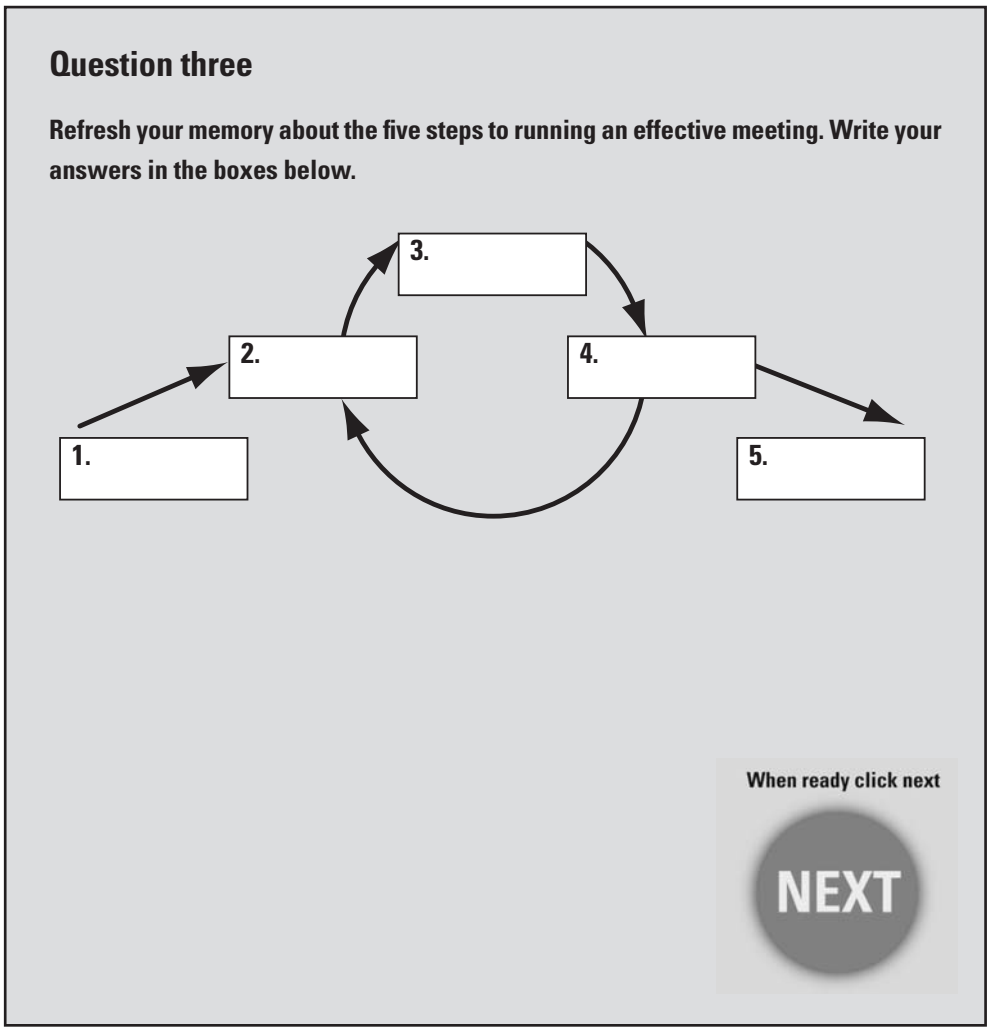
Prompt the learner if the numbers don't add up to 100.

Store the results for later display in the 'answers' section.

Sample Closing Quiz – Question 3

This Question asks the learner to enter the names of the steps in the appropriate boxes.

The results will be stored and displayed later in the 'answers' section.



The learner enters text in the five boxes.

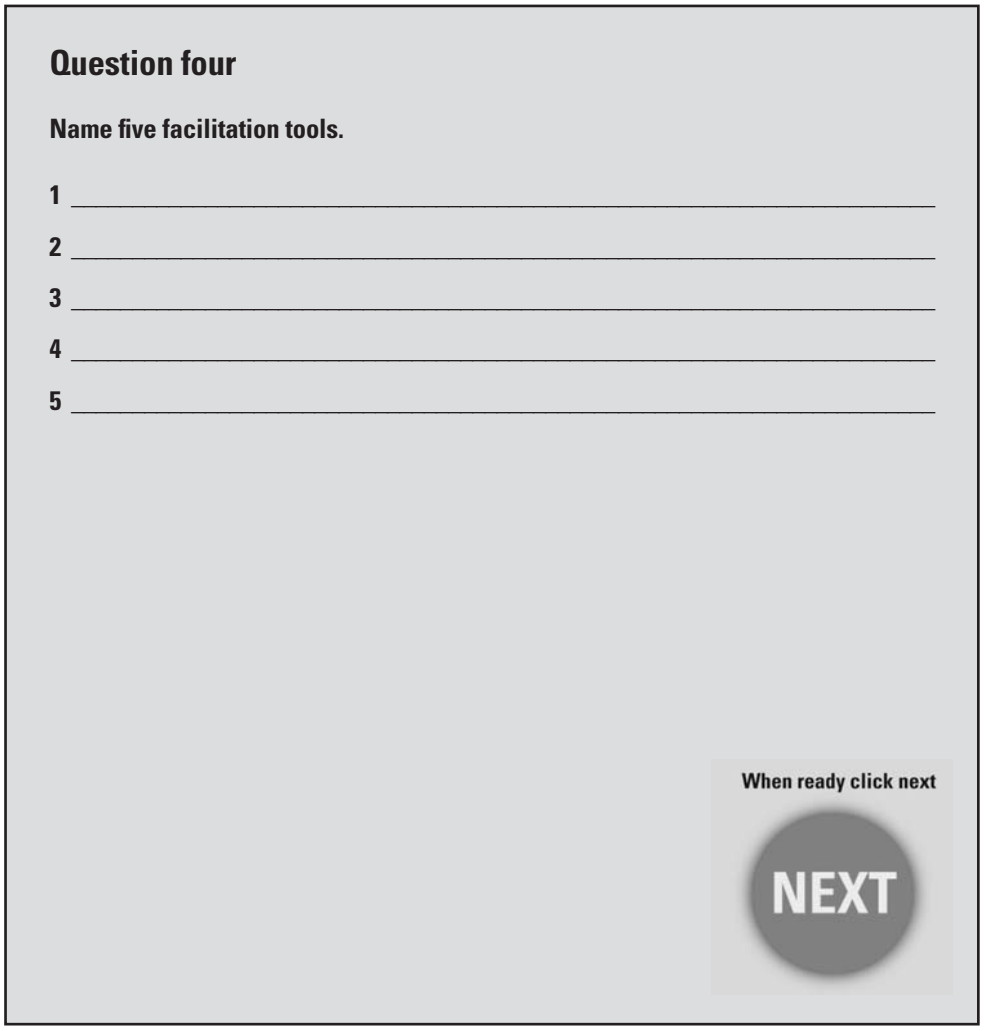
Prompt the learner if any boxes are left unfilled.

Store the results for later display in the 'answers' section.

Sample Closing Quiz – Question 4

This Question asks the learner to enter five facilitation techniques in the boxes.

The result will be stored and displayed later in the 'answers' section.



The learner types in their own ideas alongside the numbered sections.

The system should allow the learner to enter a specified amount of text alongside each heading.

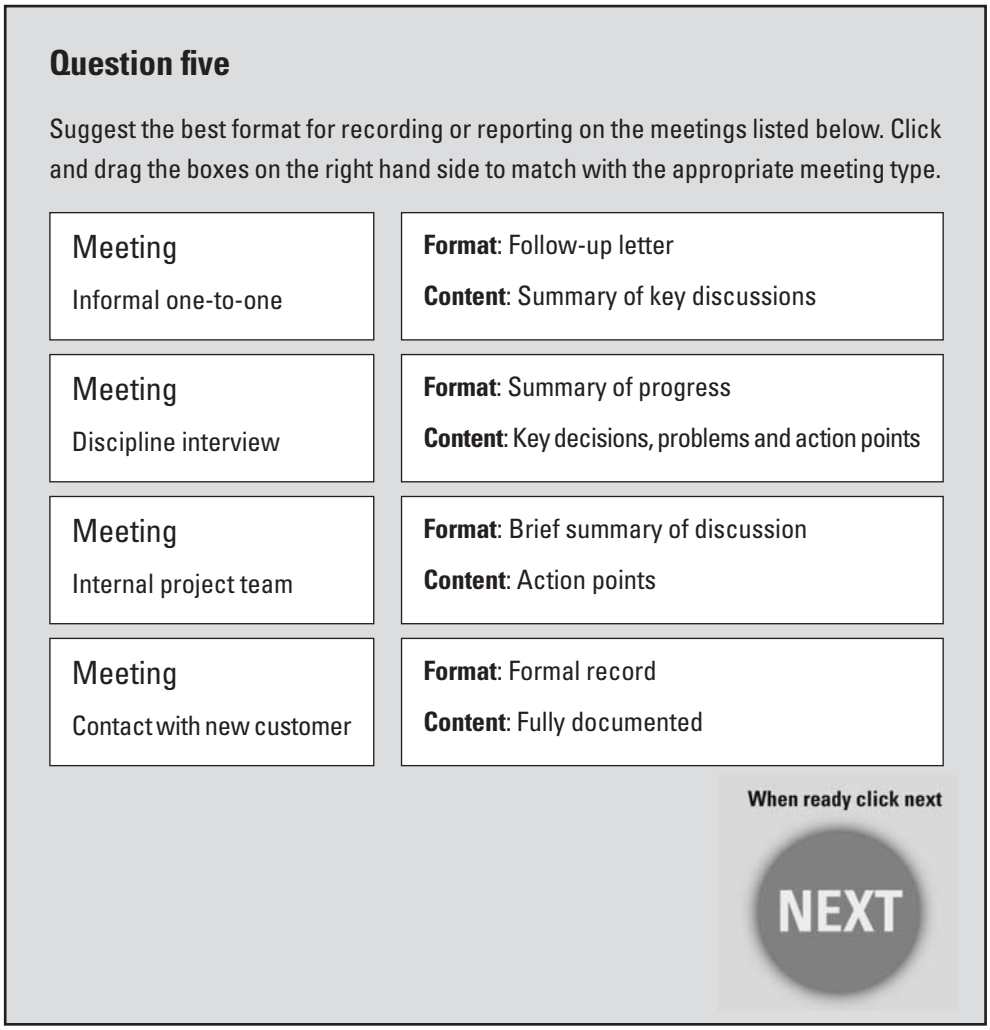
It's not necessary for the learner to use all five headings.

Store the results for later display in the 'answers' section.

Sample Closing Quiz – Question 5

This Question asks the learner to click and drag the 'format' boxes to the appropriate 'meeting' boxes.

The results will be stored and displayed later in the 'answers' section.



The learner clicks and drags the boxes as asked.

Store the results for later display in the 'answers' section.

Sample Closing Quiz – Answer to Question 1

The following pages suggest ways of displaying the recommended answers, together with the learner's responses.

This page shows the list of seven recommended items for an effective agenda.

And invites the learner to compare it with his/her response.

Answer – Question one

We've listed here the seven items we believe should be in an effective agenda. How does this compare with your list?

1. A clear title
2. The objective of the meeting.
3. Date
4. Time
5. Place
6. List of topics
7. Timings against each item

When ready click next



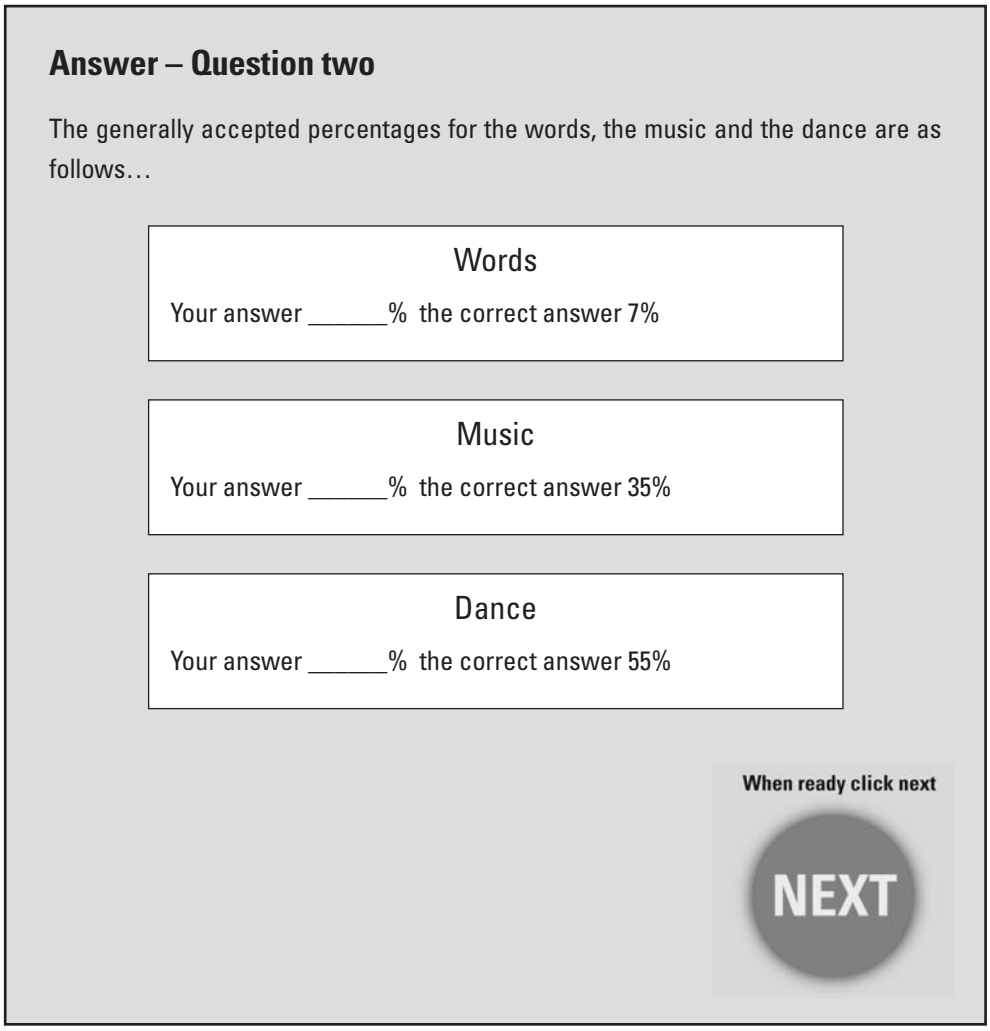
This page displays the learner's responses to question 1, alongside the 'recommended' answers.

Refer the learner to the specific section in the course covering this aspect.

Sample Closing Quiz – Answer to Question 2

This page shows the learner's responses alongside the recommended percentages.

If the learner has proposed different percentages refer them to the appropriate section of the course.



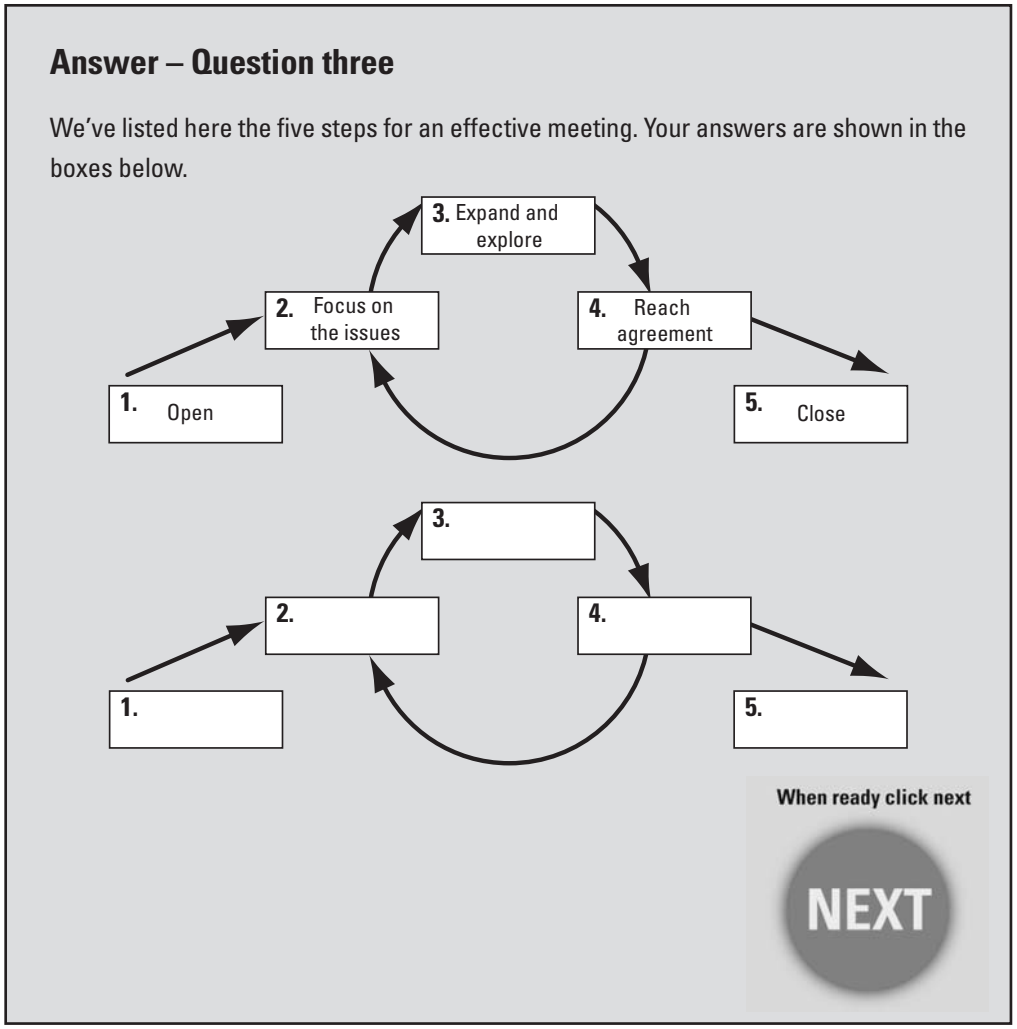
This page displays the learner's responses to question 2, alongside the 'recommended' answers.

Refer the learner to the specific section in the course covering this aspect.

Sample Closing Quiz – Answer to Question 3

This page shows the learner's suggested headings underneath the recommended choices.

If the learner has chosen differently refer them to the appropriate section of the course.



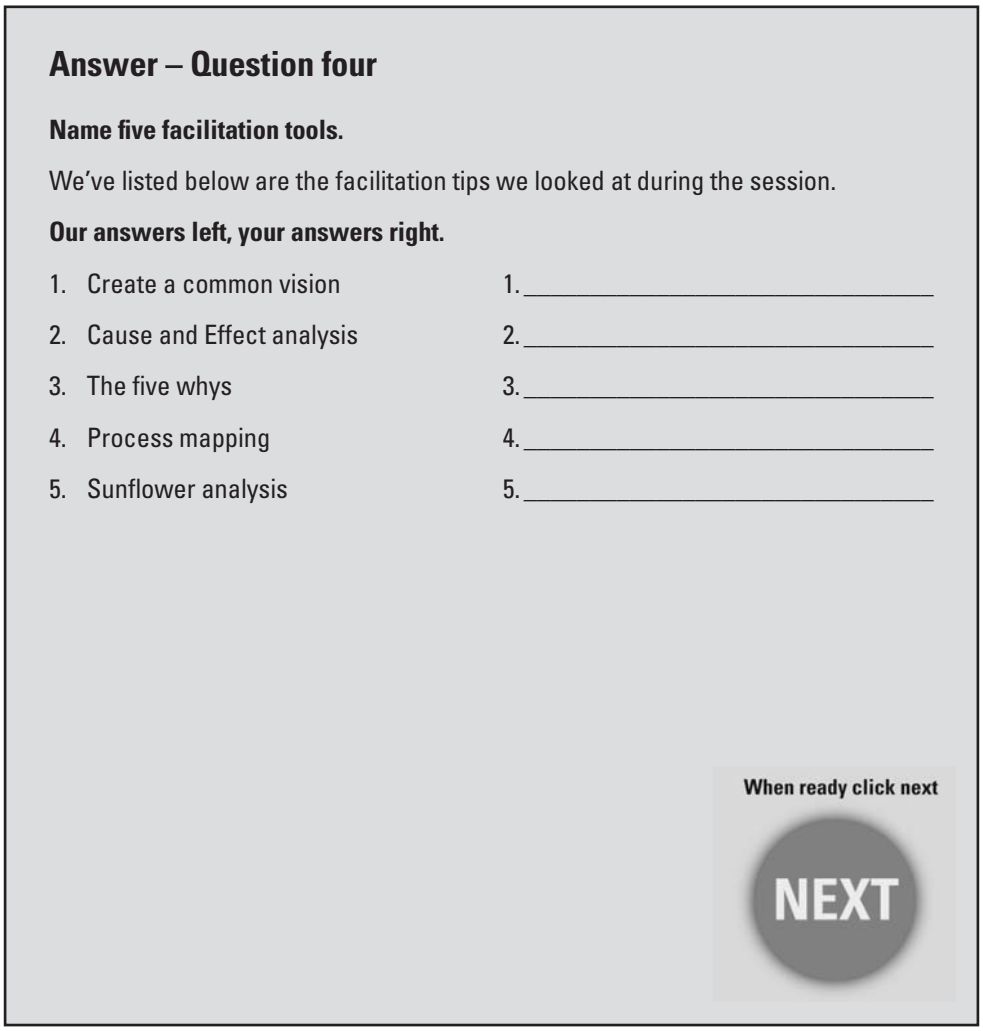
This page displays the learner's responses to question 3, alongside the 'recommended' answers.

Refer the learner to the specific section in the course covering this aspect.

Sample Closing Quiz – Answer to Question 4

This page shows the learner's responses together with the recommended answers.

If the learner has chosen differently refer them to the appropriate section of the course.



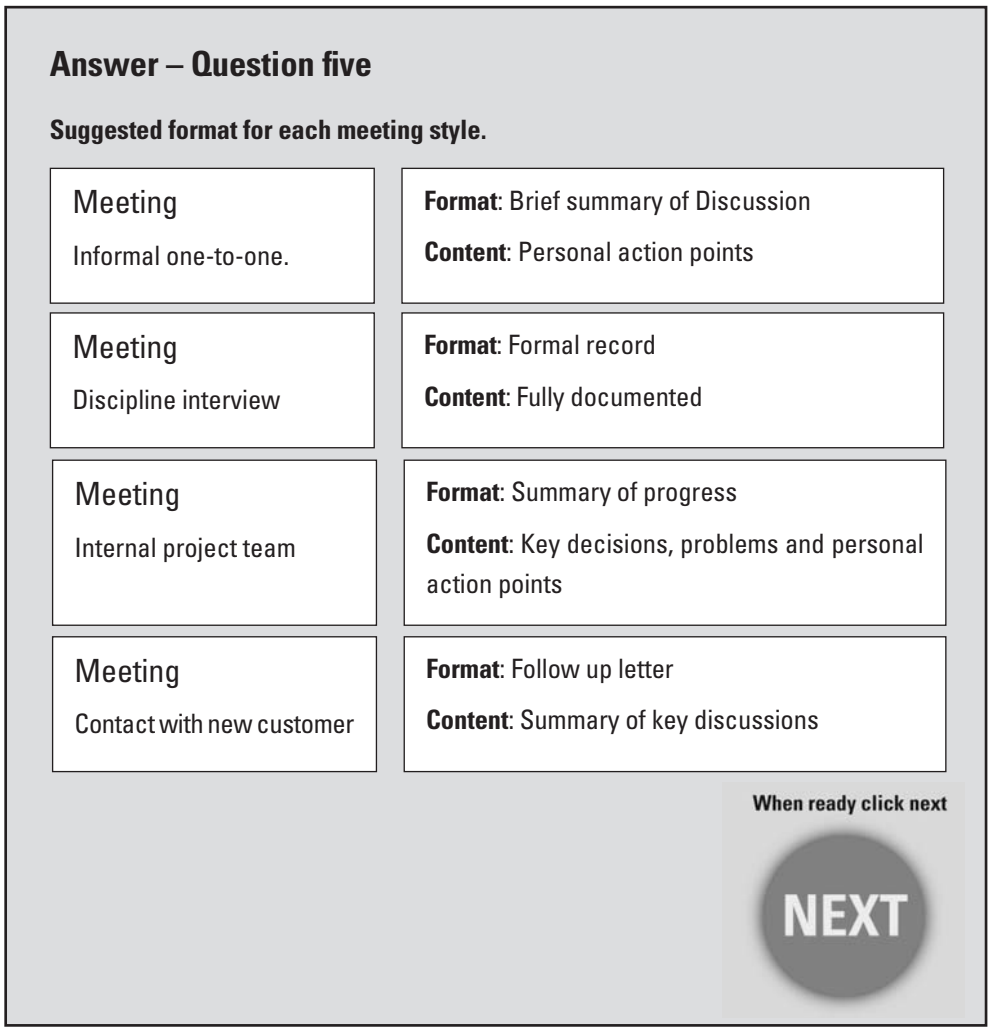
This page displays the learner's responses to question 4, alongside the 'recommended' answers.

Refer the learner to the specific section in the course covering this aspect.

Sample Closing Quiz – Answer to Question 5

This page shows the recommended allocation of report formats to meeting types.

If the learner has chosen differently refer them to the appropriate section of the course.



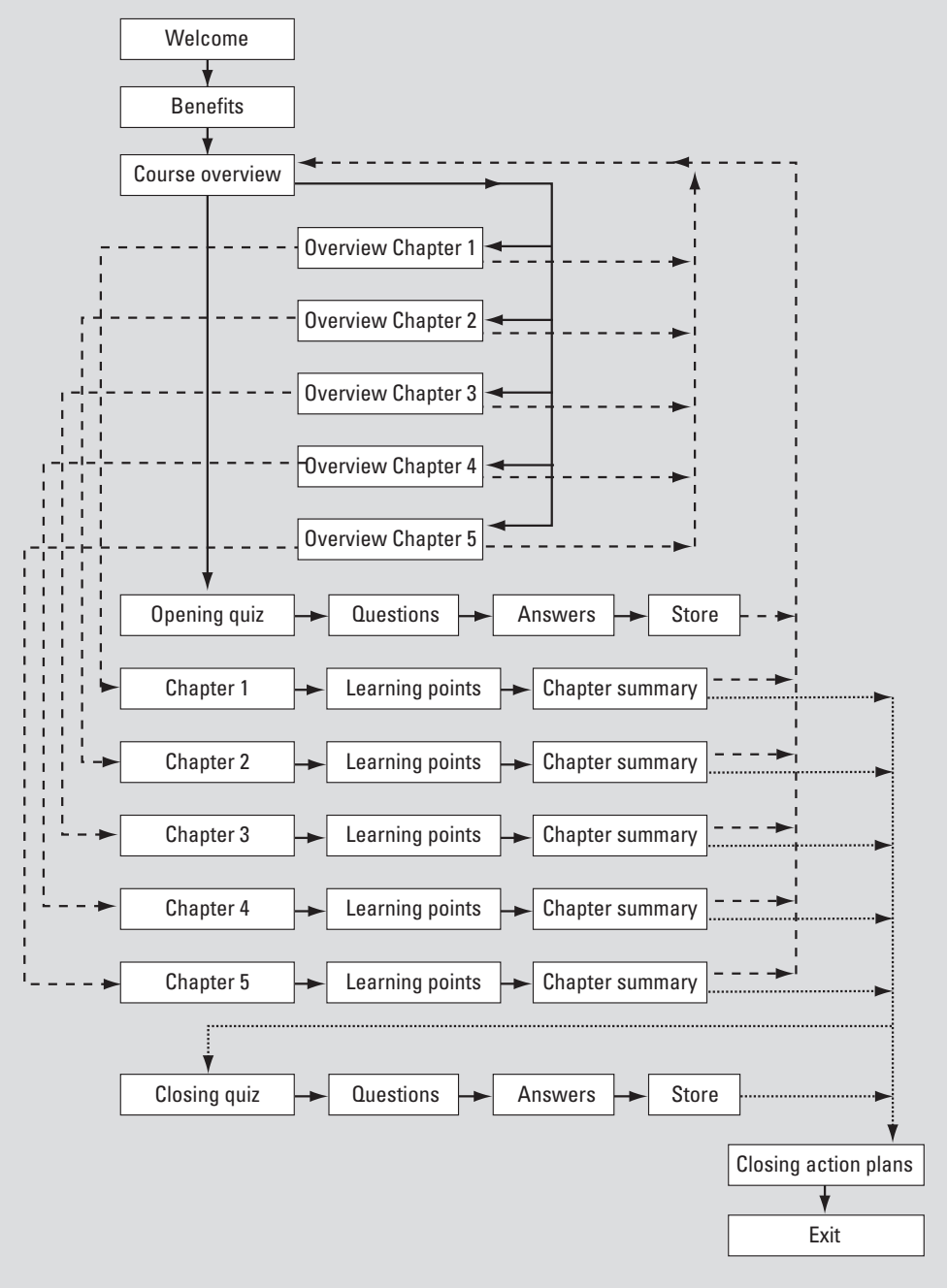
This page displays the learner's responses to question 5, alongside the 'recommended' answers.

Refer the learner to the specific section in the course covering this aspect.

Resource 6: Course Flowchart

The results of the opening and closing quizzes are stored to be used:

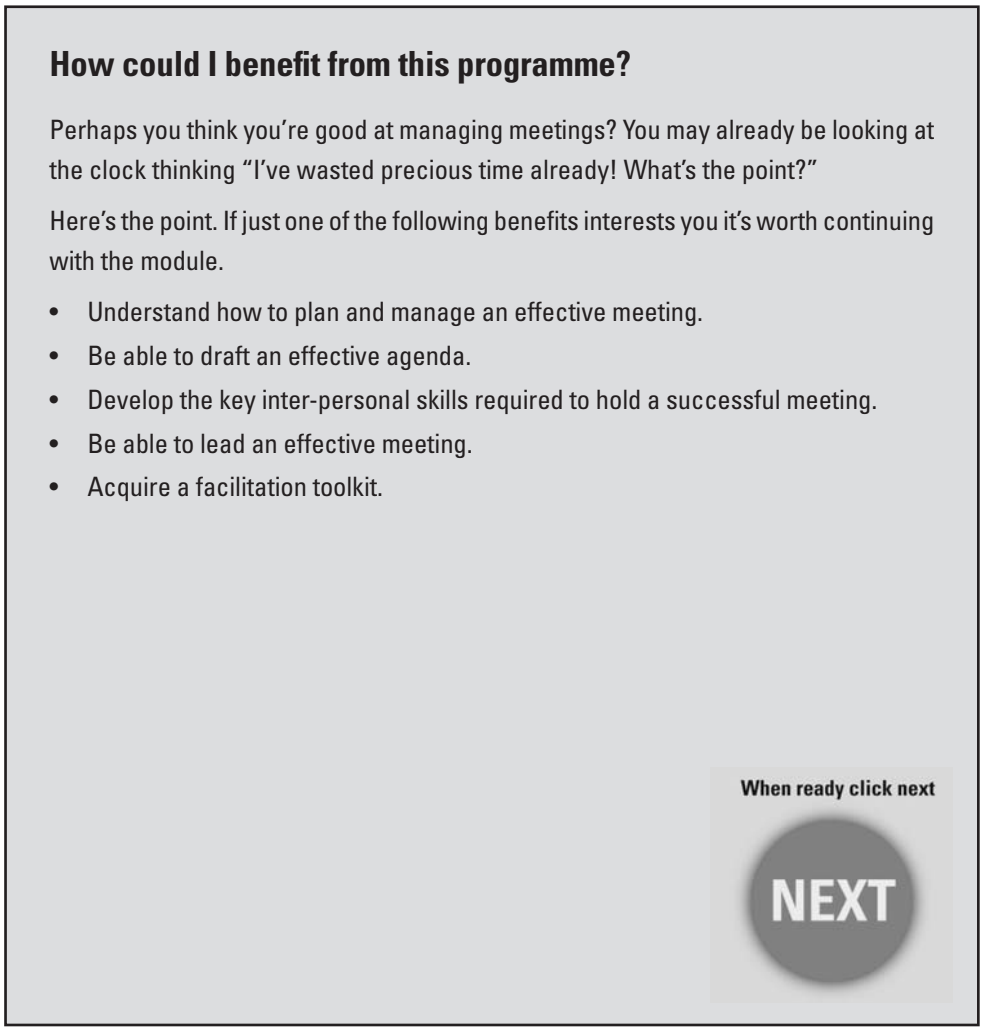
- During the relevant chapter
- To redirect learners to chapters they need to revisit
- To be accumulated towards an individual learner's record of study



Resource 7: Sample Screens

Sample screen 1

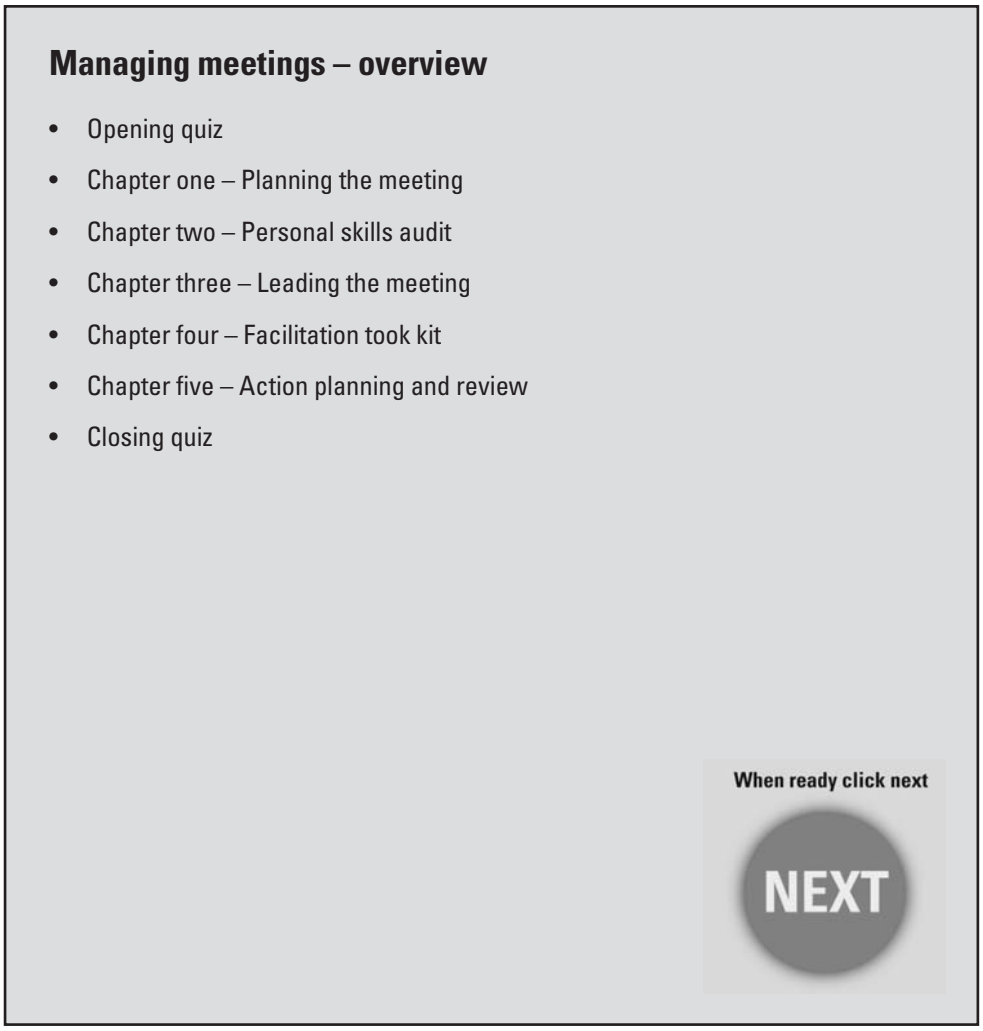
This screen displays the main benefits of completing the course which should motivate the learner to want to get started.



Sample screen 2

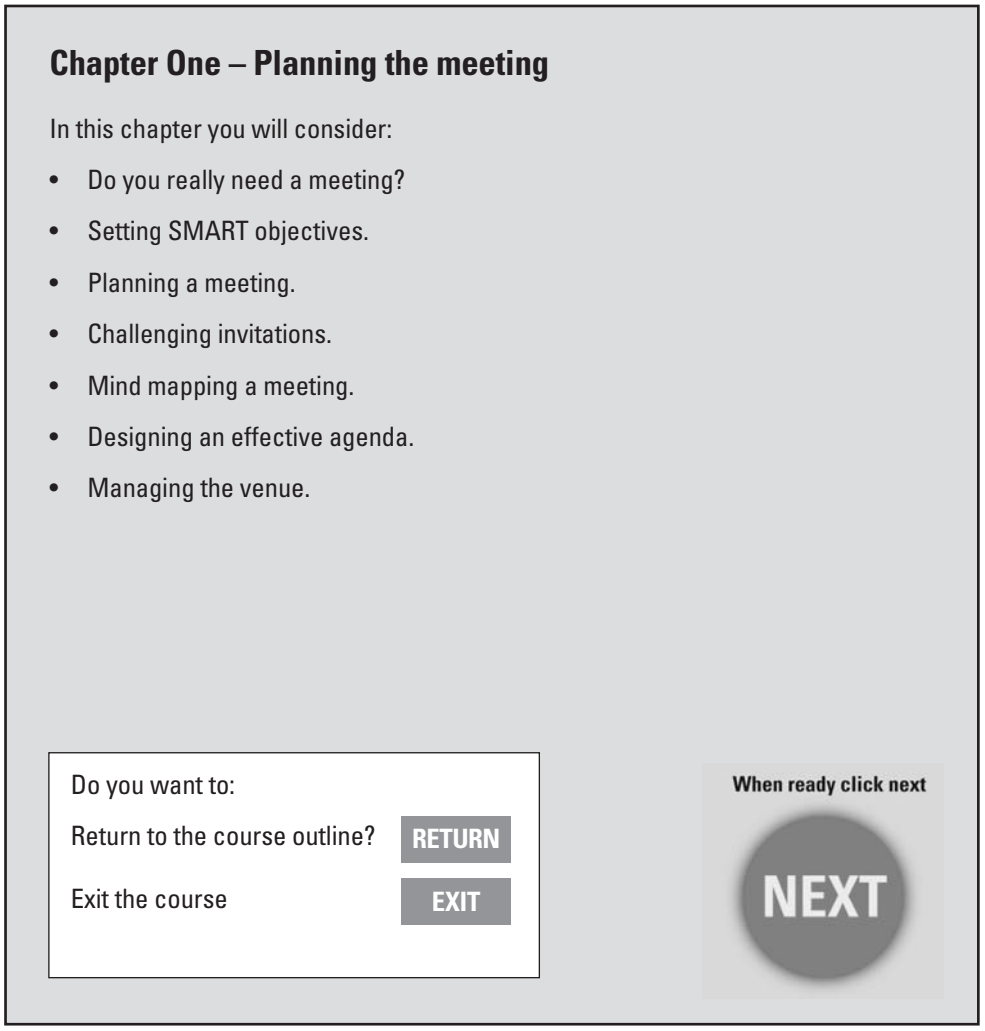
The course overview shows the learner the total course and, by clicking on any line, they get a more detailed breakdown of that module.

This screen can also show which modules they have completed.



Sample screen 3

This screen shows the learner what they can expect to learn in Chapter One, and then gives them options.



Do you need a meeting?

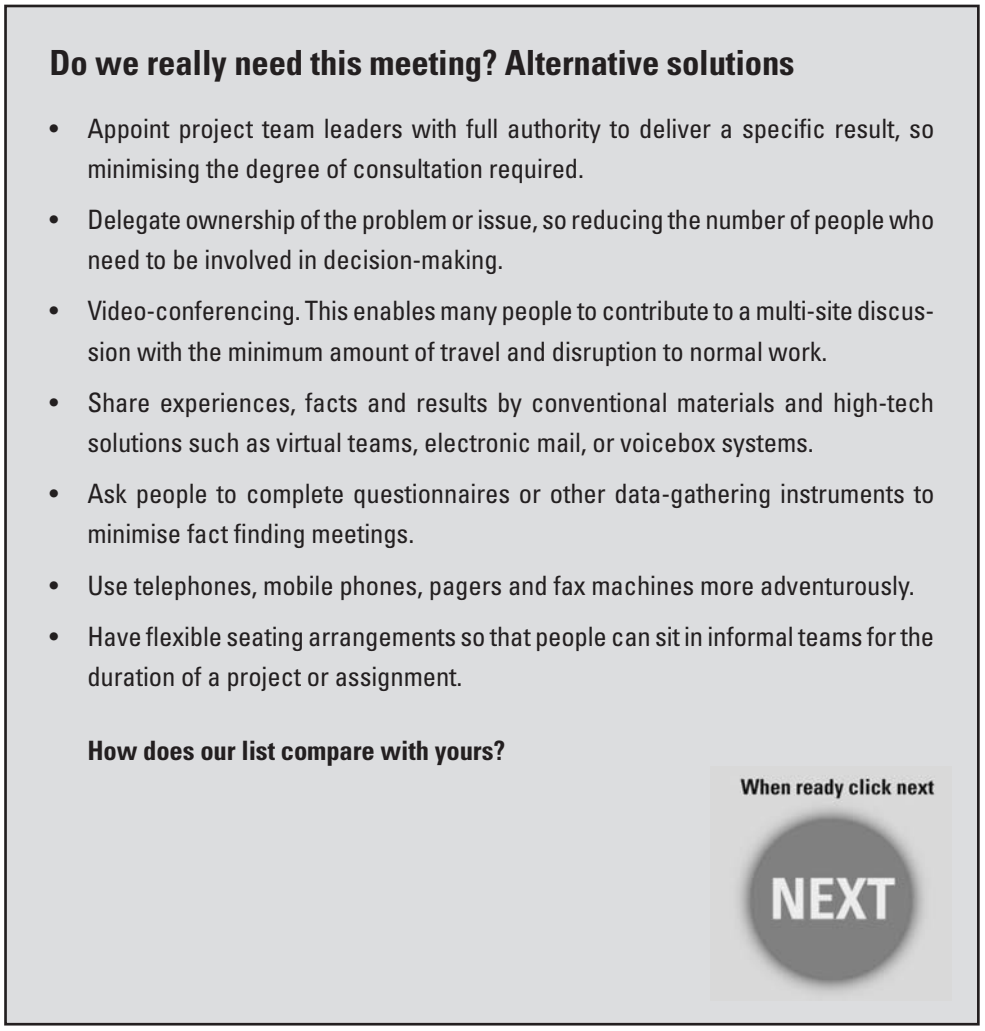
Sample screen 4

This screen involves the learner right at the start by asking them to consider two important questions, and getting them to input some ideas onto the screen.



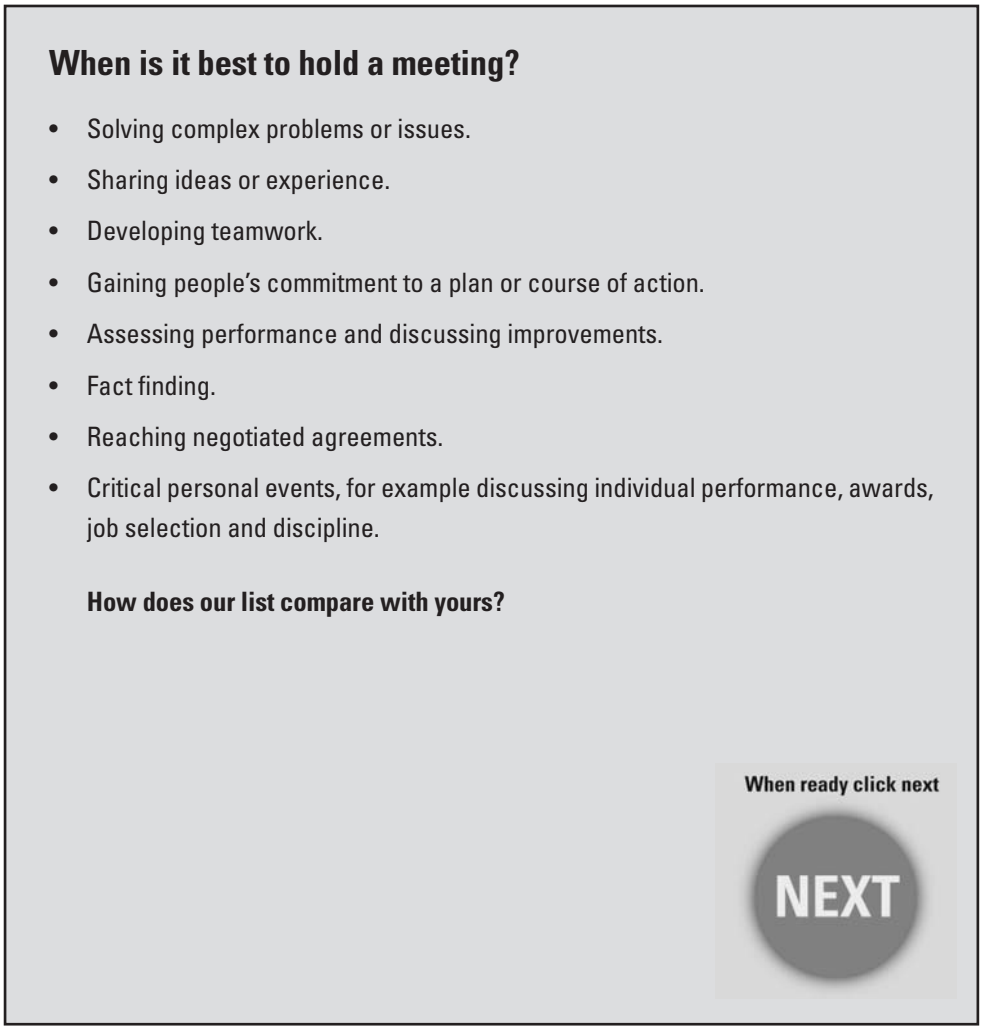
Sample screen 5

This screen follows up by offering a number of alternatives to holding a meeting, then asks the learner to compare this list with theirs.



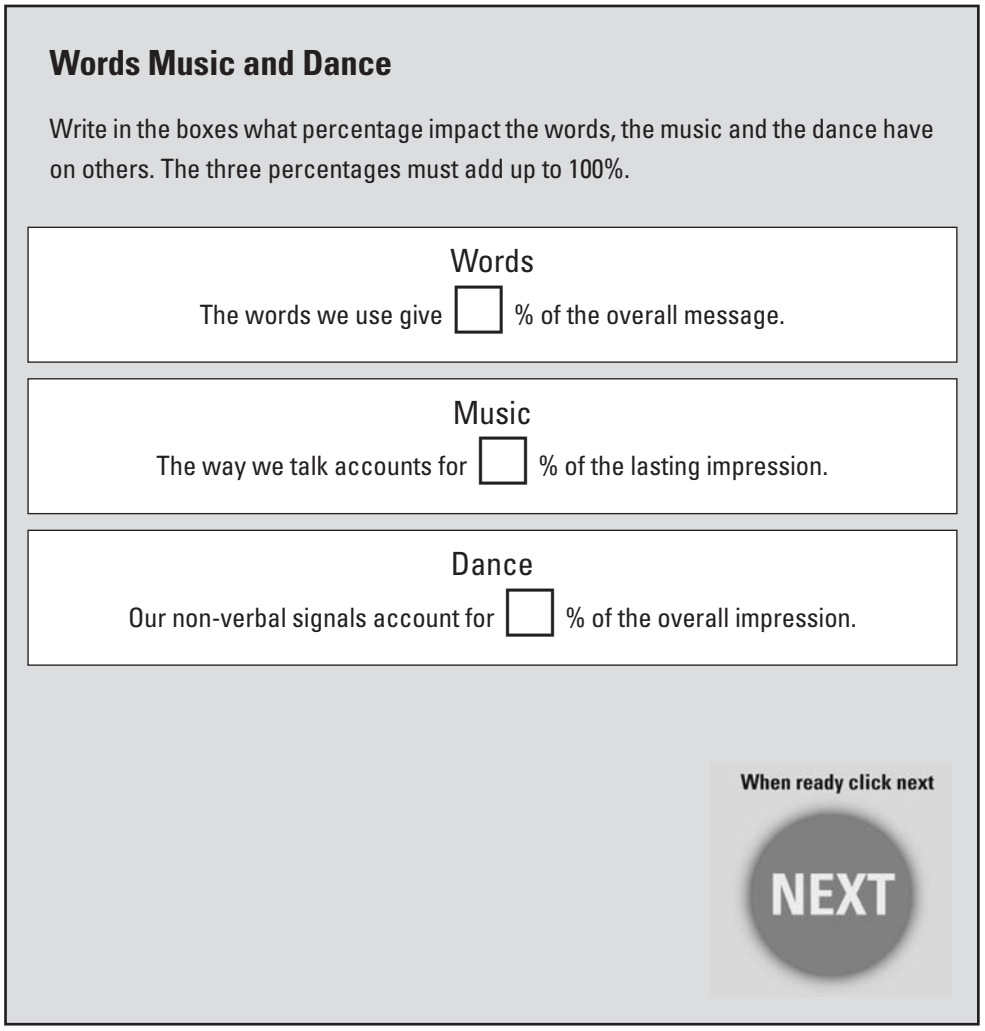
Sample screen 6

This screen expands on the basic question of when it's best to hold a meeting and sets out eight ideas, then asks the learner to compare this list with theirs.



Sample screen 7

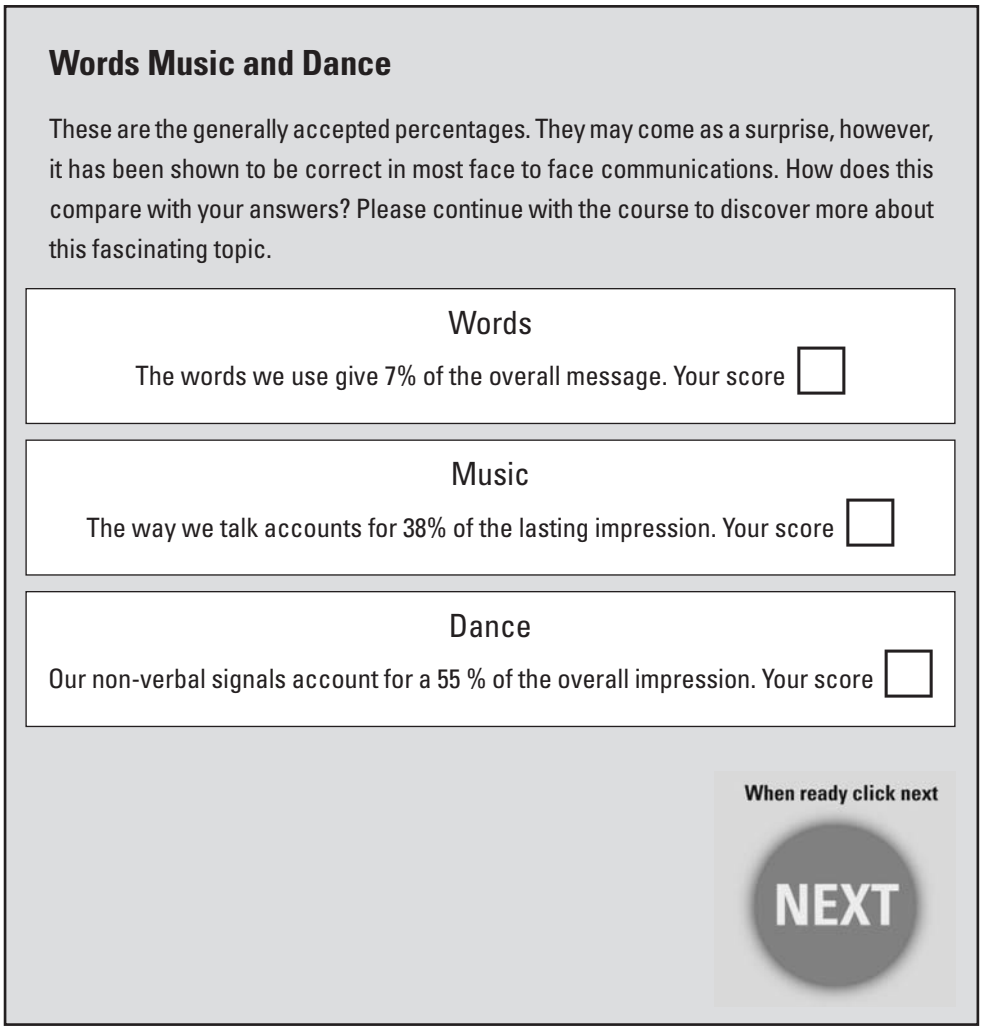
You pose a specific question and ask the learner to enter their responses on the screen.



Sample screen 8

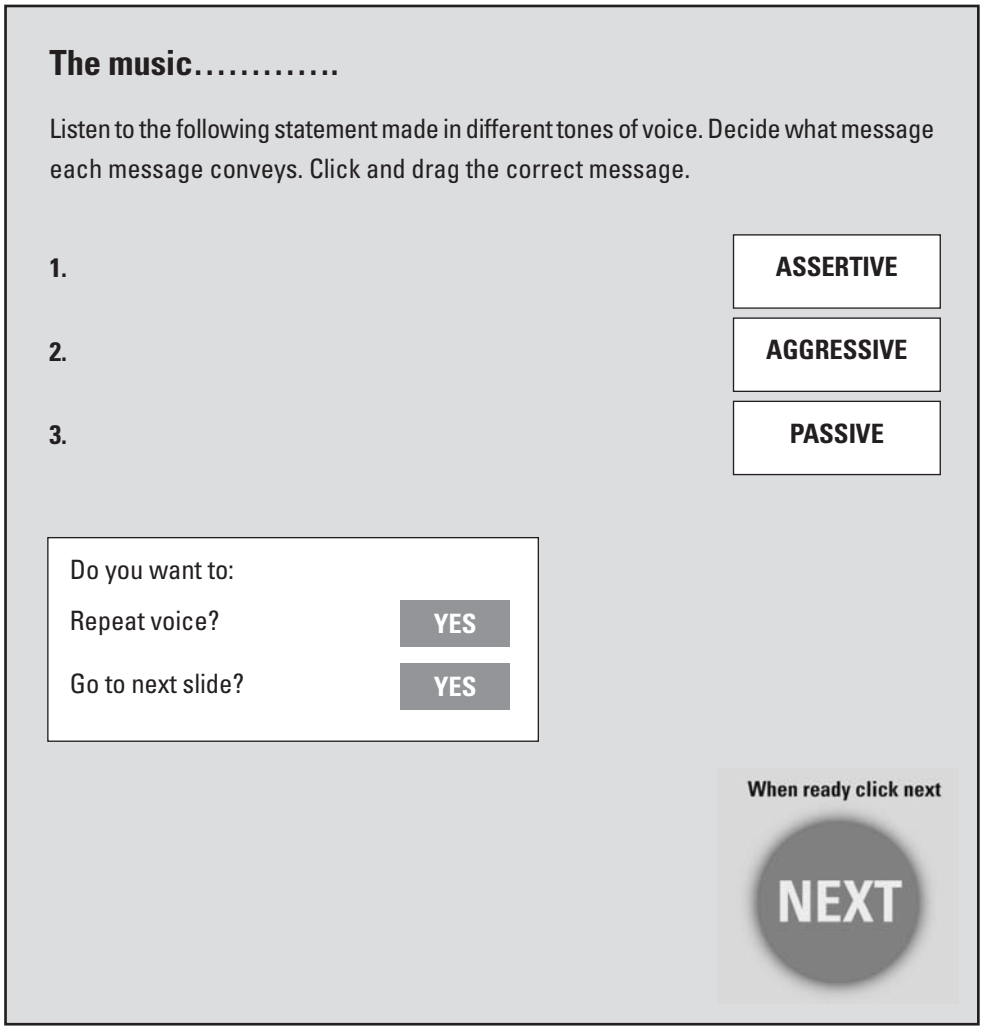
This screen will show the 'right' answers, and display the learner's responses.

It asks the learner to reflect on any differences between the responses and to continue to learn more about the topic.



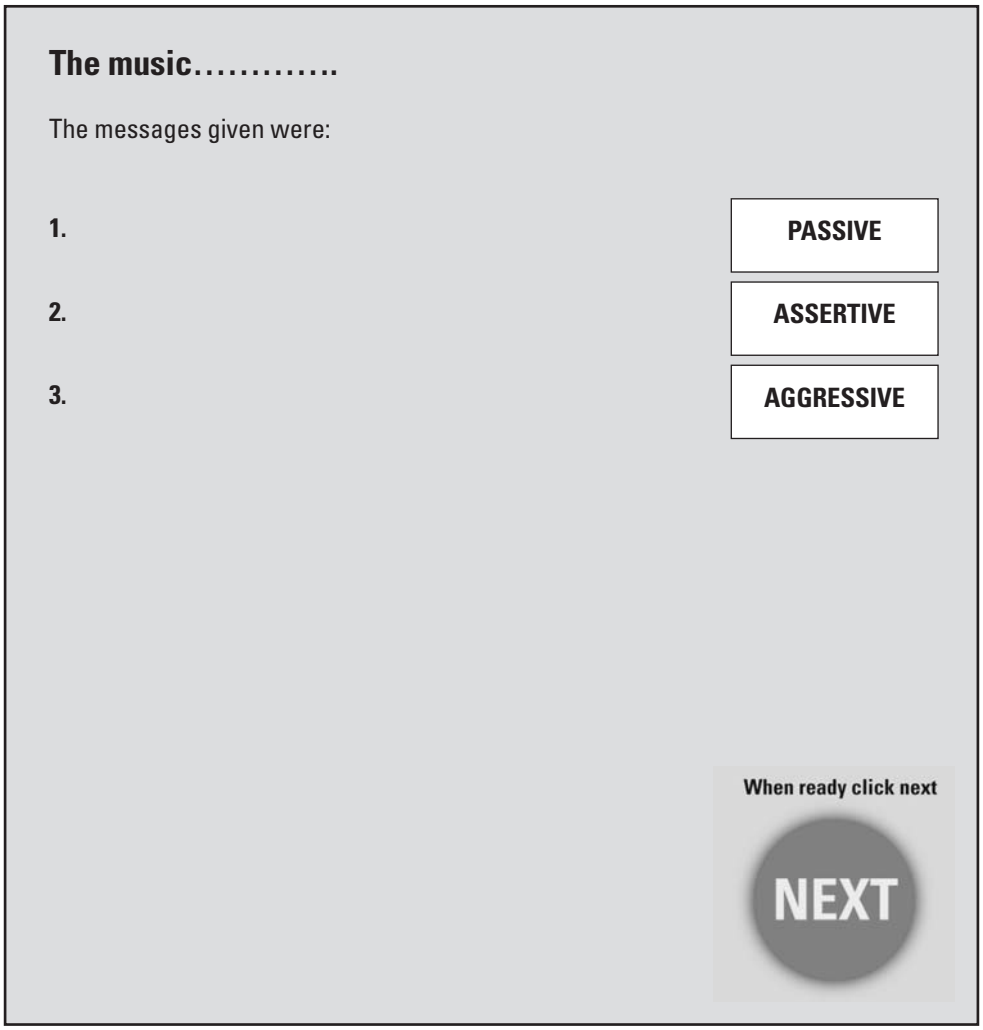
Sample screen 9

The learner is asked to listen to the same phrase spoken three different ways and decide which is assertive, which is aggressive and which is passive.



Sample screen 10

This screen shows the most appropriate interpretation of the audio demonstration.



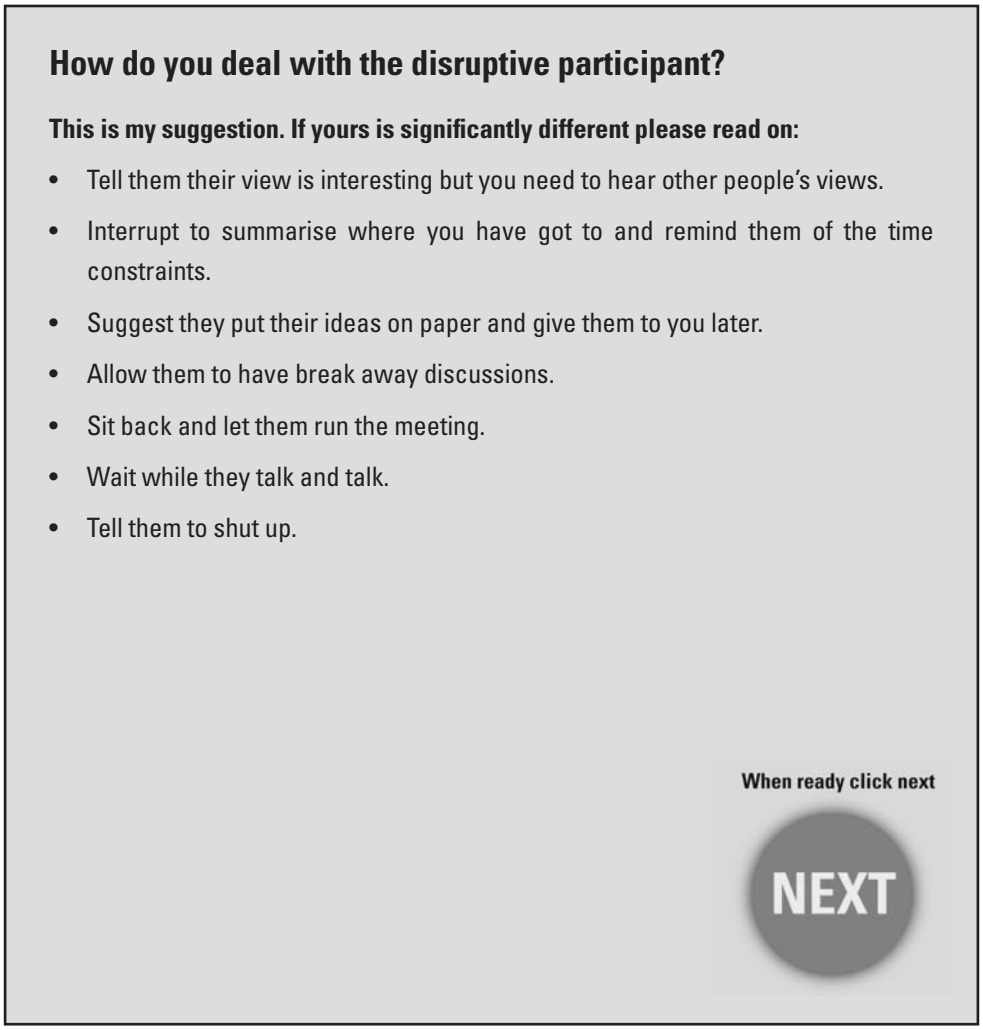
Sample screen 11

This screen invites the learner to decide how they would deal with a disruptive person at a meeting. They are asked to rearrange the list in their preferred order.



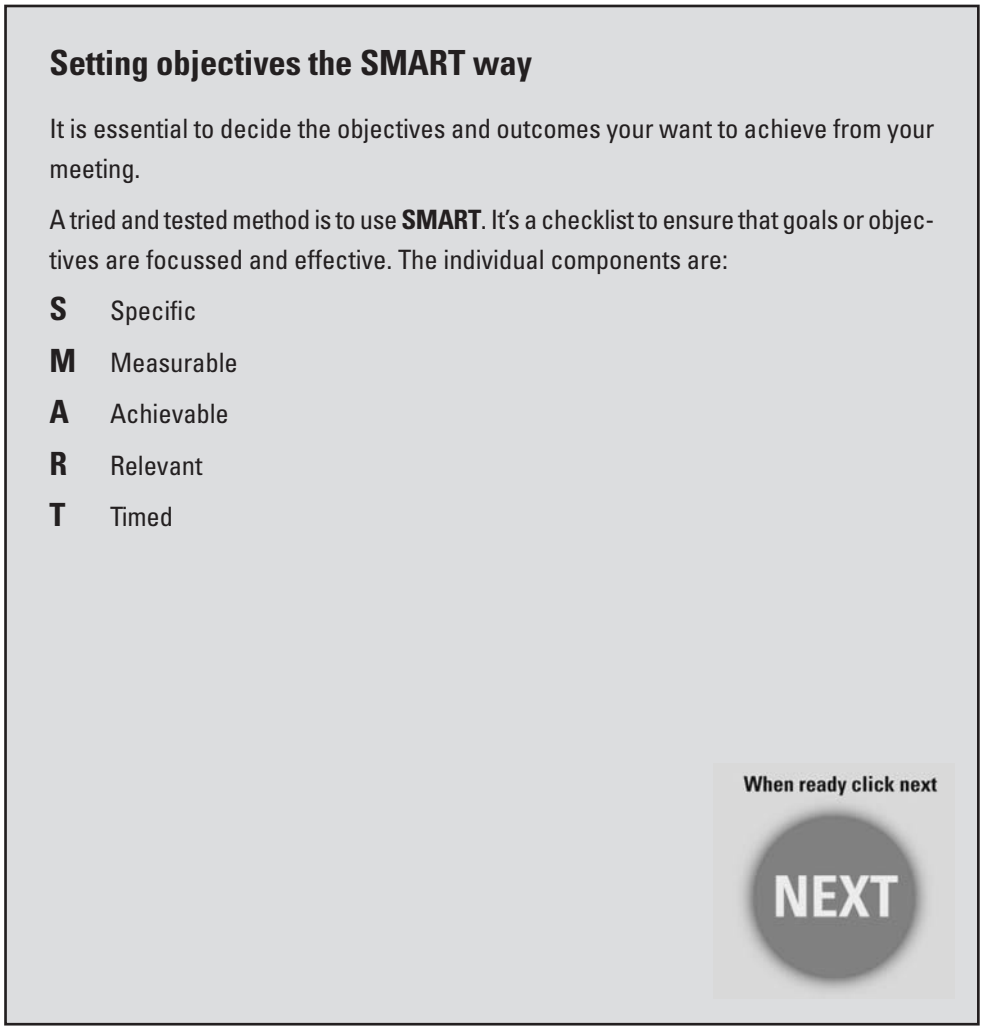
Sample screen 12

This shows the recommended order compared with the learner's choice, and invites them to read on if significantly different.



Sample screen 13

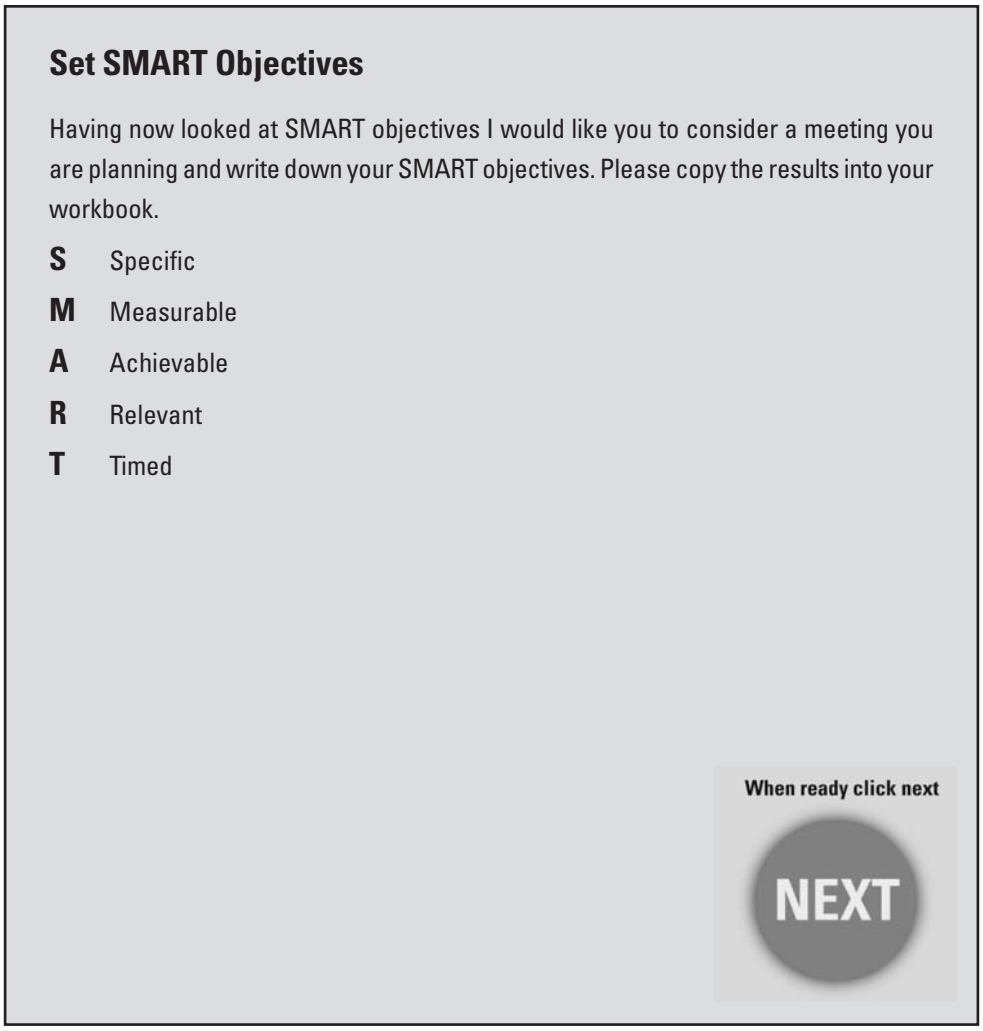
This screen introduced the concept of setting SMART objectives. It was followed by five further screens which explored each aspect of SMART in depth.



Sample screen 14

Now the learner understands SMART in theory – but can they use it?

This screen invites the learner to write a SMART objective for a meeting they will soon be holding.



Sample page 15

This is how the page could appear in the learner's workbook, mirroring the information given on the screen.

3

Set SMART Objectives

Having now looked at SMART objectives I would like you to consider a meeting you are planning and write down your SMART objectives.

Specific

Measurable

Achievable

Relevant

Timed

Resource 8: Learning Options

This resource sets out:

- The different approaches you can use to transfer ideas or concepts.
- A reference to where you first encountered it.
- Where you can find an example.

1.	Tick either a 'Yes' or 'No' box in a list of questions	Chap 7, sect 3.	Resource 4
2.	Click and drag headings to appropriate boxes	Chap 7, sect 3.	Resource 4
3.	Tick the appropriate boxes in a list of questions	Chap 7, sect 3.	Resource 4
4.	Select one choice from several possible answers	Chap 7, sect 3.	Resource 4
5.	Learner creates their own list of ideas	Chap 7, sect 3.	Resource 4
6.	Enter answers to specific questions	Chap 7, sect 3.	Resource 5
7.	Simple display of text and images	Chap 8, sect 3.	Resource 7
8.	Audio demonstration	Chap 8, sect 3.	Resource 7
9.	Rearrange a list into an appropriate order	Chap 8, sect 3.	Resource 7
10.	Using case studies to demonstrate learning points	Chap 8, sect 3.	
11.	Simulated conversations	Chap 8, sect 3.	
12.	Video clips	Chap 8, sect 3.	
13.	Animations	Chap 8, sect 3.	
14.	Complete a task in the learner's workbook	Chap 8, sect 4.	Resource 7

Resource 9: Project Status Report

Project Status Report, Project X

Project:	Managing Meetings
Period covered by this report:	XX August – XX September
Report Dated:	5th September 2006
Author:	Ms May B Lying

1. Project Manager's Summary

John, Chris and Tajinder met on the 5th September to agree budgets, development priorities, LMS and learning outcomes. As a result of this meeting the project plan has been substantially reworked; an LMS implementation meeting has been scheduled and content deliverables have been established.

Harry Jones has formally signed off the LMDP screen designs and Bill has received the revised designs for the internal review process.

The storyboards are due for formal sign off on 08/08/06, with development due to commence immediately after sign off.

2. Activities completed this period

TASK ID	KEY MILESTONES COMPLETED SUCCESSFULLY	INITIALS	DATE COMPLETED
21	Review SC & CS	KP	14/08/06
22	E-mail feedback on SC & CS	KP	14/08/06
23	Re-worked SC (LMDP)	SB	15/08/06

3. Outstanding activities and comments

TASK ID	ACTIVITY/MILESTONE NOT COMPLETED	INITIALS	DATE NOW DUE
10	Send feedback on PID & Project Plan	KP/SB/CH	30/07/06
14	Sign off PID/Project Plan	CH	01/08/06

4. Key Activities for next period

TASK ID	ACTIVITY/MILESTONE NOT COMPLETED	INITIALS	DATE DUE
29	Review and e-mail Feedback (SMDP)	CH/SB	11/09/06
30	Rework and e-mail SC (SMDP)	MW	11/09/06
31	Review and sign off SC (SMDP)	SB	11/09/06
32	Amend CRS	EP	12/09/06
33	E-mail CRS	EP	12/09/06
63	Storyboard amends and e-mailed	TB	08/09/06
64	Storyboard signed off	KP	08/09/06

5. Project Changes

TASK ID	TITLE	STATUS	EXTRA DAYS
64	Storyboard signed off	Delayed, now scheduled for 08/09/06	1 week on final delivery date

6. Risks

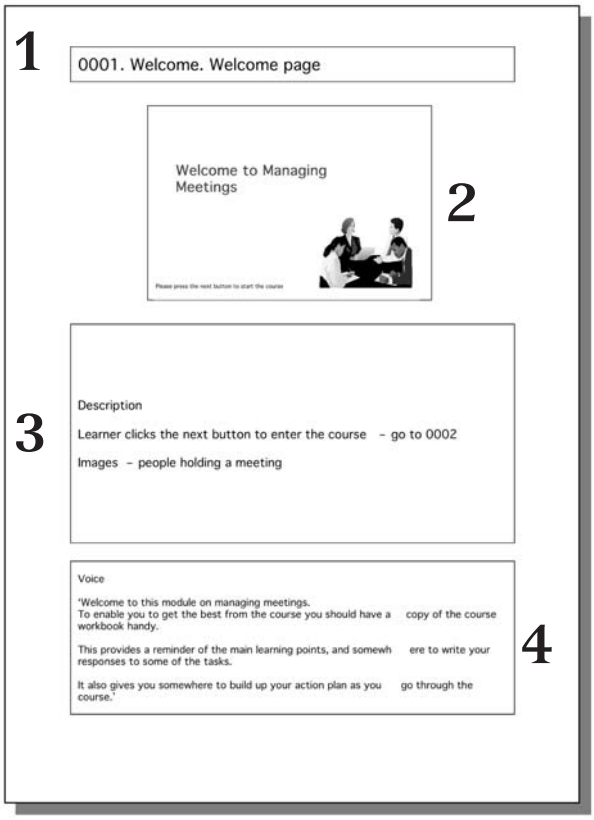
RISK	IMPACT	PROBABILITY	CONTINGENCY PLAN
1. Timescales and availability of key resources to sign off/take meetings are one of the limiting factors to this project's success	Medium	Medium	

Impact and Probability will be indicated by High, Medium, Low

7. Meeting Dates

TASK ID	MEETING	DATE	ATTENDEES	NOTE
10/09/03	LMS implementation Kick-off		CH/KP/SB/RB/AC/ TV/DG/AI/MC	

Resource 10: Sample Storyboards



1. Storyboard header

- This identifies the screen – 0001.
- The Chapter – Welcome
- The title of this screen – Welcome page

2. The screen image

This shows what the learner should see on this screen

3. The description

This tells the software designer what the learner should be able to do, and how the learning system should react to the learner's inputs.

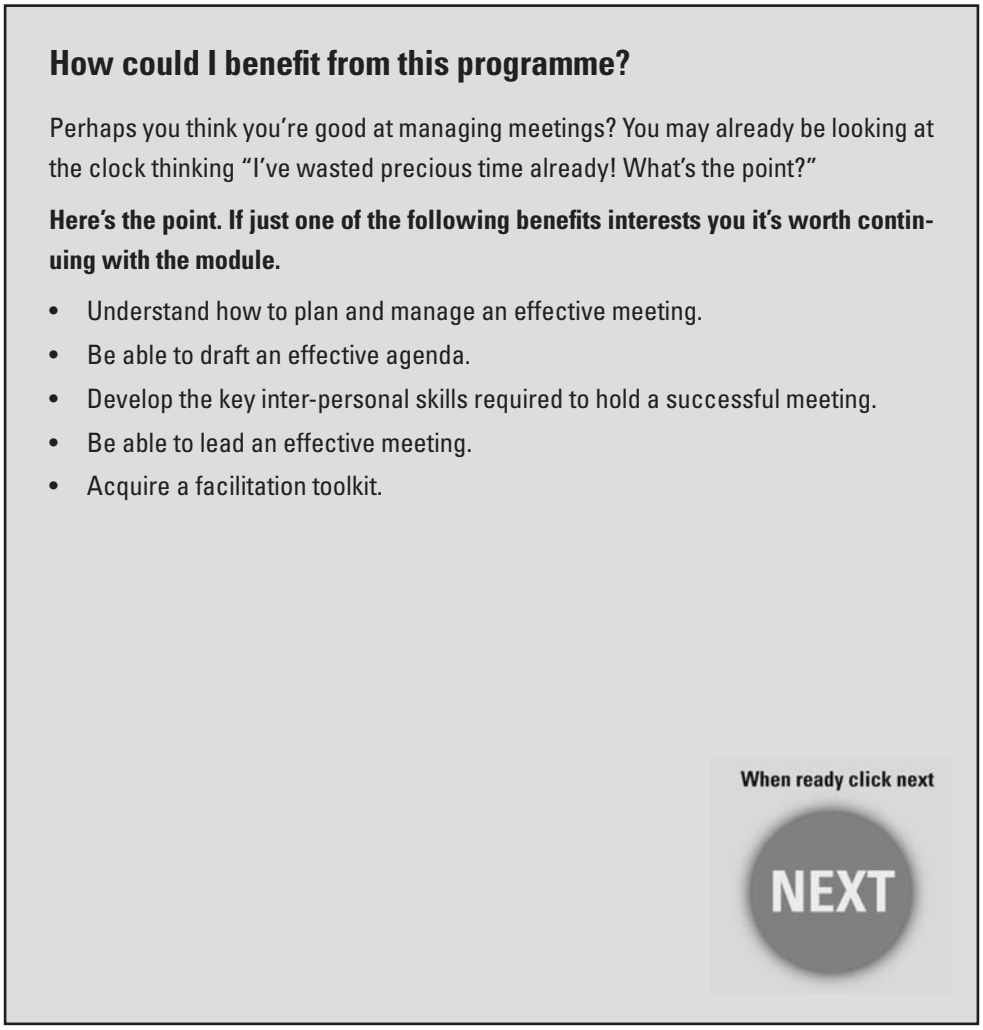
4. The voiceover

This tells the voiceover artist what to say, and how the words should be coordinated with changes on the screen.

Suggested format: Powerpoint.

It's readily available, easy to use, and easy to import screen images.

0002. Welcome. Benefits



Description

Learner clicks 'yes' button to continue – go to 0003

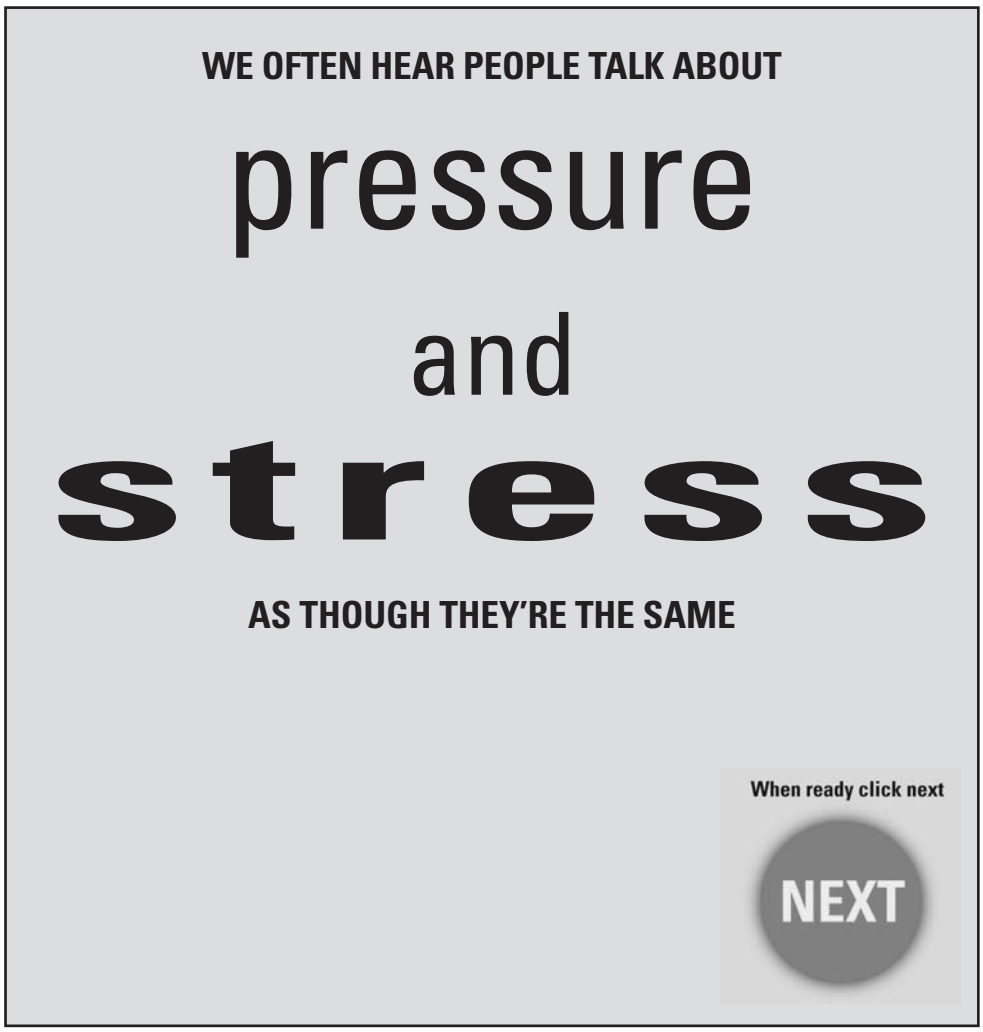
Voice

"You may feel pretty confident about the way you manage meetings, but just read this page – it won't take more than a few minutes. If just one of the ideas could benefit you then it will be worth the hour or so it will take you to work through the course."

Pause for 5 seconds.

"Click 'Yes' and we'll start the journey."

0023. Chapter 1. Pressure and stress



Description

Start with "we often hear…"

Text animation – dissolve in the word 'pressure'

Add 'and'

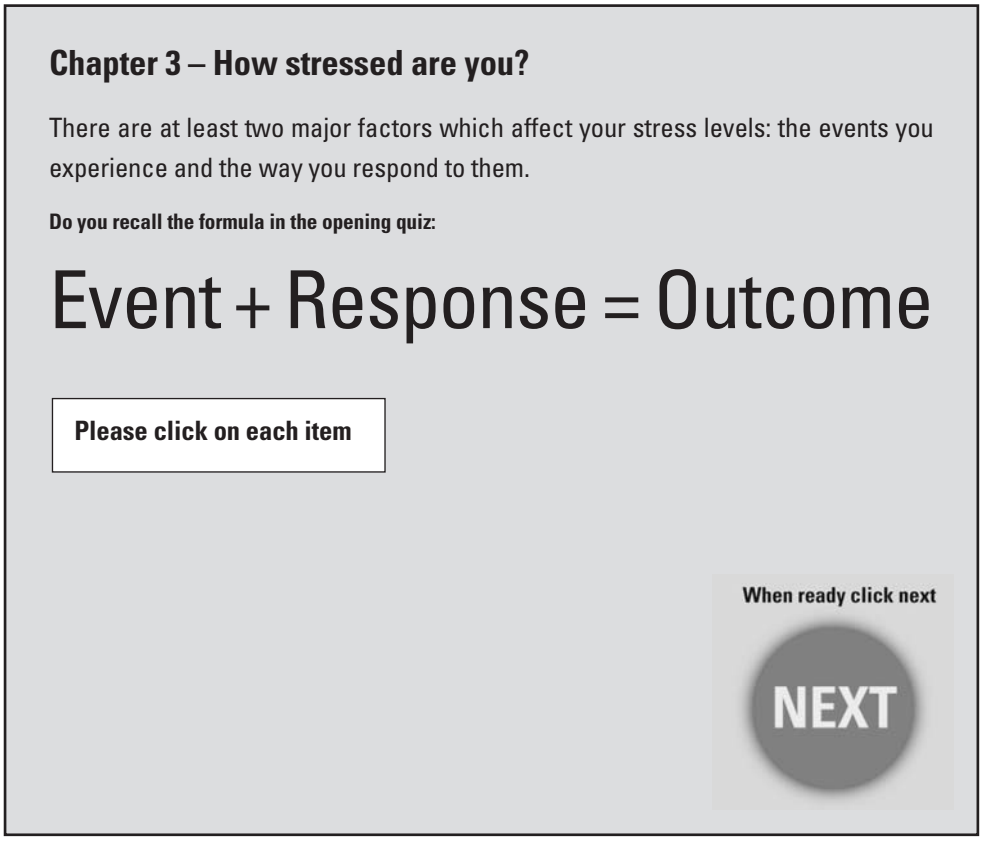
Then stretch outwards the word 'stress' [like an elastic band stretching]

Add 'as though they…'

Learner clicks 'next' – go to 24

Voice: "We often hear people talk about pressure and stress as though they're the Same. But are they?"

0033. Chapter 3. How stressed are you?



Description

Build the text in four steps:

- Start with heading and opening para.
- Then bring in 'Do you recall…?'
- Then show the formula.
- Finally show 'Please click on…'
- Learner clicks: Event – go to 0034
- Learner clicks: Response – go to 0035
- Learner clicks: Outcome – go to 0036

Voice: "Do you remember this formula from the opening quiz?

[Pause]

It reminds us that, whilst we may have limited control over what happens to us, we should be able to control the way we respond to those events.

And it's our response which determines the outcomes we get. Two people can experience exactly the same event but get totally different outcomes because they handle the situation differently.

This course will help you to adopt more appropriate responses to stressful events."

0065. Chapter 4. Breathing properly 3

Breathing properly

Not sure what six breaths per minute is like? Then try this exercise

Ready? First of all breathe out.

When you're ready – press this button GO

Now breathe in deeply, counting five seconds…

1 2 3 4 5

Pause

Now breathe out, counting five seconds…

1 2 3 4 5

Now you know the rhythm – repeat for 10 minutes.

Description

- Open with the heading.
- Pause 1 second – reveal text 'Ready? First of all…. …press the button.'
- Learner clicks 'Go'.
- Reveal text 'Now breathe in deeply…' then these items separated by 1 second pauses – '1', '2', '3', '4', '5', text 'Pause. Now breathe out…', '1', '2', '3', '4' and '5'.
- Pause 3 seconds then reveal text 'Now you know the …'
- Learner clicks: Next – go to 0066

Images – as shown

Voice: "Not sure what six breaths per minute is like? Then try this exercise. [Pause]

Ready? First of all breathe out. Now press the 'Go' button and breathe in deeply for a count of five. Watch the screen to get the timing.

[Pause] Now breathe out to a count of five – again watch the screen to see the timing.

[Pause] All done? Now you know what six breaths per minute feels like.

So repeat it for ten minutes.

[Pause] Do that regularly and you will feel more relaxed."

0103. Chapter 4. Visualisation 4



Description

Learner clicks next – go to 0104

Voice: [Instruction for the voice-over artist. Slow your voice and keep it at a soft, low pitch. Pause for at least five seconds between lines to allow them sufficient time to visualise something, and then time to experience it.]

- Walk down the path until you see a hedge with a gate in it
- Open the gate and walk through
- Take your shoes off
- Walk through the soft green grass of a meadow
- See the waving red poppies blowing in the breeze
- Smell the fresh air
- Feel a soft warm breeze on your body
- There is a bright blue sky above
- Feel the warmth of the sun, relaxing your muscles
- Walk towards a shallow bubbling stream

Resource 11: Refresher Quiz

Please work through the following questions with a colleague and record your answers in the spaces provided. Once you have finished we will give you the suggested answers, and then hold a short discussion on your responses.

Q1 When is it essential to hold a face-to-face meeting as opposed to using an alternative medium such as e-mail or video conferencing? Please list two of the four situations outlined in the course.

1. _____

2. _____

Q2 The course introduced the mnemonic SMART for planning meetings or objectives. What did SMART stand for?

S _____

M _____

A _____

R _____

T _____

Q3 An essential part of planning a meeting is to draft an agenda. Please list four things you would expect to find in an effective agenda:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

Q4 When we communicate with others the impact we make is based on three elements: The words we use, our tone of voice and our body language. What percentages would you place on each medium?

- The words [what we say] is _____ %.
- The music [our tone of voice] is _____ %.
- The dance [our body language] is_____ %.

Q5 If you heard someone say: *"When I want your opinion I will ask for it."* Would you think they were being:

- Aggressive?
- Assertive?
- Passive?

Q6 The course listed eight ways you can display positive body language. Can you list four of them?

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

Q7 Do you remember the cascade of effective questions which started with *Situation Questions*. What were the next two levels?

- Situation questions.
- _____ questions.
- _____ questions.

Q8 The course outlined ten behaviours you would expect an effective chairperson to display. Can you name five of them?

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Q9 The course introduced seven tips for facilitating difficult situations. Can you name three of them?

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Q10 You were shown a template for an after meeting report. Can you list four of the nine items which could be in the report?

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

Answers to Refresher Quiz

Please check your own responses to the Refresher Quiz with these suggested answers, and then we'll hold a short discussion.

A1 When is it essential to hold a face-to-face meeting, as opposed to using an alternative medium such as e-mail or video conferencing?

- Sharing ideas and experiences.
- Career performance appraisal.
- We want to gain other people's commitment.
- We need to reach negotiated agreements.

A2 The course introduced the mnemonic SMART for planning meetings or objectives. SMART stands for:

- **S** – Specific.
- **M** – Measurable.
- **A** – Achievable [could also be Acceptable].
- **R** – Relevant [could also be Realistic].
- **T** – Timed.

A3 An essential part of planning a meeting is to draft an effective agenda which would normally include:

- Clear title (not just 'the usual Monday morning meeting').
- The objective of the meeting.
- Date, time and place.
- List of topics.
- Timings against each item.

A4 When we communicate with others the impact we make is based on three elements: the words we use, our tone of voice and our body language. The percentages normally associated with each medium are:

- The words [what we say] is 7%.
- The music [our tone of voice] is 38%.
- The dance [our body language] is 55%.

A5 If you heard someone saying: *"When I want your opinion I will ask for it."* Would you think they were being:

- Aggressive?
- Assertive?
- Passive?

A lot depends on the tone of voice used but, based on the words alone, they sound Aggressive.

A6 The course listed eight ways you can display positive body language, and they are:

- Dress appropriately for the occasion.
- Be well groomed.
- Act assertively – not aggressively.
- Upright stance – feet flat on floor (whether sitting or standing)
- No slouching – impression of lack of interest.
- Open position – non defensive.
- Make eye contact.
- Face the other person or people.

A7 The cascade of effective questions is:

- Situation questions, which find out more about the situation.
- Problem questions, which discover what people would like to change.
- Effect questions, which reveal the true impact of things.

A8 The course outlined ten behaviours you would expect an effective chairperson to display, and they are:

- Create a productive and results-focused environment.
- Steer the discussion towards achieving the stated objectives.
- Use a problem solving approach to work through complex issues.
- Control who speaks by using body-language signals.
- Manage the personalities – encourage the quiet and manage the noisy.
- Handle conflict positively to channel energy towards a solution.
- Manage the time effectively, whilst still encouraging meaningful debate.
- Summarise frequently and check understanding.
- Ensure that participants accept personal responsibility for action points.
- Close the meeting in a positive and motivated manner.

A9 The course introduced the following seven tips for facilitating difficult situations:

- **Focus on agreement**. Find and highlight areas where group members agree.
- **Build small agreements**. Break down major decisions into component parts.
- **Spend a pound**. A method for assessing which alternatives the group is most interested in.
- **Pros and cons**. Discover the advantages and disadvantages of different options.
- **What would it take?** A question asked by the facilitator to move a group towards final agreement

- **What have others done?** Informal bench-marking by scanning group members' memories and experiences of how others have solved similar problems
- **Back off.** Defer decision making for the moment and focus the group's attention on confirming previous agreements.

A10 You were shown a template for an after meeting report which included these nine items which could be in the report.

- Who held the meeting.
- When was it held?
- List of those who attended, and those who were absent and sent apologies.
- List each item by number from agenda or describe it.
- Bullet point details of actions to be taken.
- Say who is going to take the action
- **Very important**. Say when it will happen
- Give date of next meeting.
- Evaluate how the meeting went and what could be done differently next time.

Resource 12: Sample Course Outline

Draft agenda for the trainer-led course

Course starts at 9am

1. Welcome
2. Refresher Quiz

Morning break: 10.30-10.45

3. Skill practice 1
4. Skill practice 2

Lunch: 1.00-1.45

5. Skill practice 3

Afternoon break: 3.00-3.15

6. Skill practice
7. Action planning and close

Course closes at 5pm

Draft outline for the trainer-led course

1. Welcome

- Welcome delegates to the course.
- Stress that this is the second part of the learning experience, and that after the course they can use the e-learning to refresh their learning.
- Ask delegates to briefly introduce themselves to their colleagues.
- Discuss the course objectives and outline the key points.
- Show the course outline and explain how the day works.
- Explain that everyone will chair a meeting and get feedback during the day.
- Outline the domestic issues, breaks, safety and fire escapes, etc.

Timings: 45 minutes. 9.00-9.45.

2. Refresher Quiz

- Give delegates the Refresher Quiz, which revises several of the topics they encountered in the e-learning course.
- Working with a partner they should answer as many questions as possible in 15 minutes.
- Set them going and call 'time' after 15 minutes.
- Distribute the answer sheet and ask the partnerships to score their answers.
- Discuss any specific questions they found difficult or confusing.

Timings: 45 minutes. 9.45-10.30.

Morning Break

Timings: 10.30-10.45.

3. Skill Practice 1 – Fun Team Problem Solving Task

- Break the delegates into two teams, each with a Chairperson.
- Explain the task, the required outcomes, and agree timings.

- Distribute the clue cards and set them going.
- Once both teams have completed, debrief the exercise.
- Teams give individual feedback to their Chairperson.

Timings: 1 hour 15 minutes. 10.45-12.00.

4. Skill Practice 2 – Charity Donation

- Break the delegates into two teams, each with a Chairperson.
- Explain the task, the required outcomes and agree timings.
- Teams hold an initial meeting to plan their opening position.
- Representatives meet to hold initial negotiations.
- Teams hold their second meeting to plan their closing position.
- Representatives meet to close the negotiations.
- Once both teams have completed, debrief the exercise.
- Teams give individual feedback to their Chairperson.

Timings: 1 hour. 12.00-1.00.

Lunch

Timings: 45 minutes. 1.00-1.45.

5. Skill Practice 3 – Koosh Throwing Competition

- Break the delegates into two teams, each with a Chairperson.
- Explain the task, the required outcomes, and agree timings.
- Distribute the equipment and materials.
- Once both teams have prepared their SMART objectives, hold the competition.
- Once each team has attempted the other's SMART objective, debrief the exercise.
- Teams give individual feedback to their Chairperson.

Timings: 1 hour 15 minutes. 1.45-3.00.

Afternoon Break

Timings: 3.00-3.15.

6. Skill Practice 4 – Management Planning Meeting

- Break the delegates into two teams, each with a Chairperson.
- Explain the task, the required outcomes and agree timings.
- Distribute the briefing materials which describe their roles and the challenges facing them in their given roles.
- Agree time for delegates to complete their individual preparation.
- Delegates then work in two teams to complete the tasks.
- Once both teams have completed, debrief the exercise.
- Teams give individual feedback to their Chairperson.

Timings: 1 hour 15 minutes. 3.15-4.30.

7. Action Planning and Close

- Delegates work individually to review the day.
- Group review to share action points.
- Remind participants of the on-line coaching.
- Delegates complete end-of-course evaluation sheet.
- End on a high! Send them away rejoicing!

Timings: 30 minutes. 4.30-5.00.

Resource 13: Sample Trainer's Guide

Section 1: Welcome to the Course

Welcome

This package gives you all you need to deliver an effective, stimulating and enjoyable day's training.

Purpose

The purpose of this course is to enable delegates who have participated in the online component of the Managing Meetings programme to practise their skills and receive immediate feedback on their performance in a supportive environment.

By the end of the course delegates will:

- have refreshed the concepts and techniques presented in the online component
- have practised the skills by leading one activity involving chairing a meeting
- have received focused and immediate feedback in a supportive environment
- leave with an action plan for immediate implementation.

The day is very busy and there is little or no time to cover the basic concepts so you must assume that everyone who attends the course has completed all the sections of the e-learning course.

The course joining instructions stress the importance of this pre-course work and emphasise that, unlike other courses, there really is only limited time for theory and preparation.

Course Delegates

The course has been designed to run with a maximum of eight delegates, facilitated by one trainer.

It's important to recognise that your delegates will have approached the *Grasp the Theory* learning with different levels of motivation.

- Some will have gone through the material thoroughly, squeezing the last learning point like a pip from a lemon.
- Whilst others will have meandered through the material – not necessarily completing it, certainly not in the recommended sequence, whilst allowing other distractions in.

Even if a group of people tackled *Grasp the Theory* with the same degree of energy and thoroughness they would probably end with different degrees of understanding as their starting points would all be so different. Our experience of life and work, coupled with our background and personality means we all walk into the course with different levels of skills and ability.

Your course needs to embrace all of them with energy and enthusiasm.

Venue

The venue will have been chosen to meet a detailed specification which you can find in Section 4. You should have the following rooms:

- One large training room to be used for the group sessions, which will accommodate eight delegates and one tutor in comfort.
- One smaller team room, which can seat five people in comfort.

Please walk around your rooms and ensure that you have all the necessary facilities. You should plan to arrive at least one hour before the formal starting time of the course so that you have time to rearrange any furniture or to check the operation and settings of the equipment.

Materials

You will need the following materials to ensure the course runs successfully:

- Nine copies of the Refresher Quiz used early in the course to refresh key concepts, together with nine copies of the answer sheet.
- Stock of plain A4 paper.
- Sufficient copies of the briefing notes for any tasks or activities you are using.
- Sufficient pens for each delegate.

You can find copies of these documents in Section 4.

Consistency

Prior to the course you will need to work through the complete e-learning course so that you are fully conversant with the concepts presented. It should take you half to one-day to work through the complete on-line package.

When presenting the course it is essential that you do not deviate in any way from the concepts and ideas presented in the on-line version, even if you don't agree with all of them. The material has been well researched and presented and gives delegates a superb grounding in the topic.

We recognise that, as an experienced trainer, you have your own approach to this topic and it is quite possible that certain skills or behaviours may be presented differently from how you would do it yourself.

However, to avoid confusing the delegates, and to ensure the course is delivered consistently we must ask you to:

- put aside your own personal preferences or styles and deliver the course as designed
- respond to any questions in a way that is consistent with the on-line portion
- project yourself as a role model of all the course concepts, demonstrating them consistently throughout the day.

The Course

We have developed a course timetable which aims to give the optimum balance between activities and feedback. You can find the course timetable in Section 2 of this guide.

To provide consistency we ask you to follow this closely. Of course the timings may vary by a few minutes to respond to the needs of specific delegates, but you should aim to deliver all the sessions shown as set out in the tutor guide.

The course starts at 9am and finishes at 5pm. There are three breaks scheduled during the day:

- 15 minute morning break: 10.30-10.45pm
- 45 minute lunch break: 1.00 and 1.45pm
- 15 minute afternoon break: 3.00-3.15pm

The course timetable sets out the detailed sessions and gives a brief resume of what happens in each session. Once you have run the course a few times you will probably only need to refer to this to deliver a successful course.

Each session is described in detail in Section 3 of this Trainer Guide. The notes tell you:

- the purpose of each session
- what you and the delegates should do
- the detailed timings
- what materials are required.

End of Course Evaluation

Please ask your delegates to complete an end of course questionnaire before they leave the venue.

Section 2: Course Timetable

1. Welcome

Timings: 45 minutes. 9.00-9.45pm

2. Refresher Quiz

Timings: 45 minutes. 9.45-10.30pm

Morning break

Timings: 10.30-10.45pm

3. Skill practice 1

Timings: 1 hour 15 minutes. 10.45-12.00 noon

4. Skill practice 2

Timings: 1 hour. 12.00-1.00pm

Lunch

Timings: 45 minutes. 1.00-1.45pm

5. Skill practice 3

Timings: 1 hour 15 minutes. 1.45-3.00pm

Afternoon break

Timings: 3.00-3.15pm

6. Skill practice

Timings: 1 hour 15 minutes. 3.15-4.30pm

7. Action planning and close

Timings: 30 minutes. 4.30-5.00pm

Section 3: Detailed Tutor Guide

Session 1. Welcome

PURPOSE

- To introduce the delegates to the course and cover the usual safety, domestic, and comfort issues.

WHAT HAPPENS?

- You open the course in a lively way, encourage delegates to feel relaxed then set the scene for the rest of the day.

TIME

- 45 minutes. 9.00-9.45am

MATERIALS AND RESOURCES

- Delegate name cards.
- Course overview on OHP or flipchart.
- 'Benefits of attending' OHP.

PREPARATION

To prepare for the session you need to:

- ensure the seating is right in both training rooms
- walk around the venue to find the nearest fire exits and toilets
- check if the venue is planning to test the fire alarms
- ensure that all your visual aids are fully operational.

HOW DO I DO IT?

Welcome Delegates to the Course

- Be on hand to personally greet everyone as they arrive.
- Remember they are probably feeling quite nervous!
- Make everyone feel welcome and introduce yourself.
- Settle people in and ask them to write their first names on the 'tent card'.

Discuss the Benefits of Attending the Course

- Display the 'benefits of attending' OHP and briefly talk about each one.
- Remind them that this is the second part of the learning process and that after the course they can access the e-refresher component.
- Confirm that everyone has completed the whole of the on-line component.

Briefly Explain the Course Outline

- Display the 'course outline' OHP and briefly take them through the day.
- Point out the need to keep to time, so please come back from breaks on time.
- Emphasise that they are responsible for their own learning so they must be searching for feedback on their performance.

Outline the Safety, Comfort and Domestic Issues

- Point out the nearest fire exits and ensure everyone knows where to go.
- Mention any changes to the outline timings which were given in the course joining instructions.
- Reassure them that there will be opportunities for quick 'comfort breaks' between sessions.
- Ask everyone to switch off their mobile phones.

Personal Introductions

- Ask everyone to introduce themselves to their colleagues.
- Give a brief career history and what their current job involves.
- How do meetings feature in their lives?
- Finally ask them to share something unusual or novel about themselves.

Session 2: Refresher Quiz

PURPOSE

- To refresh the key concepts of planning and managing effective meetings.
- To give the opportunity to discuss any outstanding issues or concerns delegates may have.

WHAT HAPPENS?

- Working with a partner, delegates complete a Refresher Quiz which tests their knowledge of the e-learning course.
- Once everyone has finished you distribute a list of suggested answers and then hold a short discussion on their responses to the quiz.

TIME

- 45 minutes. 9.45-10.30am

MATERIALS AND RESOURCES

- Nine copies of the Refresher Quiz and the answers document.

PREPARATION

To prepare for this session you need to have sufficient copies of:

- The Refresher Quiz.
- The suggested answers, and
- Be familiar with the content of the e-learning course.

HOW DO I DO IT?

Introduce the Quiz

- Stress that time is short and that you will not be able to discuss in detail the concepts presented in the on-line course.
- However, it is useful to spend the first part of the day refreshing some of the underlying concepts.
- Ask delegates to select a partner, preferably someone they've not met previously.
- Once they have sat together give everyone their copy of the quiz and ask them to work through all the questions together.

Discussion Time

- As each partnership finishes the quiz give them copies of the suggested answers, and ask them to compare them with their responses.
- Once everyone has finished, open a general discussion on the quiz.
- Stress that the 'suggested answers' are for guidance only.
- **Be prepared to discuss any topics which seem to spark discussion but keep an eye on the clock!**
- If someone has a specific topic they obviously wish to discuss in detail you may wish to say that you'll chat with them during the break.

MORNING BREAK

- At a suitable moment announce the morning break.
- Confirm that they must be ready to restart at 10.45am.

Session 3: Skill Practice 1 – Fun Team Problem-Solving

PURPOSE

- To give delegates #1 and #2 the opportunity to lead a task which involves a meeting, followed by coaching and feedback.

WHAT HAPPENS?

- Working in two teams, the delegates tackle an unusual and fun problem-solving task.
- After a general review the teams give individual feedback to their team leader.

TIME

- 1 hour 15 minutes. 10.45-12.00 noon.

MATERIALS AND RESOURCES

Nine copies of the task briefing notes and any other materials required for the task.

HOW DO I DO IT?

The Task in Outline

- The teams have to solve a series of interlinking problems.

- The teams are given identical sets of playing cards on each of which there is one clue.
- The clues are, by themselves, confusing and seem to make little sense.
- The team can only solve the problems by sharing all the clues.

Getting Started

- Ask for two delegates to volunteer to be team leaders – stress that everyone will have a turn during the day.
- Then ask the remaining delegates to form two equally sized teams.
- Say that one team will work in the main room, and the other in the team room.
- Explain the task and the solutions they must achieve.
- Give the team leaders the clue cards and wish them Good Luck!

Team Discussions

- Move between the two teams, only helping if they are stuck.
- Discreetly monitor what happens so you can add your own feedback later.
- Keep an eye on the time, but only recall the teams if timings are going seriously adrift.
- Tell them when they get the answers right.
- If they get them wrong don't tell them what exactly is wrong – let them work it out for themselves.

Group Review

- Once both teams have completed the exercise, reform the main group and hold a short review.
- Bring out the key learning points, especially those relevant to meetings skills.

Individual Feedback

- Ask the teams to return to their team areas and give focused feedback to their team leader.
- Stress that the feedback is not for public consumption so they can be totally honest!
- Ask that the person receiving the feedback notes the key points in their workbook so they can refer back to it during the final action planning session.

Session 4: Skill Practice 2 – Charity Donation

PURPOSE

- To give delegates #3 and #4 the opportunity to lead a task which involves a meeting, followed by coaching and feedback.

WHAT HAPPENS?

- Working in two teams the delegates tackle an unusual negotiation exercise.
- After a general review the teams give individual feedback to their team leader.

TIME

- 1 hour. 12.00-1.00pm

MATERIALS AND RESOURCES

- Nine copies of the task briefing notes and any other materials required for the task.

HOW DO I DO IT?

The Task in Outline

- The teams meet in private and have 15 minutes to identify one charity they are prepared to donate to, and agree how much to give [for real].
- One person from each team then meets with their opposite number and they hold an initial discussion.
- The teams adjourn to consider progress and modify their negotiating position.

- The negotiators meet again and strike an agreement.
- The cash is collected for donation to the agreed charity.

Getting Started

- Ask for two different delegates to volunteer to be team leaders – stress that everyone will have a turn during the day.
- Then ask the remaining delegates to form two equally sized teams.
- Say that one team will work in the main room, and the other in the team room.
- Explain the task and the solutions they must achieve.
- Stress that the donation is real – as the trainer you donate whatever they agree to give and you will collect the money at the end of the session.

Initial Team Discussions

- Working in different rooms the two teams prepare their opening positions.
- Move between the two teams and discreetly monitor what happens so you can add your own feedback later.
- First Round of Negotiations
- Each team must propose someone to negotiate with the other team – not the team leader.
- The remainder of the team watch what happens but cannot join in.

Final Team Discussions

- After initial negotiations the two teams reform in private to consider tactics, and brief the negotiator for the final round of negotiations.

Final Round of Negotiations

- The negotiators resume their discussions until an agreed settlement is reached.
- The remainder of the team watch what happens but cannot join in.

Group Review

- Once the discussions are completed hold a short review.
- Bring out the key learning points, especially those relevant to meetings skills.

Individual Feedback

- Ask the teams to return to their team areas and give focused feedback to their team leader.
- Stress that the feedback is not for public consumption so they can be totally honest!
- Ask that the person receiving the feedback notes the key points in their workbook so they can refer back to it during the final action planning session.

Lunch Break

Break the session for lunch and agree the time for return, ideally 1.45pm.

Session 5: Skill Practice 3 – Koosh Throwing Competition

PURPOSE

- To give delegates #5 and #6 the opportunity to lead a task which involves a meeting followed by coaching and feedback.

WHAT HAPPENS?

- Working in two teams the delegates write SMART objectives for a Koosh throwing competition.
- The team gather and follow the other team's instructions in a competitive atmosphere.
- After a general review the teams give individual feedback to their team leader.

TIME

- 1 hour 15 minutes. 1.45-3.00pm

MATERIALS AND RESOURCES

- Nine copies of the task briefing notes and any other materials required for the task.
- Sufficient Kooshes or scrunched up balls of paper.

HOW DO I DO IT?

The Task in Outline

- The exercise shows how hard it is to write SMART objectives.
- The teams have 30 minutes to write self-contained SMART instructions for the other team to follow.
- The instructions must be complete and self-contained – the drafting team cannot add any additional briefing or explanation.
- Each team will attempt to implement the other team's instructions.

GETTING STARTED

- Ask for two delegates to volunteer to be team leaders – you now have only four to choose from.
- Then ask the remaining delegates to form two equally sized teams.
- Say that one team will work in the main room, and the other in the team room.
- Explain the task and the outcomes they must achieve.

TEAM DISCUSSIONS

- Move between the two teams, only helping if they are stuck.
- Discreetly monitor what happens so you can add your own feedback comments later.

THE COMPETITION

- After 30 minutes reform the group and ask each team to post their instructions on the wall.
- Ask one team to attempt the instructions of the other – keep the score.
- Ask the 'authors' of the instructions to note where their instructions are not SMART enough.
- Change roles and implement the other team's instructions.

GROUP REVIEW

- Once both teams have completed the exercise, reform the main group and hold a short review.
- Bring out the key learning points, especially those relevant to meetings skills.

INDIVIDUAL FEEDBACK

- Ask the teams to return to their team areas and give focused feedback to their team leader.
- Stress that the feedback is not for public consumption so they can be totally honest!
- Ask that the person receiving the feedback notes the key points in their workbook so they can refer back to it during the final action planning session.

Afternoon Break

Break the team for afternoon tea/coffee and agree the time for return – ideally no later than 3.15pm.

Session 6: Skill Practice 4 – Management Planning Meeting

PURPOSE

- To give delegates #7 and #8 the opportunity to lead a task, which involves a meeting followed by coaching and feedback.

WHAT HAPPENS?

- Working in two teams the delegates assume roles in a management team and conduct a crisis planning meeting.
- After a general review the teams give individual feedback to their team leader.

TIME

- 1 hour 15 minutes. 3.15-4.30pm

MATERIALS AND RESOURCES

- Nine copies of the task briefing notes and any other materials required for the task.

HOW DO I DO IT?

The Task in Outline

- The teams operate in self-contained management teams, each with identical briefing materials.
- The four members in each team assume a role in their management team and they are each given a briefing relevant to their role.
- They prepare for, and hold, a meeting to handle a crisis situation.

Getting Started

- Ask for the two final delegates to volunteer to be team leaders.
- Then ask the remaining delegates to form two equally sized teams.
- Say that one team will work in the main room and the other in the team room.
- Explain the task and the solutions they must achieve.

Initial Team Planning

- Working in different rooms the two teams have 20 minutes to prepare their opening positions.
- Move between the two teams and discreetly monitor what happens so you can add your own feedback comments later.

Team Meetings

- The team leader in each room opens the meeting and works through the agenda.
- The other team members respond in their role.

Group Review

- Once the team meetings are completed reform the group and hold a short review.
- Bring out the key learning points, especially those relevant to meetings skills.

Individual Feedback

- Ask the teams to return to their team areas and give focused feedback to their team leader.
- Stress that the feedback is not for public consumption so they can be totally honest!
- Ask that the person receiving the feedback notes the key points in their workbook so they can refer back to it during the final action planning session.

Session 7: Action Planning and Close

PURPOSE

- To review progress and commit to personal action plans.

WHAT HAPPENS?

- Delegates work individually and review the personal action plans.
- The session closes with the team sharing the headlines of the action plans, before completing an end of course questionnaire.

TIME

- 30 minutes. 4.30-5.00pm

MATERIALS AND RESOURCES

- Sufficient copies of the end of course questionnaire.

HOW DO I DO IT?

Review the Day

- Ask your delegates to work individually.
- They should check their progress against the personal learning goals they came with.

Share the Headlines

- After five minutes reform the main group and ask each delegate in turn to share the headlines of their action plans.
- Mention that they may have on-line e-refresher coaching from the course tutors after the course which will help with ongoing development. **[Note – this depends on your own situation.]**
- After each person has spoken add your own comment of encouragement, based on what you've seen of them during the day.

Closing Review

- They will all say that the activities with feedback were the most helpful part of the course.
- So build on that theme and now ask them for their feedback on the day.
- Pass around copies of the end of course questionnaire and ask them to complete it.
- Stress that as well as 'ticks in boxes' you especially appreciate their comments.
- Finally, thank them all for their willing participation and ask them all to give each other a final round of applause.

Wrap Up

- Once the last delegate has left please tidy up the room and pack away any materials that need to be returned.

Thank you very much for running the course to these demanding standards. We hope you have enjoyed the experience.

Please give us any feedback about any aspect of the course which you think will make it more effective or easier to deliver.

Section 4: Copies of the Course Documents

In this section you will find copies of all the key documents you need to deliver the course successfully, including:

- venue specification
- course joining instructions
- refresher quiz [please see Resource 11]
- briefing notes for specific sessions [where appropriate]
- end-of-course questionnaire [please use your own design].

Venue Specification

One-day Trainer-led Managing Meetings Course

TRAINING ROOMS

We will require the following rooms:

- The main training room [7 x 7 metres minimum] to accommodate eight delegates plus one tutor.
- One smaller team room to accommodate five people. This room should ideally be adjacent to the main training room or within 30 seconds walk.

THE MAIN TRAINING ROOM

This room should have:

- natural daylight
- air conditioning
- seating for eight delegates
- chair for the tutor at the front of the room
- a side table for course materials and equipment
- two free-standing flipchart stands with a good supply of flipchart paper and pens
- a projector for computer graphics
- an OHP projector, with a pack of blank OHP acetates and a good supply of OHP pens

- sockets and extension cables
- water/orange juice etc
- pens and paper for delegates.

THE TEAM ROOM

This room should have:

- seating for five people
- one free-standing flipchart stand with a good supply of flipchart paper and pens.

TIMINGS

- **8.00am:** the trainer will arrive to prepare.
- **8.30am:** tea/coffee/fruit juice available for delegates as they arrive.
- **9.00am:** the course starts.
- **10.30am:** morning break with tea/coffee/fruit juice available out of the rooms.
- **1.00-1.45pm:** buffet lunch to be served out of the rooms
- **3.00pm:** afternoon break with tea/coffee/fruit juice available out of the rooms.
- **5.00pm:** the course closes.

Course Joining Instructions

One-day Trainer-led Managing Meetings Course

WELCOME

You will shortly be attending the one-day trainer-led course having successfully completed the e-learning component of the Managing Meetings course.

These course joining instructions introduce you to the course and outline what you need to do prior to attending to ensure you gain the greatest benefit.

Please note – you will not be able to enrol on this component of the programme unless you have completed the e-learning component in full.

BENEFITS OF THE COURSE

By the end of the course you will:

- have refreshed the concepts and techniques presented in the on-line component
- have practised the skills by leading one activity involving Chairing a meeting
- have received focused and immediate feedback in a supportive environment
- leave with an action plan for immediate implementation.

ABOUT THE COURSE

The day will be very busy so please ensure that you arrive on time and that you can devote your energies entirely to the course activities. We especially ask for mobile phones to be switched off for the whole day so there will be no distractions to other delegates.

The outline timings are:

- **8.30am:** tea/coffee/fruit juice will be available for you when you arrive.
- **9.00am:** the course starts.
- **10.30am:** morning break with tea/coffee/fruit juice available.
- **1.00pm:** buffet lunch to be served.
- **3.00pm:** afternoon break with tea/coffee/fruit juice available.
- **5.00pm:** the course closes.

THE VENUE

The course is being held at the XXX hotel/conference centre, in the YYY suite/rooms. The contact details for the venue are:

- Phone:
- Fax:
- E-mail:

Directions on how to travel to the venue are given separately.

PRE-COURSE WORK

We have designed the day to give you the maximum opportunity to practise your meeting skills so there will only be limited time to refresh the underlying concepts introduced in the e-learning course.

So to make sure you get the greatest benefit from the course you should:

- work through the whole online portion of the training materials no more than one week prior to the course
- arrive with clear personal learning objectives for the day.

COURSE TUTOR

There will be a maximum of eight delegates on the course. The tutor will be available at the venue from 8.30am and will be pleased to answer any questions you may have.

DRESS CODE

Please wear smart, casual dress.

CAN'T ATTEND?

If for any reason you won't be able to attend please let us know at the earliest opportunity, so we can offer the place to someone else.

ANY QUERIES?

If you have any queries at all please contact XXX.

- Phone:
- Fax:
- E-mail:

We look forward to meeting you on the day.

Other specially commissioned reports

BUSINESS AND COMMERCIAL LAW

The commercial exploitation of intellectual property rights by licensing

CHARLES DESFORGES **£125.00**

1 85418 285 4 • 2001

Expert advice and techniques for the identification and successful exploitation of key opportunities.

This report will show you:

- how to identify and secure profitable opportunities
- strategies and techniques for negotiating the best agreement
- the techniques of successfully managing a license operation.

Damages and other remedies for breach of commercial contracts

ROBERT RIBEIRO **£125.00**

1 85418 226 X • 2002

This valuable new report sets out a systematic approach for assessing the remedies available for various types of breach of contract, what the remedies mean in terms of compensation and how the compensation is calculated.

Commercial contracts – drafting techniques and precedents

ROBERT RIBEIRO **£125.00**

1 85418 210 2 • 2002

The Report will:

- Improve your commercial awareness and planning skills
- Enhance your legal foresight and vision
- Help you appreciate the relevance of rules and guidelines set out by the courts
- Ensure you achieve your or your client's commercial objectives

The Competition Act 1998: practical advice and guidance

SUSAN SINGLETON **£149.00**

1 85418 205 6 • 2001

Failure to operate within UK and EU competition rules can lead to heavy fines of up to 10 per cent of a business's total UK turnover.

Insights into successfully managing the in-house legal function

BARRY O'MEARA **£65.00**

1 85418 174 2 • 2000

Negotiating the fault line between private practice and in-house employment can be tricky, as the scope for conflicts of interest is greatly increased. *Insights into successfully managing the In-house legal function* discusses and suggests ways of dealing with these and other issues.

For full details of any title, and to view sample extracts please visit: www.thorogood.ws

You can place an order in four ways:

1 **Email**: orders@thorogood.ws
2 **Telephone**: +44 (0)20 7749 4748
3 **Fax**: +44 (0)20 7729 6110
4 **Post**: Thorogood, 10-12 Rivington Street, London EC2A 3DU, UK

The legal protection of databases

SIMON CHALTON **£145.00**

1 85418 245 5 • 2001

Inventions can be patented, knowledge can be protected, but what of information itself?

This valuable report examines the current EU [and so EEA] law on the legal protection of databases, including the *sui generis* right established when the European Union adopted its Directive 96/9/EC in 1996.

Litigation costs

MICHAEL BACON **£95.00**

1 85418 241 2 • 2001

The rules and regulations are complex – but can be turned to advantage.

The astute practitioner will understand the importance and relevance of costs to the litigation process and will wish to learn how to turn the large number of rules to maximum advantage.

International commercial agreements

REBECCA ATTREE **£175**

1 85418 286 2 • 2002

A major new report on recent changes to the law and their commercial implications and possibilities.

The report explains the principles and techniques of successful international negotiation and provides a valuable insight into the commercial points to be considered as a result of the laws relating to: pre-contract, private international law, resolving disputes (including alternative methods, such as mediation), competition law, drafting common clauses and contracting electronically.

It also examines in more detail certain specific international commercial agreements, namely agency and distribution and licensing.

Email – legal issues

SUSAN SINGLETON **£95.00**

1 85418 215 3 • 2001

What are the chances of either you or your employees breaking the law?

The report explains clearly:

- How to establish a sensible policy and whether or not you are entitled to insist on it as binding
- The degree to which you may lawfully monitor your employees' e-mail and Internet use
- The implications of the Regulation of Investigatory Powers Act 2000 and the Electronic Communications Act 2000
- How the Data Protection Act 1998 affects the degree to which you can monitor your staff
- What you need to watch for in the Human Rights Act 1998
- TUC guidelines
- Example of an e-mail and Internet policy document.

For full details of any title, and to view sample extracts please visit: www.thorogood.ws

You can place an order in four ways:

1 **Email**: orders@thorogood.ws
2 **Telephone**: +44 (0)20 7749 4748
3 **Fax**: +44 (0)20 7729 6110
4 **Post**: Thorogood, 10-12 Rivington Street, London EC2A 3DU, UK

Employee sickness and fitness for work – successfully dealing with the legal system

GILLIAN HOWARD **£95.00**

1 85418 281 1 • 2002

Many executives see Employment Law as an obstacle course or, even worse, an opponent – but it can contribute positively to keeping employees fit and productive.

This specially commissioned report will show you how to get the best out of your employees, from recruitment to retirement, while protecting yourself and your firm to the full.

Data protection law for employers

SUSAN SINGLETON **£125**

1 85418 283 8 • May 2003

The new four-part Code of Practice under the Data Protection Act 1998 on employment and data protection makes places a further burden of responsibility on employers and their advisers. The Data protection Act also applies to manual data, not just computer data, and a new tough enforcement policy was announced in October 2002.

Successful graduate recruitment

JEAN BRADING **£69.00**

1 85418 270 6 • 2001

Practical advice on how to attract *and* keep the best.

Successfully defending employment tribunal cases

DENNIS HUNT **£95**

1 85418 267 6 • 2003

Fully up to date with all the Employment Act 2002 changes.

165,000 claims were made last year and the numbers are rising. What will you do when one comes your way?

How to turn your HR strategy into reality

TONY GRUNDY **£129.00**

1 85418 183 1 • 1999

A practical guide to developing and implementing an effective HR strategy.

Internal communications

JAMES FARRANT **£125**

1 85418 149 1 • July 2003

How to improve your organisation's internal communications – and performance as a result.

There is growing evidence that the organisations that 'get it right' reap dividends in corporate energy and enhanced performance.

Mergers and acquisitions – confronting the organisation and people issues

MARK THOMAS **£95.00**

1 85418 008 8 • 1997

Why do so many mergers and acquisitions end in tears and reduced shareholder value?

This report will help you to understand the key practical and legal issues, achieve consensus and involvement at all levels, understand and implement TUPE regulations and identify the documentation that needs to be drafted or reviewed.

New ways of working

STEPHEN JUPP **£99.00**

1 85418 169 6 • 2000

New ways of working examines the nature of the work done in an organisation and seeks to *optimise the working practices and the whole context* in which the work takes place.

Knowledge management

SUE BRELADE, CHRISTOPHER HARMAN **£95.00**

1 85418 230 7 • 2001

Managing knowledge in companies is nothing new. However, the development of a *separate discipline* called 'knowledge management' *is* new – the introduction of recognised techniques and approaches for effectively managing the knowledge resources of an organisation. This report will provide you with these techniques.

Reviewing and changing contracts of employment

ANNELISE PHILLIPS, TOM PLAYER and PAULA ROME **£125**

1 85418 296 X • 2003

The Employment Act 2002 has raised the stakes. Imperfect understanding of the law and poor drafting will now be very costly.

This new report will:

- Ensure that you have a total grip on what should be in a contract and what should not
- Explain step by step how to achieve changes in the contract of employment without causing problems
- Enable you to protect clients' sensitive business information
- Enhance your understanding of potential conflict areas and your ability to manage disputes effectively.

Applying the Employment Act 2002 – crucial developments for employers and employees

AUDREY WILLIAMS **£125**

1 85418 253 6 • May 2003

The Act represents a major shift in the commercial environment, with far-reaching changes for employers and employees. The majority of the new rights under the family friendly section take effect from April 2003 with most of the other provisions later in the year.

The consequences of getting it wrong, for both employer and employee, will be considerable – financial and otherwise. The Act affects nearly every aspect of the work place, including:

- flexible working
- family rights (adoption, paternity and improved maternity leave)
- changes to internal disciplinary and grievance procedures
- significant changes to unfair dismissal legislation
- new rights for those employed on fixed-term contracts
- the introduction of new rights for learning representatives from an employer's trade union

This specially commissioned new report examines each of the key developments where the Act changes existing provisions or introduces new rights. Each chapter deals with a discreet area.

Email – legal issues

SUSAN SINGLETON **£95.00**

1 85418 215 3 • 2001

360,000 email messages are sent in the UK every second (*The Guardian*). What are the chances of either you or your employees breaking the law?

The report explains clearly:

- How to establish a sensible policy and whether or not you are entitled to insist on it as binding
- The degree to which you may lawfully monitor your employees' e-mail and Internet use
- The implications of the Regulation of Investigatory Powers Act 2000 and the Electronic Communications Act 2000
- How the Data Protection Act 1998 affects the degree to which you can monitor your staff
- What you need to watch for in the Human Rights Act 1998
- TUC guidelines
- Example of an e-mail and Internet policy document.

For full details of any title, and to view sample extracts please visit: www.thorogood.ws

You can place an order in four ways:

1 **Email**: orders@thorogood.ws
2 **Telephone**: +44 (0)20 7749 4748
3 **Fax**: +44 (0)20 7729 6110
4 **Post**: Thorogood, 10-12 Rivington Street, London EC2A 3DU, UK

Implementing an integrated marketing communications strategy

NORMAN HART **£99.00**

1 85418 120 3 • 1999

Just what is meant by marketing communications, or 'marcom'? How does it fit in with other corporate functions, and in particular how does it relate to business and marketing objectives?

Strategic customer planning

ALAN MELKMAN AND
PROFESSOR KEN SIMMONDS **£95.00**

1 85418 255 2 • 2001

This is very much a 'how to' Report. After reading those parts that are relevant to your business, you will be able to compile a plan that will work within your particular organisation for you, a powerful customer plan that you can implement immediately. Charts, checklists and diagrams throughout.

Selling skills for professionals

KIM TASSO **£65.00**

1 85418 179 3 • 2000

Many professionals still feel awkward about really selling their professional services. They are not usually trained in selling. This is a much-needed report which addresses the unique concerns of professionals who wish to sell their services successfully and to feel comfortable doing so.

'Comprehensive, well written and very readable… this is a super book, go and buy it as it is well worth the money' *Professional Marketing International*

Corporate community investment

CHRIS GENASI **£75.00**

1 85418 192 0 • 1999

Supporting good causes is big business – and good business. Corporate community investment (CCI) is the general term for companies' support of good causes, and is a very fast growing area of PR and marketing.

Tendering and negotiating for MoD contracts

TIM BOYCE **£125.00**

1 85418 276 5 • 2002

This specially commissioned report aims to draw out the main principles, processes and procedures involved in tendering and negotiating MoD contracts.

Defending your reputation

SIMON TAYLOR **£95.00**

1 85418 251 • 2001

'Buildings can be rebuilt, IT systems replaced. People can be recruited, but a reputation lost can never be regained…'

'The media will publish a story – you may as well ensure it is your story' *Simon Taylor*

'News is whatever someone, somewhere, does not want published' *William Randoplh Hearst*

When a major crisis does suddenly break, how ready will you be to defend your reputation?

Insights into understanding the financial media – an insider's view

SIMON SCOTT **£99.00**

1 85418 083 5 • 1998

This practical briefing will help you understand the way the financial print and broadcast media works in the UK.

European lobbying guide

BRYAN CASSIDY **£129.00**

1 85418 144 0 • 2000

Understand how the EU works and how to get your message across effectively to the right people.

Lobbying and the media: working with politicians and journalists

MICHAEL BURRELL **£95.00**

1 85418 240 4 • 2001

Lobbying is an art form rather than a science, so there is inevitably an element of judgement in what line to take. This expert report explains the knowledge and techniques required.

Strategic planning in public relations

KIERAN KNIGHTS **£69.00**

1 85418 225 0 • 2001

Tips and techniques to aid you in a new approach to campaign planning.

Strategic planning is a fresh approach to PR. An approach that is *fact-based* and scientific, clearly presenting the arguments for a campaign proposal backed with *evidence*.

Managing corporate reputation – the new currency

SUSAN CROFT and JOHN DALTON **£125**

1 85418 272 2 • June 2003

ENRON, WORLDCOM... who next?

At a time when trust in corporations has plumbed new depths, knowing how to manage corporate reputation professionally and effectively has never been more crucial.

Surviving a corporate crisis – 100 things you need to know

PAUL BATCHELOR **£125**

1 85418 208 0 • April 2003

Seven out of ten organisations that experience a corporate crisis go out of business within 18 months.

This very timely report not only covers remedial action after the event but offers expert advice on preparing every department and every key player of the organisation so that, should a crisis occur, damage of every kind is limited as far as possible.

FINANCE

Tax aspects of buying and selling companies

MARTYN INGLES **£99.00**

1 85418 189 0 • 2001

This report takes you through the buying and selling process *from the tax angle*. It uses straightforward case studies to highlight the issues and more important strategies that are likely to have a significant impact on the taxation position.

Tax planning opportunities for family businesses in the new regime

CHRISTOPHER JONES **£49.00**

1 85418 154 8 • 2000

Following recent legislative and case law changes, the whole area of tax planning for family businesses requires very careful and thorough attention in order to avoid the many pitfalls.

Practical techniques for effective project investment appraisal

RALPH TIFFIN **£99.00**

1 85418 099 1 • 1999

How to ensure you have a reliable system in place.

Spending money on projects automatically necessitates an effective appraisal system – a way of deciding whether the correct decisions on investment have been made.

Strategy implementation through project management

TONY GRUNDY **£95.00**

1 85418 250 1 • 2001

The gap

Far too few managers know how to apply project management techniques to their strategic planning. The result is often strategy that is poorly thought out and executed.

The answer

Strategic project management is a new and powerful process designed to manage complex projects by combining traditional business analysis with project management techniques.

For full details of any title, and to view sample extracts please visit: www.thorogood.ws

You can place an order in four ways:

1 **Email**: orders@thorogood.ws
2 **Telephone**: +44 (0)20 7749 4748
3 **Fax**: +44 (0)20 7729 6110
4 **Post**: Thorogood, 10-12 Rivington Street, London EC2A 3DU, UK